

The gold she's after
isn't his wedding ring...



An Inconvenient WIFE

Award
Winning Author

Katy
Madison

AN INCONVENIENT WIFE

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Smashwords Edition

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Prologue

“Niet, niet, niet.”

Brandi Yeats tried to visualize the moves she needed to make across the ice. The sound of the Russian skater protesting to his partner drowned out her efforts. Her own partner, Kevin, was in the men’s dressing room or she would have concentrated on calming him to reduce the strain on her own nerves.

She jumped up and down. Her blade guards clicked as she landed. The peacock blue skirt of her dress floated up and down. The gathered folds fanned out with iridescent shimmers, softening her jerky hops. Feeling edgy in the small crowded staging area under the seats of the Bucharest arena, she paced across the short loop carpeting,

Skaters milled around her, some doing run-throughs. Some laced on skates. Others sat on the scattered wood benches trying to block out the noise, color and confusion. An increased intensity hung in the air, nervous edges to multilingual voices, the smell of fear. Too many people used to wide open rinks were crammed into too tiny a place. They spilled into the hallway, pacing and praying, laughing in tight laughs. Only one sounded angry.

“Niet! Niet!”

Brandi frowned across the backstage area. He sounded like a cat huffing up a fur ball. She didn’t know why his voice jumped out from the murmurs and hum of conversation. It just did.

He grated on her nerves. Not for the first time. Their coach Gina had made Brandi and Kevin watch all the other couple’s practices. She’d kept her mouth shut while Gina pointed out the speed and deep edges of the couple. She wasn’t preventing them from skating faster. Every time she pushed for more speed, Kevin ended up sniffing the ice.

Besides, Brandi’s gaze kept straying to him, the tall, dark-haired, blue-eyed man, when she should be watching the woman’s difficult steps. She knew the way he would shove back his sleeves exposing sinewy forearms as he listened to his coach. She knew the way he would blow air out of his mouth and cross his arms across his chest when frustrated with a small mistake. That was while he stood still.

When he skated, her breath caught. Her eyes were drawn to his long lean form, his trim athletic body, his narrow hips, wide shoulders, the

smooth and fluid way he moved all those body parts in the dance. Her own body responded to the sway and lean of his. She tilted in response to his tempo, although he was yards away from her. Oh yeah, she knew how he moved. She knew his name, Nikolai Petronof. She knew a lot about the way he looked, this Russian skater. He had a mouth made for kisses, a deep voice that would be better used for gentle words of love—in English.

Not a chance. With his long-limbed, contortionist partner Tatiana, he was on the way to world gold. The couple was obviously ten times better than she and Kevin. Brandi and Kevin hoped to make the top ten in nationals in the next few years. She wasn't likely to run into Nikolai on a regular basis.

Kevin emerged from the bathroom looking wan and pale under his makeup. Relieved to have something to do Brandi crossed over to him. She dodged a pair of skaters in gold spangled costumes practicing a lift sequence. "Are you ready?" she asked.

"No." He bent over, resting his palms against his black clad legs.

Checking all the hidden snaps and buttons of his costume, Brandi walked around Kevin.

The Russian skater paced furiously back and forth beside the bench where his partner sat. By some quirk of fate, they had ended up in the same group of six for their long dance. Brandi expected the Russians to skate in the last group composed of the top six competitors, but they were down in the dregs with them.

Brandi moved behind Kevin just as the angry man crossed. Their shoulders collided—or actually her shoulder collided with his upper arm. He stopped and stared at her. His gaze seared through her, not with anger as she expected, but more with surprise and a hint of something else edging the blue.

She froze with her hand halfway down Kevin's pants making sure the button that held his shirttail tucked in was fastened. *Great.* She flushed and attempted a discreet withdraw. She didn't think the Russian noticed. He seemed caught in some personal hell with his partner and coach. He put his hand on her shoulder and spoke in a garble of Russian.

Heat streaked down from his casual touch. She lowered her eyes quickly. "My fault," muttered Brandi.

"Okay," he answered with a thick accent.

Her heart did an unexpected flip at his reply in English.

One word, for heaven's sake. *Get a grip*. He hadn't smiled or anything. Really, he'd be good looking if he just smiled, but for the past half hour he had been in a snit. Come to think of it, she hadn't seen many smiles during his practices either.

He stalked off. Brandi glanced at his partner. Tatiana sat on the bench, her shoulders trembling. Her knees on her long, long legs shook too, knocking together under the ruffled edge of her deep red dress.

"Look, Kevin, I think she's more nervous than you," whispered Brandi.

"They fell in the short dance," said their coach, approaching from the hallway leading rink side, where she watched the ice dancers. "They should have walked away with this competition in their pocket. They have to win tonight to stand a chance of placing." Gina ushered them through the tunnel toward the ice.

"Brandi Yeats and Kevin Morrison," vibrated over the cloudy intercom system, and there wasn't time to worry about the other skaters.

As Brandi took Kevin's hand to skate to center rink, she knew they were in trouble. Cold air swirled up from the ice, but his hand was slippery with nervous sweat. During their first lift she slid out of his hold. She grabbed his leg to keep from plummeting face first into the unforgiving white ice. The spectators oohed, but the judges would know the move was a mistake. But, other than their awkward recovery from the slip, they skated a fairly clean program.

As they took their bows and headed for Kiss and Cry, Brandi noticed another skater moving away from the boards. The black tuxedo-style shirt he wore had small ruffles edged in red. The Russian. Brandi frowned. Had he watched them skate? Observing other couples from the boards was unusual. Usually competitors viewed the skating on the backstage monitors if at all.

After the low scores were read, they left the vinyl-covered, curved couch, to enter the short hall leading to the backstage area.

Brandi reached up and brushed her hand over her light brown hair, pulling the bun twisted in it loose. Awareness grew in her. Heat snaked down her spine. She turned and encountered the eyes of Nikolai Petronof.

He leaned against the wall of the hallway. Uncomfortable with his scrutiny, she turned away, looking around the staging area, before she reentered the crowded room.

Skaters milled around in nervous preparation, but she was done. She would relax as soon as he quit looking at her.

His partner, Tatiana, moaned, while their coach mopped her face. He reentered her view and walked toward his partner. He rubbed his shoulder. He said some harsh words in Russian to Tatiana.

She raised her tear-streaked face and leaned forward, her neck out like an angry chicken. A volatile spate of words escaped her lips.

Nikolai repeated the words he kept saying, “*Niet, niet, niet.*”

Brandi couldn't take it anymore. She crossed to where the Russian skater stood with his arms folded across his chest, his face flushed. Tatiana sputtered and issued words in a volatile mix that sounded like a combination of whines and accusations, not that Brandi could tell. She didn't know enough Russian words to fill a thimble. She did know that *niet* was no. And he kept saying it. Repeatedly. Angrily.

“Yes, yes, yes, think positive,” she said.

The man's blue eyes jerked to hers. Brandi wished she had kept her mouth shut. Even the prima donna stared at her, before breaking out in a new rash of words. The man cast a half-hearted glance at his partner, nodded his head at Brandi and said, “Thank-you.”

“You're welcome,” Brandi answered, trying to slide by into the ladies' dressing room, but a new influx of skaters into the staging area held her back.

The muted burst of applause signaled the end of the program of the couple on the ice.

The Russian held out his hand to his partner. He watched Brandi though, as he headed for the ice. She retreated into the hallway, allowing them to pass. She heard only his name on the loudspeaker, Nikolai Petronof, as he smiled back at her, before turning his engaging smile to his partner as if all the *niet, niet, niets* were a figment of Brandi's imagination.

Chapter One

Brandi stroked around the ice. She wasn't surprised to find herself alone, especially after what Kevin had said on the flight in from California yesterday evening.

Brandi relished the silence. Solitary ice time was likely to be rare during this ice dancing seminar in Lake Placid, and she had a lot to think about. Kevin's announcement that he planned to attend Purdue this fall hadn't come as a huge shock. He should go to college, and on one level she was truly happy for him.

At the same time she wondered what his decision would do to their partnership. Even if their coach thought she was over-the-hill compared to their coach Gina's new child prodigies, or even compared to Kevin, Brandi wasn't ready to quit. She wanted a championship. She needed a medal. She believed she could win them, but she knew she needed to temper her natural optimism with a dose of reality.

Without a top trophy, her future was looking more like dirty slush than shiny and bright, freshly-surfaced ice. She could try out for a position in one of the ice shows. She'd probably end up as Dopey wearing a huge paper mache head as she skated. Without a world title she would never be a headliner. Without a partner she was about as effective as a boot without a blade.

She built up speed and cruised around the edge of the rink. Her life revolved around skating. Every dime she had went into ice time, skates, coaching fees, travel, and costumes. Ice dancing was her life. Although her skating career seemed to be mimicking her circles around the ice. She kept ending up back where she started.

She had time for one more partner switch in her career. Once before a relationship gone bad forced a switch, and the transition set her back competitively. Kevin was so much younger and inexperienced, and developing competition-level chemistry took years. Years she didn't have anymore.

Leaving the partnership was practically unthinkable, but she had his blessing. She just came up blank when she tried to think of any male ice dancers who might consider teaming up with her.

Another skater entered the ice. She didn't pay attention, assuming Kevin had joined her, but the full black was unusual for him. She and Kevin

frequently wore matching practice outfits, and they both favored bright jewel tones.

Her companion on the ice had dark hair not Kevin's dishwater blond hair. Definitely, not her partner. She took a second look, and her breath caught. It was the harsh Russian, whom she had last seen over a year ago in Bucharest. What was he doing here? Where was his partner? Where was Kevin? Both of them were warming up alone, together? This was too weird.

She skidded to a halt at the entrance to the ice, picked up her guards and placed them on her skates. If Gina hadn't shown up already, she would soon.

Brandi left the ice rink. Her coach hurried across the nearly empty entranceway, weaving around the low, carpeted, square benches. The two munchkins trailed in after her, skate bags slung over their shoulders. Lately the preteen pair took all of Gina's energy.

Kevin was nowhere to be seen. Brandi had walked over from the hotel a few blocks away early, and a maintenance man let her into the darkened rink. She laced on her skates and did warm-up exercises, while the Zamboni drove around the ice.

"Where's Kevin?" asked Brandi.

"He'll be along later," said Gina dismissively.

Gina introduced a nearby woman as Mikelina Karinna, a coach training several Russian skaters in America.

"Are you ready?" asked the other coach. Brandi was already having trouble remembering which one of her names came first.

"For what?" asked Brandi, looking back and forth between the two women.

"You tryout for to skate with Nikolai," said the foreign woman.

"Nikolai Petronof?" asked Brandi. "Gina, what is going on?"

"I put on a waltz first, *da*?" said the Russian coach.

Gina nodded. "Go on, Brandi. He's a great skater. You do well, you could go far with him." She turned around and began instructing her young skaters in their warm-up exercises.

Brandi headed back to the ice, knowing she would have to wait for an explanation. Gina was fanatical about wasting ice time. No discussions, just skate, skate, skate. "All right don't tell me anything. Don't ask if I want to skate with a man who yells at his partner right before a performance,"

muttered Brandi under her breath, as she stepped back onto the ice and sprawled flat on her face. She had forgotten to take off her blade guards.

Lovely. That graceful move ought to impress them.

She bit back a nervous giggle, turned over and sat, removing the plastic runners from the blades of her skates, while the opening bars of the standard music for one of the dances played.

She needed a new partner, or she would have to follow Kevin to Indiana and try to fit skating around his schedule. Kevin told her he was holding her back. He wasn't cut out for competition. He'd also said their coach knew of someone interested in partnering her. She had never in her wildest dreams imagined it could be the Russian.

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Nikolai skated up beside her and took her blade guards. He set them on the boards and lifted her to her feet. "Okay?" he asked, cursing his limited English.

Brandi nodded, but she didn't meet his eyes. They were late starting to the music. He listened for an alternative starting point. He didn't know how to ask her if she wanted to start straight into the prescribed pattern or take the seven allowable free steps before the standardized dance. He held out seven fingers, and she nodded again. He limited himself to forward strokes to gather speed and get used to her style. She flowed with him across the ice. He didn't have any other way to describe it.

Oh, she was a little wooden, and he wasn't attempting to skate at full speed or as close as he would have with Tatiana, but Brandi felt natural in his arms. A good fit. Except she was so much shorter, she would need to tilt her head back to look him in the eye, and she seemed more inclined to stare at his chin. He also had some trouble with the correct placement of his hands with each position change. She was so much shorter than flagpole Tatiana. Brandi scowled each time he had to slide his hand down from her shoulder or from her ribs to her hip.

Nikolai searched for the words to explain his problem. He finally settled for a gesture. "Tatiana," he put his hand five or six inches above Brandi's head. "Large. You small." He touched her light brown hair surprised at the silky softness his fingers encountered. Or perhaps not surprised. He'd found it difficult to stop thinking about her since he'd watched her in Bucharest. It wasn't just about ice dancing with her,

although that had been his original motivation for having his coach approach hers.

“Why are you looking for a new partner?”

She started muttering before he completely translated her words in his head, composed a reply in Russian and then translated it back into his broken English. Her words came out so fast; he couldn’t begin to follow them. As soon as he started translating, a new torrent would follow, and he would forget what he heard of the first sentence. He shook his head and put his fingers across her lips.

Her eyes jerked to his for the first time. Such a warm liquid brown and so distrustful. A surge of attraction pulled through him. Although she looked at him like he was a stinky fish.

“Tatiana fall too much,” he finally managed to spit out. “My English bad.” He reluctantly moved his fingers away from her petal soft lips. She drew in a breath, and Nikolai let his eyes linger where his fingers had been.

“Better than my Russian.” Brandi looked at his chin, her brown eyes clouded and wary.

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In their third repeat of the pattern, Brandi couldn’t hold her tongue anymore. “You don’t have to hold back. I can go faster.

He missed a step. She didn’t. Their feet tangled, and he went down. She fell on top of him. Her knee jammed into the ice between his legs. Pain shot through her in radiant spikes. As they slid, he put his arms around her, holding her on top of him until they stopped.

The pain turned to tingling and the tingling spread to all the wrong places. That was a problem.

Brandi moved off of him as quickly as she could.

In spite of her negative first impression of him, she was incredibly attracted to him. And a romance between an ice dancing pair could be a disaster, especially one based on physical attraction. Oh, it happened, but given that she didn’t really like him much, it would be a major problem. The strain of working together, practicing and competing would destroy all but the firmest of relationships.

“Who falls too much?” She stood. Her knee protested vigorously.

Nikolai muttered some words in Russian, sat up, and reached for her leg. She didn’t want him to touch her and pulled her injured knee out of his

reach. Brandi knew it would be a bad bruise and probably wasn't anything worse. She put her weight on her other leg, trying to ignore the throbbing.

At least the heavy pain kept her from thinking about the way his solid chest felt under her breasts. The way his arms around her made her feel secure and protected, the one being watched out for instead of the responsible, solicitous partner. The way being vertical in his embrace felt as natural as the dance steps had felt before they fell.

The next thing she knew, he scooped her into his arms and was skating toward the entrance.

"I'm all right. Put me down."

"*Niet.*"

"Oh, here we go with the *niets*. I'm okay. You understand okay, right?"

"*Niet.*"

Brandi moved her injured knee, kicking her leg up and down. "See works fine. I'm okay. Set me down. I'll skate it off."

Gina and the Russian coach met them at the boards. Brandi limped back onto the ice as soon as he put her down, telling Gina she was fine. After a couple of quick circuits of the ice, she actually felt fine. The pain was an ignorable buzz. She even did a long spiral on that leg to show her knee was intact.

Things would work out. One door shuts and another opens. She just had to figure out which door was open and dart through it before it slammed on her fingers. He skated on a much higher level of competition than she had, and this could be a golden opportunity, even if he was a jerk.

He skated up beside her and lifted her from the ice with one hand under her free leg and the other across her waist.

"Okay, fine," he said, setting her back down to the ice after a quick spin in a lift position.

Brandi grimaced. Nikolai scowled. His coach snapped something at him in staccato Russian, and his expression turned pleasant. She lost her breath.

He moved her into a Killian position to start another of the compulsory dances. Side-by-side with his hand on her hip and her hand over his they moved in time to the music.

This time his coach accompanied them barking instructions alternately in Russian and English. Brandi hardly realized how fast they were skating until her ponytail slipped. Nikolai snagged the rubber band before it fell all

the way out, and the breeze caught her flyaway hair, tossing it in her face on turns. With each circle around the rink, their steps became more synchronized and more powerful, their edges deeper. He pulled her closer, their hips brushing. He brought her arm up around his neck, putting his now unoccupied hand on her other hip.

She was now almost in front of him, when the coach told her to pivot. Nikolai pushed her hips forward. She turned, lost speed and was caught back close to his body. Half wondering if her body betrayed her into deliberately seeking contact with him, she fought to pull away from him. But it was like he was a vacuum hose sucking her against him.

“More space, more space, *niet*,” instructed the Russian coach.

No kidding. How to make more space between them was the trick. Part of the problem was that their skates were so close that one wrong step would send them tumbling, and she wasn’t used to him. She wasn’t used to throwing in nonstandard moves in the middle of the set patterns all ice dancers skated to in the compulsory part of the short dance.

Right now, she had no idea how to get back into the pattern.

Nikolai squeezed with his left hand on her waist and then stroked with that foot first. On the second squeeze she moved with him, picked up the speed again and the normal steps to the dance.

All right, they were pretty good together—or at least she felt like she was doing much better than she ever could with Kevin.

“Again?” she asked.

“Okay,” said Nikolai. He turned his hips sideways. His skates kicked up a small spray of ice, stopping them both. He placed his hands on her shoulders, turning her around. He gathered her hair back into a ponytail and threaded her hair tie back in. His fingers raking against her scalp sent little shooting sensations down her spine. He looped the ponytail through the band, before moving her back into their original position. “Stay now.”

“Thank you,” she said self-consciously.

She did better the second time. Although Nikolai’s coach gave her a dissatisfied look and made some comment in Russian.

“It’s not nice to talk about people when they can’t understand,” said Brandi.

Nikolai answered in Russian.

“He say, look in his eyes,” His coach translated. “Dance should look romantic.”

Brandi cast a mutinous look around. She had no problem with the concept. She was just afraid when she and Nikolai were trapped into exchanging longing looks, he would know hers weren't faked.

She steeled herself and tilted her head back letting her eyes drink from his deep blue ones. Oh boy, was she in trouble.

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Nikolai concentrated hard on his steps until he was used to the exchange. His coach complimented him on his expression reminding him they were ice dancing and acting to eventually please crowds and judges. Passion in ice dancing was highly regarded and rewarded. He wanted to point out that it was a lot easier to admire Brandi's face, than Tatiana's. Whatever desire was in his face wasn't exactly faked. He admired Brandi. He liked her. Hell, he just plain wanted her.

Her warm coffee-colored eyes locked with his, but there was distrust in them. Whatever he felt, she wasn't ready for. And all things being equal he really wanted to skate with her.

She might not be on his level yet, but she learned quickly and wanted to try new moves again and again, until she had them down. And she skated fast with him. American dance couples often had trouble with velocity, but she matched his powerful strokes easily. Even Tatiana grew tired after a few revolutions around the ice at top speed.

Nikolai didn't know how long they had been at it, but several other couples were on the ice now. His other coach/choreographer Yuri arrived, and in Russian his two coaches speculated about Brandi's flexibility.

"Can put foot on shoulder?" he asked.

She glanced behind. He knew they had enough clear ice for the movement if she wanted to try it, but they were traveling fast. If she lost her footing they would be in trouble, but he had seen video where she placed her boot on Kevin's shoulder.

"You better lift my foot. I don't want to slice you with my blade."

She lifted her leg up to his waist and motioned for him to take her boot. She leaned towards him. She flexed her foot on the ice. He noted how she kept her weight over the blade and avoided catching her toe pick. He raised her foot slowly, unwilling to risk overextending her leg. She was in full splits by the time her foot was level with his shoulder, but he hadn't felt resistance. The correctness of her posture pleased him. Her back was

straight and true. Her foot on the ice remained consistent with their direction.

He realized belatedly they didn't have much time. They needed to turn or they would hit the boards. He started to lean when he caught the wince on her face. Her gaze was on her hurt knee.

Nikolai dropped his arm to the back of her leg, bending her knee over his arm. He lifted her off the ice in the same motion, turning both his feet sideways, sliding to a stop before they crashed into the red-topped, white boards. He set her back down on the ice, and she untangled her leg from his arm.

"Sorry, my knee's a little sore." She backed away from him, her head down.

He smiled. She was less flexible than Tatiana, but who wasn't? All Tatiana wanted to do was make moves that showcased her contortions. Nikolai would prefer more dancing, less showing off one partner's elastic body. "Stop?"

Brandi shook her head and smiled for the first time since they'd started skating together on the ice.

"You skate with me?" he asked.

She stopped smiling. "You mean I pass the audition?"

He frowned. Audition? Where had she gotten the idea that he was auditioning her? Maybe he misunderstood the word. They had been skating together over an hour now, working on complicated moves, not just running through the compulsory dance patterns all ice dancers at their level knew. He'd thought that indicated their intentions.

"It's a big decision. I don't know. I'd like to take some time to think about it. And what about Tatiana? How will we communicate when you barely speak English, and I don't speak Russian? What about our nationalities? We couldn't ever compete at the Olympics." She blushed.

"I wish skate with you," he said slowly, frustrated with his English. "I find..." He touched his mouth and made a couple of loops with his hand and then touched her ear. "Talk."

"Interpreter?"

He thought a second, decided the word was right and nodded.

"Where would we skate? What about money? There are a lot of problems. We hardly know each other."

"Say one time."

“What?”

“Say one time. One *thing*, one time.” His struggled to find the right word. One concept at a time wouldn’t hurt, either. She jumped around so much in her objections he couldn’t think about all the different ways he needed to respond at once.

“Say one thing at a time?”

“*Da.*”

“Yes.”

“Yes,” he repeated. “Skate now. Help talk later. Interp—” he made a hash of the word.

“Interpreter. Well, I suppose that’s one way to shut me up. If you can’t understand what I say then all we can do is skate. I—”

He clapped a hand over her mouth. She shook away from him, the river of her words dammed, temporarily at least. His two coaches closed in on them, and he paused waiting for instruction. He was glad when they descended on Brandi. If they considered her skating too far beneath his, they wouldn’t have bothered. They would have told him to stop pursuing Brandi as a partner and insist on looking for a new partner among Russian skaters.

Last year, when he started talking about skating with Brandi, they hadn’t been pleased. Tatiana had more talent than anyone ice dancing—during practice when it didn’t truly matter. Nikolai felt he had to prove himself. When he threatened to quit a few months after the fiasco in Bucharest, they finally acknowledged Tatiana took most of their energy. One of the reasons for training in America was access to sport psychiatrists for Tatiana. But she resisted the help, insisting that her problem was Nikolai. For too many years his coaches sided with her, ignoring the video and outside commentary that showed otherwise. Lately, his coaches had lost faith in Tatiana.

He’d told her six months ago he was looking for a new partner. Because she hadn’t seen any real effort on his part to court another partner, he supposed she hadn’t believed him. But he’d never received a solid answer back from the inquiries he’d made to Brandi’s coach until now.

He noticed Brandi was uncomfortable with the physical way his coaches trained. Mikelina would pull her shoulders back, and Brandi flinched. Her muttered, “Just tell me,” was barely audible to him.

Across the ice the American coach worked with her other pair. Brandi was obviously the better skater of her previous pairing. No doubt her partner received the bulk of instructions during skating sessions. Brandi probably wasn't used to the attention focused on her and not by two coaches.

"Don't scare her off. She hasn't agreed to skate with me," he said to Mikelina in Russian.

His coach seemed surprised. "Why would she refuse?" she fired back.

"I don't know. We'll talk later." He switched to English. "*Da?* We talk later?"

Brandi nodded. "Can we just run through some more of the compulsory dances? I'd like to get comfortable, before we work too much on new stuff." She shrugged.

Nikolai looked to his coach to finish the translation. His coach named the complicated Golden Waltz as the dance to practice.

Brandi broke away from him and said, "Hang on a minute." Then she skated to the boards where her partner stood.

Nikolai watched. He was lost in the translation of what she said. He heard the words, but he had no idea what she wanted him to hang on to. He cast a puzzled look to his coaches.

Mikelina said, "She skate with you."

"With your approval?"

His coach shrugged. "She has potential."

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Brandi returned with an MP3 player. She clipped it to the waist of her skirt. With luck it wouldn't break free and hit Nikolai. Usually, since Kevin had pockets, he wore the player if they were skating without their music on the rink sound system. Since that happened more and more with Gina concentrating on her younger couple and their programs, Brandi was prepared. She punched up the waltz music.

Brandi replayed the fifteen-minute stretch twice, and her legs grew rubbery. Her stomach started to protest too. Gina hadn't said more than two words to her, and Kevin watched contentedly from the side. She turned off the player.

"I'm starving. Do you know what time it is?"

"Time for fit," said Nikolai.

Great, she couldn't understand him even when he spoke English. Although he seemed a little more tolerant of the way she talked nervously as she skated. He'd stopped answering unless she looked at him expectantly. Then he usually asked her to repeat what she said. She wanted to tell him she wasn't always a motor mouth, but she normally coached Kevin on moves as they skated. She didn't know what to say to Nikolai who obviously was so much better than her. And she was nervous. The thought that she would be crazy to turn him down kept spinning in her mind.

"Stop?" he asked.

Brandi frowned. Hadn't she said that? No, she hadn't. "Yes. Stop. I need to eat."

"Eat and talk. How knee?" He didn't look at her though. He kept looking over her shoulder.

"It's fine. Maybe we should talk later."

"I think better leave now." Circling around her, he caught her hand and skated across the rink to the entrance.

Brandi had no choice but to skate with him, or be dragged. He blocked her view as they approached the edge of the ice. In fact, with the protest of her bruised knee, she was skating too fast to stop, and she ended up with her face against Nikolai's back, hanging onto his waist to avoid falling. As she started to back away a crack of flesh against flesh rent the air. Nikolai's head jerked sideways.

Reversing roles quickly, Brandi held him steady. Not that the slap unbalanced him. Tension leaped through the muscles under her fingers. His hands jerked up and apart. Brandi watched the movement of his shoulders, aware of a heat spreading through her already overheated body. Nikolai looked as good from the back as from the front. A good trait in a skater, her mind registered absently, but she wasn't really thinking about how he looked skating.

Russian words flew back and forth in a furious volley. Brandi peeked around Nikolai's arm to see a tearful Tatiana alternating between sobbing and trying to attack Nikolai. She aimed her black red talons at her rival when she saw Brandi peering around him.

Hadn't he told his partner that he was considering switching? She watched as Nikolai held Tatiana by the wrists and said icy words to his partner. Tatiana fell to her knees, and Nikolai tossed her arms away as he

interspersed *niets* in what he said. He reached back and wrapped an arm around Brandi's waist, pulling her alongside him. She saw the suppressed fury in his expression and the red handprint on his face. She shivered.

Was this an example of how he worked with his partner? Was Nikolai so callous he hadn't warned Tatiana? Had she shown up ready to skate to find her partner circling the rink with another woman? Mortified to be caught in part of this scene, Brandi pushed out of Nikolai's hold and reached for her blade guards on the boards. Her eyes sought Kevin's, and he appeared in front of her. She reached out, and he pulled her into a hug with the silent empathy they had developed in their five years as partners.

"God, Kevin, I can't believe this. Didn't he tell his partner he was thinking about finding someone different to skate with?"

"Don't know," answered Kevin.

"He treats her horribly."

Kevin made a sympathetic noise.

"I won't skate with someone who can't treat his partner with respect."

"She did slap him, Brandi," said Kevin.

"But you saw the way he treated her before competing in Bucharest. He yelled at her. What if I fall? What if he decides I'm not good enough? Will he start yelling at me? We can barely understand each other—well, he can understand part of what I say. I just don't see how we can make it work. His coaches keep manhandling me. He keeps picking me up. I don't like it. It makes me uncomfortable."

"You guys look good on the ice," said Kevin slowly.

"You didn't see our fall earlier. I rammed my right knee into the ice."

Kevin bent down and pressed his fingers against her kneecap.

Brandi leaned on his shoulder. "It's all right, just bruised."

"You ought to go back to the hotel room and ice it. It's swelling a little," said Kevin. "But maybe you're right. He's giving me dirty looks right now."

Brandi turned to see Nikolai spin around and stalk off across the open area. She patted Kevin's shoulder. "He is a good skater." He was a great skater.

"It won't be worth it, if he is abusive. I'd forgotten about him yelling at his partner in Bucharest. There's a lot of anger there. Come on, you can just come to Indiana with me in the fall. I'll work it out. I'll tell my parents I

still want to compete.” Kevin rose up from his knees. His face was grim. “I don’t want you hurt.”

“You already told them you weren’t competing next season?”

Kevin shrugged. “When I heard who wanted to skate with you, I called them, but, Brandi, you can’t pair up with a guy who is ballistic. It’s too risky.”

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Chapter Two

Nikolai watched Brandi's partner probe around the bruised knee she wouldn't let him touch. Actually, she had been uncomfortable any time he touched her. He examined his jealousy. She hadn't even agreed to skate with him. That she turned to her partner for comfort shouldn't upset him. Just because he wouldn't mind the line between their professional and personal relationship to blur didn't mean he had to have it that way.

He needed a new skating partner. There weren't any solo ice dancers. Now that he had told Tatiana he would never skate with her again, new partner or not, he needed and wanted Brandi as a partner. Any romantic urges had to take a back seat to his career. He found the snack area and located the ice machine. No one staffed the bar so he levered himself up and slid across the counter.

If he had a chance of skating with Brandi, he couldn't blow that by scaring her off. She might like her men green behind the ears, like her young partner. She might like to be the one in charge. She might want an American. He had no idea if she was involved with anyone. His attraction to her hadn't worried him enough to investigate that aspect of her life. He liked her skating. He liked her style and excellent form. First and foremost he wanted to skate with her.

He scooped up a paper cup of crushed ice. To sell her on skating, he needed to communicate with her well enough to convince her they were a match meant to be. That meant he needed his friend who was fluent in English. He grabbed a couple of napkins before scooting across the counter again.

Brandi had donned her warm-up pants and tied her trainers on her feet by the time Nikolai returned with his friend by his side. Her partner Kevin hovered protectively over her with his arms folded across his chest. Nikolai deferred to his friend.

"I am Alexei. Nikolai ask me to translate for him. He would like you to go to lunch with us to discuss skating together."

"I haven't had breakfast yet," said Brandi.

Nikolai bent down and handed her the cup of ice. He also gave her a plastic bag from his skate bag. He'd had apple slices in it. He hoped it wasn't too sticky. "For knee."

Her brown eyes met his, faintly surprised. He forced himself to back away after she took the cup. Kevin's closed expression relaxed, and he

dropped his arms to his side.

“There is restaurant serves both, yes?” asked Alexei.

“You could talk to him, Brandi,” said Kevin. “What could happen in a restaurant?”

“I’m not ready to make a major decision like this. I need some time to think,” she said with her head down.

Alexei quietly translated, earning a frown from Brandi. She cast a speaking glance to her partner Kevin.

“Have not think for six months?” asked Nikolai, after he heard the translation.

“What’s he talking about? I just found out this morning,” said Brandi.

Nikolai interrupted Alexei’s translation. Mikelina had solicited an answer from her coach six months ago. He couldn’t find the right words in English and slipped back into the mother tongue. “I don’t have a partner, now. I need an answer soon. I want to compete this next season. I must start training with new partner right away. I asked her a long time ago, surely she’s thought about it.”

Alexei began translating.

“She didn’t know. Gina didn’t tell us he was looking at her as a potential partner,” said Kevin, interrupting the translation. “She only told me yesterday that there was someone interested in Brandi. She didn’t tell Brandi anything at all.”

“What about Tatiana?” asked Brandi, looking directly at Nikolai.

Too many threads of conversations were going on around him. Alexei hadn’t finished translating his last words as best Nikolai could tell, let alone what Kevin had said.

“I never skate Tatiana again.”

“I never skate *with* Tatiana again,” corrected Alexei.

“I never strike her.” Nikolai lost the English to finish saying she shouldn’t have slapped him. Folding his arms across his chest, he finished in Russian. Couldn’t she see that Tatiana was totally out of control? A professional relationship with her was impossible.

“You yell at her,” fired Brandi, not waiting for the rest of what he said to be translated.

Alexei told him in Russian to be quiet before he started yelling at Brandi.

“I not yell for much years,” Nikolai said, ignoring Alexei’s advice. He turned to his friend. He switched to Russian. “Tell her, I’ll respect other person, who respects me. I was tired of Tatiana screaming and blaming me. In Bucharest, I yelled at her. I pulled a muscle in my shoulder trying to keep her from falling. I don’t like the kind of relationship I have with Tatiana. I would prefer to be more professional. I want to skate with someone who will work together with me, unlike Tatiana. Tell her, if we skate together, I won’t yell at her, unless she yells at me first.”

He turned his back and walked a few feet away, so Alexei would have enough time to finish the translation before he and Brandi started firing quips back and forth at each other. He didn’t know if he could hold to the promise he had just made. The accusation and distrust in her eyes made him want to yell, but he knew that was exactly what he shouldn’t do. He needed to think about skating with her. He was surprised to find Kevin behind him when he turned around to see how Brandi reacted to Alexei’s translation.

“She’s just freaked out,” said Kevin.

Nikolai frowned, puzzled about what she had to do with freaks. English could be tricky. “Sorry, I not understand.”

“She’s scared.”

“Why?” asked Nikolai. He stared at the younger man. Was he encouraging a change in partners for Brandi? If Nikolai were Brandi’s partner, he would have fought to keep her.

“She wonders if you mistreat your partners.”

Nikolai held up his hand as Kevin started to say more. “I treat Brandi well.”

“But not Tatiana?” said Kevin with a smile.

Not lately, but he hadn’t started this way. And he doubted that another man in his situation would have lasted as long as he did. He shook his head. He didn’t know how to defend himself. “You want lose her?” he asked.

Kevin shrugged. “I’m going to college. I don’t like competing. She’s better than I am.”

Nikolai shook his head. He was lost.

Kevin watched him, then turned and called out to Alexei, who, after a quick word to Brandi, trotted over. Kevin repeated what he said to Alexei, and asked if Nikolai had told Tatiana that he was looking for a new partner before today.

Nikolai explained he'd told her before he made any inquiries about Brandi. Tatiana hadn't believed him.

While the three of them stood discussing things, a few feet away Brandi cleaned her blades and put her skates in her bag. His stomach churned as he waited for her to look in his direction.

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Brandi joined them, her heavy skate bag slung over her shoulder.

She mulled over what Alexei said. He said Nikolai had been inhumanly patient with Tatiana, and it wasn't fair to judge Nikolai's behavior by the last year. Brandi knew she should just make up her mind to skate with Nikolai. His skating was too good to be that concerned about anything else. She could lay ground rules and expect him to honor them. If he didn't, she could quit. Only that wasn't much of an option. A chance like this might come along once in life, and really it couldn't have come at a better time. Kevin wanted to leave competition, so she didn't need to feel any guilt about moving on.

Major changes. Big opportunities. She felt like a midget standing across from Nikolai. He still wore his skates, adding another four inches to his height. He was already five-ten or five-eleven to her five-foot-two.

"We're mismatched," she said.

Nikolai answered by stepping across, taking her hand and raising it above her head. He replied in Russian.

Alexei translated. "He says that means you don't have to duck to twirl under his arm. Makes the dance look better. He also says you're very easy for him to lift."

"I'll knock him in the head if he needs to duck under my arm, and he lifts me too much."

"He says he's used to picking up Tatiana. She falls she blames him. He says he'll stop, when he gets used to skating with you."

"He'll have to learn English."

"I work my English. I take class." He paused and looked at Brandi. "Help, you say one thing at time."

"Impossible," interjected Kevin. "She talks in monologues. Don't worry, Nick. You just have to nod occasionally."

Brandi shoved at Kevin.

Nikolai glared. "This how treat partner?"

Her heart beating too fast, Brandi stared at him. He couldn't think she treated Kevin badly—or was his point that she'd jumped to a conclusion based on one thing she'd seen?

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Belatedly, Nikolai smiled. He'd meant to do it sooner, but he had a hard time erasing his resentment of Brandi and Kevin's closeness. He knew Brandi's shove was entirely playful. He could recognize Kevin's words as teasing, although the translation was a little iffy in his head.

Kevin laughed. "See, you guys'll be great together. Come on, Brandi, you should at least give it a trial period. You won't know anything for sure until you see what happens. You can always quit if things are too rough."

Nikolai didn't want a trial period. He wanted a commitment of at least a season, but Americans were different about these things.

"I'm going back to the hotel to shower, and I'll meet you somewhere to eat," said Brandi, looking at Nikolai. "I can bring Kevin, can't I?"

Alexei nodded. "Is a half hour enough time?"

"There's that restaurant with green awnings down the street," said Kevin.

Brandi nodded.

Nikolai heaved a sigh of relief, as he watched her leave the rink with Kevin beside her. "What you think?" he asked Alexei.

"Do you care?" asked Alexei.

"*Niet*," answered Nikolai with a smile as he headed for a bench to remove his skates.

"Play with fire, you might get burned."

"Skate first, fire later," said Nikolai with a shrug. "I like her skate, too. I go nowhere with Tatiana." Talking in English to Alexei was easier. Since it was Alexei's second language too, he understood Nikolai needed the long pauses between bursts of words to compose and translate his thoughts into English. "She feel good on ice. You watch?"

"A little. She's not Russian."

"She better than today." He reverted back to Russian. "She's not always so stiff. Today I worry about footwork. She will loosen up as she learns to trust me. She's a tough competitor. I think she's a hard worker. Mikelina likes her."

"She's not Russian," repeated Alexei.

"I know," answered Nikolai, watching his friend, wondering why he was belaboring the point.

Alexei sighed. "Not a Russian fire. Your mama will be disappointed."

Nikolai smiled. "Not a Russian fire. American fires burn out, don't they? We skate, maybe more. When the performing part of my career ends, I go home and marry nice Moscow girl." He shrugged.

He was an athlete, and by definition the performance phase of an athletic career was short. Admittedly an ice dancer could last longer, but there wasn't a huge demand for them when and if they turned professional. At twenty-seven he had, at best, maybe ten years left in his performing career, probably a lot less. Then he would have to move into coaching if he wanted to continue skating.

"I really wish to skate with her too, maybe most. I need a new partner." Having an affair for a few years with Brandi would be a nice diversion. He found her enticing, but he sure as hell didn't want a permanent relationship with someone who didn't speak his native language. No, he was pretty clear about what he wanted, and it had more to do with the physical than the emotional. Hell, he hardly knew her. Why was Alexei concerned that his lusting after Brandi marked anything deeper than, well lust?

Besides, having an affair with his skating partner seemed like an easy, painless solution to finding a regular lover. A certain level of friendship and intimacy developed naturally anyway. He wouldn't have to go out looking in a foreign country, or worry about potential jealousy problems between his lover and his partner if they were one in the same woman. Also, they would be together no matter where they were competing. No long distance phone calls or long separations to work through. And he found Brandi damn attractive. He might be Russian, but he was a decent guy, all things considered. It seemed like an ideal solution, although he hadn't thought so when Tatiana decided they should become more involved.

"Then we work hard to convince her to skate with you. You ready to go?" answered Alexei.

Nikolai nodded. "Is Vera coming with us?" He realized he hadn't seen Alexei's partner this morning. He scanned the room. Tatianna huddled in a corner sobbing pathetically, but the other skaters present ignored her. Only his coaches talked to her, but even Mikelina appeared impatient.

Alexei grabbed his arm and pulled him back. "Tatianna wouldn't appreciate your company now. And Vera's sick."

He hadn't really thought he could do anything to help Tatianna, but he hadn't intended to end his partnership with her so publicly. He shook his head and turned his back. Relief filtered over him. "Better leave now then," said Nikolai. "What's wrong with Vera?"

Alexei pressed his lips together and shook his head. "I don't know. She said she would be ready to work this afternoon."

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Seated at the restaurant table, Nikolai wished he'd taken the time to change. He felt out of place in his turtleneck shirt, and hot. The bad thing about ice skating in the late spring. After living in America the better part of a year, he still felt foreign. May in Russia would have still been cool.

He should have made more effort to fit in, he thought when Brandi and Kevin came through the aisle, both of them in jeans shorts and matching California skate club tee shirts. They looked like partners, like they thought alike, dressed alike. Nikolai looked as different from Brandi as night from day. He reminded himself that he was the better skater. This was to her advantage. He pushed his sleeves back to his forearms.

She watched him as she scooted in beside him. Rather than sit beside him, Alexei sat opposite him in the booth, while they waited for the Americans. He saw the discoloration on her knee before she sat down. He shouldn't have, but he put his hand above her knee. He felt the instant tightening of her thigh under his palm, and an answer coiling deep in his gut.

"How knee?"

"It's just a bruise."

He turned to Alexei, who repeated what she said in Russian.

"I sorry," said Nikolai, giving her an awkward pat and putting his hand on the tabletop. Stupid move, he thought to himself. Especially since Kevin had warned him she was frightened of him. Skate first, anything else later.

That was why he found himself agreeing when Brandi said that their partnership would be purely a professional relationship. He'd waited for Alexei to translate before he answered, although he understood perfectly what he was agreeing to before he did it.

Alexei shot back a question in Russian. Nikolai shook his head. "If those are her terms I accept, but I don't want a trial period. I want a commitment to skate through the next season."

Alexei watched Nikolai before he turned to Brandi and said. "Nikolai wants your promise to skate with him all this next winter. He does not want a trial period."

Brandi nodded, surprising Nikolai. "If I skate with you, I would consider it a permanent change. You have to make the commitment too. I would be making major changes in my life, moving across the country."

"I move across ocean. I become US citizen." He looked at Alexei, "Tell her one of us to change citizenship. Does she want to become Russian instead?"

"How long does it take to become a citizen?" asked Kevin.

"I know a lawyer. Another skater friend of my partner Vera became citizen two years ago and used him. I think it took three years, maybe four. I will give Nikolai the name of the lawyer."

Brandi's head was spinning. She frowned. He had made bigger changes than she would make. Not all of which he'd made because of a desire to skate with her. But switching nationalities, that was a much bigger step than she was willing to make. She stared at Alexei as he finished relaying what else Nikolai said. Both of them seemed to take competing in the Olympics as a serious consideration. It had almost become an unobtainable ambition to Brandi. She shook her head. "If I compete internationally, I want to represent the United States. Let's do this."

"Can't hurt having a native Russian, as part of your team," said Kevin. "You sure, Brandi?"

"Talking about the Olympics is premature, isn't it?" said Brandi.

"*Niet*," answered Nikolai at the same time as Alexei said, "No."

No wonder there were always Russians on the podium.

The two Russians had a brief exchange and Alexei translated, "You'll have better chance of making the Olympic team as Americans."

Brandi frowned. "That's almost a reason to not skate with him," she said to Kevin.

"Brandi, we go Olympics...together. You, him," he pointed at Kevin, "no go."

Brandi cringed. Nikolai was a much better skater than Kevin, but she felt bound to protest. "You don't know that."

"Tatiana go Olympics never."

Brandi shook her head. "The next Olympics are four years away. Where do you train, and do you expect us to train there? What do our coaches

think?”

“Train in Michigan. Coaches work for us. Mikelina okay.”

Brandi blinked. He was right. The coaches did work for them. Somewhere along the line with Gina she had forgotten that. Nikolai wasn't finished, but he switched back to his native language. She waited for Alexei to translate.

Alexei looked uncomfortable as he relayed Nikolai's less than glowing opinion of Brandi and Kevin's coach. He gave specific examples of her neglect, including her failure to relay the vital information that Nikolai was interested in Brandi as a potential partner, and that she hadn't paid any attention to Brandi after she began skating with him, other than when they fell.

Brandi started to defend Gina, but Kevin interrupted saying, “He's right, Brandi. Gina's given up on us and works almost exclusively with the munchkins. She's good at developing children, but maybe we should have looked for a better coach a couple of years ago. She should have told you when he first asked about partnering you, instead of waiting until I wanted to quit.”

“I don't know why she wouldn't have told me, if he asked about me,” Brandi said to Kevin.

“She probably didn't tell you, because she didn't want to lose us, but she's losing us now, one way or another, but you know Gina.”

Yeah, she knew Gina. She kept information from them if she felt like it might interfere with their skating or their concentration on skating. Which had been fine when they were kids, but now both of them were adults and needed the information to make decisions about their lives and careers.

Brandi dropped her head. “Okay.”

“Okay,” answered Nikolai.

“What about money, jobs, a place to live?”

Nikolai smiled at her, and Brandi felt her heart do a stutter step. Not good. She deliberately kept her gaze on the plate in front of her, as they made arrangements for her to join Nikolai in Michigan in a couple of weeks.

“I very happy you skate with me,” he said formally as she and Kevin stood to leave. Only his happy sounded more like heppy. His accent made her realize the enormity of what she'd agreed to do. She felt sick and elated as they returned to the motel.

“Oh, Kevin, I think this is a mistake. I should have talked it over with Mom and Dad first.”

“Brandi, it’s the right thing. Everybody wins in this situation. I don’t feel bad about leaving you without a partner. You get to skate with a great skater who expects and wants to compete internationally. Nikolai gets to dump his hysterical partner. After talking to him, he seems all right to me. I think Tatiana must be the ballistic one.”

“Everybody wins except Tatiana.”

“She gets what she deserves,” said Kevin.

“And Gina.”

“She gets to concentrate on her rising stars.” He tossed his arm around her shoulders, offering understanding and support. “I get to be a regular college stud with a social life.”

Brandi laughed. It was true. Skaters normally didn’t have time for social lives. Kevin was her closest friend, in spite of the six-year age gap. Boyfriends rarely lasted more than a couple of dates. No one outside of skating understood the intensity of training or the dedication it required. Too many of the men in skating were gay or taken.

Brandi leaned her head against his shoulder. She wondered if she would ever have this easy kind of relationship with Nikolai. She suspected not. Not with the underlying attraction she felt for him. She would never be totally relaxed the way she was with Kevin.

Nikolai stared as the couple walked down the street ahead of him and Alexei. They laughed and touched, and he simmered.

“You made your choice. Ice not fire,” reminded Alexei.

“For now,” agreed Nikolai, forcing his features to relax.

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But the vow was hard to remember as he opened his door to Brandi two weeks later. He reached out and took her suitcases out of her hands, wanting to lean into her and brush a kiss across her lips. Her brown eyes widened at his sudden proximity. He had invited her to stay in his apartment until she found her own place.

He frowned. The closeness required with ice dancing wouldn’t survive her reluctance to allow him in her personal space. She needed to be totally comfortable with intimacy. Of course he was well aware that he wasn’t casual about the closeness, either. His heart took an extra beat. His breath caught, and he wanted nearer. All the way. Inside her. She ducked away.

“Hi!” she said with a nervous brightness.

“Hello, Brandi,” he managed, hoping she didn’t start rattling. He worked on his English every day, but he was far from fluent. He had half a dozen things he wanted to tell her worked out, but, if she started talking, he would get lost.

And he had spent the last two days worrying she might have changed her mind.

“I have more stuff. I don’t think I should leave things in my car around here.” Her brown eyes swept around his bare apartment. A frown appeared between her eyebrows. There was a sharpness in her words that he hadn’t expected.

“I help.” He carried her suitcases into the bedroom.

“Bathroom?” she asked, carrying her skate bag into the room after him and carelessly dropping it and her purse on the bed.

Nikolai smiled. He could deal with the one-word sentences. He walked out to the hallway and pointed to the right door. She ducked inside and scrabbled on the wall. He leaned in and found the light’s pull chain over the dingy sink. “Sorry, is very small.”

Small was an overstatement, thought Brandi. She practically had to stand in the bathtub to close the door, and she knocked her head into the tile wall when she bent over to pick up a piece of gravel that had caught in her flip-flop. Anxious to find his place before dark, she hadn’t stopped in five hours. He had texted her the address, fearing his directions might be garbled if he relayed the numbers over the phone.

The bathroom was neat and smelled of cleanser, but the yellowed porcelain fixtures had permanent rust stains. She didn’t know what she expected, but something a little less depressing would have been nice.

She washed her hands with the lukewarm water from the hot tap. After opening the door she glanced around. All the walls were a dun color that reminded her of schools and institutions. The narrow dark hallway led to a living room with lumpy furniture an indistinguishable shade of brown or gray. The scarred and scuffed wood floors were bare and cried out to be covered. A window air-conditioning unit droned in one of the windows, blocking any sunlight that might have brightened the place.

She cast a glance in a kitchen barely bigger than the bathroom. Nikolai waited for her beside the front door.

“Let me get my car keys.” She ducked into the bedroom. The putty-colored bedspread looked like something that would have been thrown away at a thrift shop.

As she rummaged in her purse, it occurred to her that she hadn’t seen another bedroom. A tall jelly glass with a single carnation sat on the ancient dresser. Brandi didn’t know whether to laugh or cry. This dump needed a whole lot more than a carnation to brighten it up, but Nikolai had obviously put some effort into making her feel welcome. The single bedroom made her uneasy, but this was a temporary arrangement.

“Nikolai, this is your bedroom.”

He folded his arms across his chest. “I sleep couch.”

“I can’t kick you out of your bedroom. I’ll sleep on the couch, until I get my own place,” she pulled her skate bag and purse off of his bed to take back into the living room.

“*Niet*. Leave here. You sleep bed. I sleep couch.”

“I won’t kick you out of your bed.”

“Is temporary, *da*?”

“Yes.”

“I sleep couch.”

“*I’ll* sleep on the couch.”

“I’ll sleep on the couch,” he repeated dutifully, as if she had corrected his English.

Was she making too big a deal over the whole thing? “The flower is nice. I’m sure it would look great on the coffee table.”

He smiled. “I not understand. You sleep bed, *da*?”

She had the sneaky suspicion he understood, and he was just as stubborn as she. “I won’t force you out of your bed.”

“You want share bed?” he asked innocently.

“*Niet*.” Just to make sure he understood. Definitely not.

Her use of a Russian word must have amused him, because he grinned as if in spite of himself. He turned away quickly, but not before she saw.

“You have more?” he gestured toward her suitcases.

“My costumes, and a trunk.” She twirled her keys around her finger. She looked around the bare bones room with a grimace.

He held the apartment door as she crossed into the musty hallway. Threadbare carpet with a flowered pattern only recognizable near the walls

covered the floor. His blue eyes met hers. "Remind me Russia," he said with a shrug. "You help me be American."

Brandi felt bad. Her dislike of his place must have shown in her face. It just was old and worn, and cramped. He'd probably rented the place furnished. And she didn't know that she could afford much better. She walked down the stairs to the glass door that still bore part of a law office name in gold-flecked letters. The row of apartments was over a strip of storefronts. She'd seen old two story buildings like this a dozen times without ever giving a thought to the occupants over the stores, or that the buildings had any other tenants besides delis and drugstores.

This place wasn't far from the ice rink where they would be practicing. That was a big plus. Cheap, conveniently located, definitely a can of paint would help. Who needed a big place anyway? Thank God it wasn't hers.

Nikolai held the door, and the hot outside air, different than the stale air of the hallway, blasted her. She crossed in front of him. He watched her with his startling blue eyes. His dark hair was too long, and he didn't look like he could ever look American. He looked faintly exotic with his pale skin contrasted against his black tee shirt worn too tight, his jeans stiff as if uncomfortable and foreign. She didn't know if she wanted him to be more American. In that moment she couldn't find any fault with him. She felt weak-kneed. She stumbled stepping off the curb.

He caught her arm. His palm seared her skin. The heat of contact rushed through her in a molten spiral. This was the first time they had ever been alone together, and they would spend the night alone together. The next few nights alone together. Brandi wondered what had made her think staying with him was a smart idea to save motel rates while she found a place to live.

At the time she had been relieved that her tentative question about the possibility of staying with Mikelina had been shot down with the answer that Mikelina already had three permanent Russian guests.

It had seemed like one less thing she needed to worry about. A small detail she could take care of after she arrived, settled in, and adjusted. She didn't know what she'd expected. Except he'd claimed his apartment was large enough to temporarily house them both. He definitely used a different measuring system. Of course he did. He was Russian. He would use metric.

"Don't you dare pick me up," she said as soon as she could make her brain form the words.

His smile was slow in coming, but worth the wait. Oh boy, she was in trouble. His hand dropped away with a brush against her arm.

“We skate four tomorrow. Mikelina eager start.”

The long cast of shadows meant they needed to hit the hay soon. She frowned. She was restless and exhausted from the long drive, but she suspected she wouldn’t be able to sleep well. It wasn’t that kind of exhausted. “Do they have an open skate? I wouldn’t mind getting on the ice tonight.”

“Ends ten,” said Nikolai.

Brandi sighed. She scanned the street, wondering if she felt safe enough to make a few runs up and down in her inline roller-skates. She unlocked her car trunk, put her keys in her pocket and reached for the handle of the footlocker that took up most of the space. Nikolai pulled the locker up to his shoulder and pulled out her rolling suitcase.

Brandi started to protest, but she noticed the flex of muscles in his arms as he balanced the footlocker. The words disappeared in her throat. She glanced down. “Let me get my dresses,” she said, slamming the trunk shut.

She dug her keys out of her pocket and unlocked the back door. She pulled the stack of plastic encased skating costumes off the back seat. She didn’t know which costumes she would be able to use, but, since they each cost several hundred dollars, bringing them made more sense than not. She draped them over her arm and hurried ahead of Nikolai to hold the door.

After climbing the stairs, he parked her rolling suitcase, set her trunk down in the hallway and pulled his keys from his pocket. Brandi tried not to notice the faint sheen of sweat on his arms. She tried to concentrate on the musty disused smells in the hallway, not the heady masculine scent of him. He opened the door and motioned her inside, before following.

“Have you eat?” he asked, pulling open a closet and motioning for her to hang her dresses inside.

Brandi shook her head. She wasn’t sure she could. Colorful clothes hung in his closet. No doubt they were his costumes.

“I have food,” he said, reaching around her. He pulled out a red dress covered by black lace with black taffeta underskirt. Her tango dress.

“Later. I need to get my blood moving. I’ve been driving too long.” That was a lie. Her blood was moving just fine, to all the wrong body parts. She did need to burn off some of her restless energy. She sidestepped out of his proximity.

He frowned. "You need exercise?" He flipped through his stuff until he found black pants, and a red shirt with ruffled sleeves on a connecting hanger.

"Yeah. It doesn't match, does it?" she said.

"I change to white shirt, short jacket, and match..." He gestured across his midriff.

Brandi assumed he meant he would get a matching cummerbund. In some ways it made more sense for him to modify his costumes, than for them both to get all new outfits. Her dresses were probably more expensive.

He dropped the costumes and shut the closet door. "Want walk?"

"If you wouldn't mind."

He shook his head slightly as if he didn't understand.

"Please."

But Brandi wasn't sure the walk made her feel any less restless. Nikolai strolled beside her, watching her. They walked down the sidewalk in front of a festively lighted party supply store. A stocky man stood at the door ushering late customers out, obviously preparing for closing. Most of the other storefronts were dark, already closed several hours ago. The area seemed deserted. She couldn't decide if that meant it was safer or more dangerous. In any case she didn't think it would be wise to be out after dark. However, danger of a different kind waited in Nikolai's apartment.

It was even more apparent after she changed to a sleep tee shirt and then realized she would need to cross through the living room to brush her teeth. Nikolai had unfurled a sheet and blanket on the couch, grabbing one of the pillows from the bed, before she closed the door to change. She didn't think before she opened the door. She flushed as she realized Nikolai was in the process of removing his jeans, his shirt already tossed on the chair. He paused before pushing his jeans the rest of the way down. He sat on the couch pulling them off his lower legs.

Of course he couldn't undress in the pea size bathroom. They absolutely had to work out arrangements for using the bedroom for changing. Only most skaters weren't too modest. In some venues the lack of proper dressing rooms prevented excessive modesty. At times the only privacy they would have would be what they supplied for each other, by holding up towels or whatever.

"Sorry," muttered Brandi, dropping her head.

“Do need something?” he asked, watching her, as he thrust his legs under the sheet.

She held up her toothbrush and toothpaste before she scurried towards the bathroom. She wondered if black underwear was a Russian thing. And decided she knew far more than she should about what was underneath his clothes. She wished abstractedly that she would have noticed some kind of flaw, but she hadn't. There wasn't a chance in hell she would be able to sleep anytime soon.

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Chapter Three

Nikolai had prayed last night that she wouldn't need anything. Not that he would have minded helping her out in any way. It was just that she would be totally aware of his blatant reaction to her catching him shedding his clothes. He could only think to finish removing his jeans, pretend nothing was happening, and get under the covers as quick as possible. Now he prayed that he could control his reaction. That wasn't easy as they circled the ice, locked in each other's arms. Although the physical exertion helped some.

"Can you relax?" he asked, leaning close to her ear so his voice wouldn't carry to Mikelina.

"I'm sorry," she answered. "I know I'm stiff."

So was he. In more ways than one. Nikolai barely suppressed a groan.

Mikelina clapped her hands. Nikolai recognized this a signal that his other coach, Yuri, was here and would want to start working on specific dance steps. Brandi didn't have a clue. She crashed against him, as he dug his toe picks in to stop. He sucked in a deep breath, feeling her soft breasts against his chest, her thighs against his. He couldn't help but wrap his arms around her, but managed to stop himself from tugging her closer.

She gave him a suspicious glance as she backed away from him. Nikolai grasped for control and English, too many tasks for a brain that was oxygen deprived. "*Izvinite.*"

"What?"

Nikolai winced. "Excuse me. Is time for work with choreographer. Mikelina"—he clapped three times to teach her the coaching shorthand Mikelina used—"when Yuri ready."

"I see."

They worked with the coaches for a long time. Doing intricate footwork, first in slow steps, and gradually with more speed. Brandi watched him with trepidation shining out of her brown eyes. The more he tried to get her to relax, the more uptight she seemed to get.

Mikelina and Yuri snipped at him in Russian. They both told him he made a poor choice. He was crazy to want to become an American. How they learned he intended to apply for United States citizenship, he didn't know. He hadn't talked to the lawyer yet.

It's a career choice, he wanted to shout at them. It had nothing to do with who or what he was. He knew in his soul he was Russian. Becoming a

US citizen wouldn't change that. Acting like an American wouldn't change that. After he was done with skating, he would return home to the motherland. But he'd like to have his career and enjoy himself for the time being. He didn't know why everyone seemed to take his decision to become naturalized so hard.

His mother had cried when he phoned her. He kept trying to tell her it was only for his career, only temporary. Besides it wasn't that big a deal. Americans could live in Russia, just the same as Russians could live in America.

He knew Brandi was a good skater and dancer. So far, only her skating persona had shown up. He had hoped that by sharing living quarters for a few days, they could fast start the trust and intimacy they needed to develop, but that hadn't happened.

Instead she jumped like she was scalded any time he touched her. This morning, scooting around her in the tiny kitchen, he'd put his hand on her waist. He hadn't thought about it too much before doing it. It was just a friendly gesture to let her know he was there. He could have risked letting her back up into him, letting his body brush against the whole length of hers.

She'd slammed back into a cabinet and ducked out of the kitchen. Later, he entered the small shared bathroom as she exited, worried that he wouldn't have time to finish shaving, and she had looked panic-stricken as she tried to move past without touching him. This was a bad sign.

Ice dancers had to touch each other, often intimately. They had to look passionately toward each other. They had to trust their partners with their bodies. They frequently had to act as if they were in love, or lust, depending on the dance. They had to be in tune with each other, or their steps would never be totally synchronized.

"Look like wood puppets," yelled Mikelina.

Great, now both of them had a stiffness problem.

"I'm sorry," muttered Brandi. "I'm trying to relax. I really am. Everything seems so strange, and I haven't been on the ice in more than a week. I'm doing the steps, aren't I? The more she yells at me—"

"Stop!" interrupted Nikolai.

Brandi's brown eyes flashed. "I can't not talk."

"You want I smile and nod?" he asked.

She stared at him blankly for a minute.

He heaved a sigh.

Mikelina yelled at them. They'd missed the dip part of the dance they were following, but amazingly both of them had stayed in step through the lapse. Nikolai held up his hand to his coach.

"You want I not understand?"

"I don't know. I've never had to worry about that before."

"Not worry now. Decide what want."

She flushed and looked away. He watched her carefully. Her timing faltered. He dragged his toe picks, so the lack of harmony wouldn't cause them to fall.

"Sorry," she muttered, picking up the motions of the dance.

"Strange to me, also. I wish listen you say." He frowned, knowing his English was poor. "Is important, *da*?"

"No, most of what I say isn't important." She rolled her eyes. "It's just what I do. Run at the mouth, that is."

"How I know important?"

"I don't know. I'm getting a headache."

"Wish stop?"

"No, I don't wish to stop. We have lots of work to do. We have to come up with a short dance and a free dance in three months, let alone learn to skate all the compulsory steps together."

"You are worry?" he asked.

"Worried, yes."

"This why like wooden puppet? Not relax?"

She flushed again. "Partly."

"What other part?" he asked, at once wanting to both soothe her and ruffle her even more.

"You know, maybe I need to work on my edges a little here. I think I went through an inside edge instead of stepping straight to an outside edge. Could you tell? Maybe, I should ask Mikelina."

"What other part?"

~~*

Brandi didn't want to answer him. His mouth flattened and he shook his head as the silence stretched out like a gaping hole begging to be jumped into. "Did we miss the dip on the last circuit? I think we did."

"*Da*. What part?"

Because she was attracted to him and didn't know what to do about it. Each time his hand was on her hip, or holding her hand she felt giddy. She rolled her eyes. "I'm really am using my inside edge as we make that turn. I should concentrate on making it an outside edge."

"Brandi, am ask you—"

"I know, I know. I just want to concentrate on skating, okay. That's what we're here for. I'll loosen up eventually. I'm just not used to you. Watch my edge, okay? Tell me if I go straight to an outside edge."

Mikelina clapped, and, this time, Brandi nearly jerked Nikolai's arms out of his sockets, because he held on and she didn't stop. The music stopped a couple of beats later.

"Stop on clap," said Mikelina, skating to a stop beside them.

"Clap on. Clap off," muttered Brandi.

"What?" asked Nikolai.

"Never mind. American joke."

"Teach me."

"It wasn't funny."

"Nikolai!" shouted Mikelina.

He snapped to attention, giving Brandi a questioning look, before turning to his coach. *Their coach*, Brandi reminded herself.

"Work some dance moves now." Mikelina and Yuri demonstrated a turn Yuri wanted them to execute. From a face-to-face waltz hold Brandi would do one and a half revolutions while they changed hand holds to a modified Killian position with Nikolai behind her as much as beside her. A tighter Killian position with Nikolai's hand centered against her ribs, instead of her hip. She had to pivot, complete the turn without tripping him, losing speed, and she actually ended up closer to him than when they started.

She watched as Yuri and Mikelina demonstrated that they should stroke with their left foot as they came out of the turn. She asked how to time it with the music. Yuri gave her an answer, but, she found his thick accent hard to understand. And there wasn't any music playing right now to give her a beat. They did a dry run without the music, barely moving instead of skating full speed. Nikolai totally missed his hold, because she was stroking, before he was. Mikelina yelled at her to turn slower. She supposed they considered it her fault anytime their darling missed a move.

She flashed him a frown.

The first time skating fast his hand landed too high, and because he stroked sooner, he collided into her, as she came out of the turn.

Brandi shuddered. His fingers curled around her breast before he slid his hand down, making the sensation worse. Better. Oh hell. This wasn't happening. She could feel his thigh against her bottom. Solid strength against her softness. Hard heat nearly against her melting warmth.

Brandi jerked forward as he said, "*Izvinite*, excuse me. I not mean..." English must have failed him at that point, because he lapsed back into Russian.

Accidents happened. It was nothing. A little incidental contact, although it felt anything but incidental. Brandi stroked away from him, making a quick circuit of the ice before returning to try again. She tried to draw a deep breath, but she was breathless. That would have made sense if she had been skating hard for some time, but they hadn't. They had been watching Yuri and Mikelina demonstrate the move before walking through it. She'd had plenty of time to catch her breath.

She had to get over this. Nikolai skated a small circle in the middle of the ice. Was he as tense as she was? He rested his hands on his thighs as he glided across the ice, letting his speed dissipate gradually.

"Tatiana big," he said as she returned to his side. "You small." His blue eyes held hers, as if he was concerned that she might think he had grabbed her breast intentionally.

She hadn't thought that—until now. No, he had agreed. And if he was going to break an agreement like that, surely he could at least wait until they had more than one half day of practice together.

"Tatiana is taller. I'm shorter. I'm not angry. Just don't do it again." She held out her arms, for them to resume the waltz position.

"Not bad for first try," said Mikelina, reminding them they weren't alone on the ice. "Now you go too fast, Nikolai." She snapped her fingers to give them a beat to work with.

Why couldn't she have done that in the first place, wondered Brandi. She was much better at timing moves if she knew how they were supposed to fit to the music. Giving the tempo of the choreography was the right thing to do.

Except it must have made it worse.

Not only did Nikolai's hand skim across her breast as he tried to complete the change in hold, but in the midst of his apology, she thrust back

with the wrong foot. The resulting tangle of boots brought them both down. He landed half on top of her. His warm body on her back and cold ice underneath gave a bizarre jolt to her nervous system. She could feel the turgid tightening in her nipples, and she tried to ascribe it to the cold. Tried, but knew the sensation started before she hit the deck.

Nikolai shifted off of her. “Okay?” he asked nervously.

“Fine. You?”

“Okay,” he answered, but his voice sounded a little funny.

Brandi stood, and planted her hands on her hips. Nikolai moved to his knees and stood up slowly. She wanted to watch his face and make sure he wasn’t the type to hide an injury, but he turned away from her. This time he took the big circuit of the ice.

Brandi watched him. Then she wondered about the wisdom in that. Mikelina skated out from the boards again. Brandi wished she’d just stay on the ice with them instead of watching from the sidelines and disappearing from view. It might help her remember she wasn’t alone with Nikolai, although Brandi suspected it might not make much of a difference to her raging hormones.

Brandi needed a boyfriend. Pure and simple. She needed a potential lover, an outlet. With the support of her family around her in California, she hadn’t felt the need so keenly. But here, with a partner she found potentially attractive, she would have problems if she didn’t find a companion to take care of her emotional—hell physical—needs. It had been a long time, too long. Her first skating partner, in fact. Before she paired up with Kevin. The reason she’d needed to pair up with Kevin. Because once her off-ice relationship with her former skate partner ended, they couldn’t skate together.

There had been too much animosity. She thought she might have been able to get past it, although she knew she had been guilty of heavy sarcasm and hurt overreactions to anything that seemed cruel on his part. Every fall, she felt like her partner tripped her on purpose. Even when she knew falls were inevitable. Every misstep by either one of them resulted in shouting and accusations. Gina had seemed more like a referee, sending them both to their corners of the ice to cool down, before going at it again. Her former partner acted as if she’d dropped a bomb on him, even though he’d gone out with someone else. He had been too angry to get past their split. That’s how Brandi knew how wrong an affair with a skating partner could go.

Kevin had been a blessing, and fortunately too young for any kind of attraction to develop. Only thirteen to her nineteen when they started. Instead they had developed a great close friendship. Now she was paired with a man she found terribly attractive, and the misplacement of his hand sent disturbing hot and cold flashes running through her.

And why was he having so much difficulty with the change in hand positions anyway? She had the difficult steps. All he needed to do was make sure they stayed close and position his hold. She flushed, wondering if she was sending off unspoken signals that she would welcome an advance from him. At his apartment he had been friendly. Overly friendly?

Maybe not. Maybe she was hypersensitive. No, not maybe, she was. His hand at her waist made her breathing catch. Her blood roared in her veins with an increased pounding that settled low in her. She had to get over this, or they would never be able to skate together. And she was not going to go the other route. No way.

She would not even consider sleeping with Nikolai to relieve this tension. She hardly knew him, and his broken English wouldn't ease the process. Besides, she knew how badly a played out affair could end. And she had too much at stake to risk skating. She was too old, and the scarcity of available good male ice dancers made finding a new pairing, if things didn't work out with Nikolai, too unlikely.

Affairs between ice dancing couples that did work, were ones based on years of friendship and partnering each other. They weren't based on attraction alone. And Brandi couldn't see that there was much more at work here. She'd disliked him the first time she'd seen him yelling at Tatiana. Admittedly Tatiana wasn't ever going to be nominated for a Miss Congeniality award, but still. Brandi had thought Nikolai was too insensitive, too foreign, too unaware of how depressing his apartment was. And the way he cut her off as she was talking really irritated her.

"Skate together. Not make big circles around the ice alone," said Mikelina. "You make turn good. Concentrate on follow through."

Brandi felt her fingers curling in. She intentionally relaxed her hands, shaking them out. She nodded. Mikelina switched to Russian and addressed Nikolai. He returned to her side, and they resumed the steps of the dance. They tried one more time to execute the turn. This time his hand dropped far too low and landed below her waist. He slid it up to her ribs, but the

damage was done as heat trailed after his hand, like a trail of light following a sparkler.

“Higher,” shouted Mikelina.

“*Da*,” muttered Nikolai.

“Try dip. Brandi, lean back into Nikolai’s hand. Right foot straight forward.”

“Go,” said Nikolai, giving her hips a shove forward while positioning his hand at the back of her neck. “Fall back.”

Brandi had to trust him. Otherwise she would end up on the ice. Lifting her right blade from the ice, she let her weight sink back, bending her left knee.

“Look strained. Relax,” instructed Mikelina.

“I have you,” echoed Nikolai as he cradled the back of her head with his hand. He bent over so she dropped low to the ice. She was so low she had to depend on him to support her.

“How do we get out of this?” asked Brandi, aware that Nikolai had shifted. She slowly rose as he lifted her head up.

“Look good, look good. Build up speed and try again,” said Mikelina. “This time cross hands on chest, like pray. Raise one hand to Nikolai.”

This time she dropped faster and put her hands over her heart. She reached up finding it was possible to cup his cheek in her hand. They moved across the ice in the pose for several beats. His blue eyes held hers for a long moment that left her breathless. She jerked up as fast as she could.

“Let him raise you up,” instructed Mikelina. “Do again.”

They moved through the turn to the dip again, only this time Brandi had a hard time relaxing.

“Too stiff. Too stiff,” said Mikelina.

Nikolai brought Brandi back up to a standing position.

Mikelina clapped. This time Brandi stopped, admittedly ten feet in front of Nikolai, but he skated up beside her.

“You do good for first day. Must work much on feeling comfortable together. Skate open session tonight.” She named another ice rink. She went through a list of basic moves she wanted them to do.

Nikolai groaned.

“What?” asked Brandi.

“You have car now, yes?” said Mikelina, looking at Brandi.

Brandi nodded.

“You do this all week,” Mikelina said, turning her attention back to Nikolai. “If no improvement. I schedule more private ice time.”

“We do it,” said Nikolai.

“Here tomorrow four.” Mikelina skated toward the entrance. “Don’t be late,” she called over her shoulder.

“Wait. I can’t afford more private ice time,” said Brandi. She couldn’t necessarily afford *this* private ice time unless she found some kind of job. Well, she could until she found an apartment, but managing both was doubtful. “What did you say we would do anyway?”

“Skate public session Ice Palace. Six to midnight. Back here at four tomorrow.”

“All week?”

“Da.”

No wonder he’d groaned. They would be exhausted. And when would they sleep?

“Must go now. Sleep maybe.” He held her hand and pulled her towards the boards.

“Yeah, right.”

The Zamboni lumbered out of its resting place. Their coaching was done for today. No chance to redeem herself by relaxing as she skated. Mikelina had decreed her dancing wooden, and they would be skating for twelve hours a day until she corrected her problem.

“I need to find a place to live. I need to find some kind of job. We’re going to be on the ice almost twelve hours a day.”

“I miss English, teach,” interrupted Nikolai.

“I’m not upset. I’m venting. I’m not a whiner. I can deal with a lot of skate time. I’m just worried we won’t get enough rest. I have so much to do to get settled.”

“I not understand.” He picked up their guards from the rink edge and handed hers to her. Bending he put his guards on his blades.

“Yeah, you shouldn’t miss English. Maybe we should talk to Mikelina. Maybe there is another solution. Maybe some rink has earlier sessions. We’ll never be able to get up at three or three-thirty in the morning.”

“We do...have do,” said Nikolai, wishing she wouldn’t pile so many sentences on top of one another. He wished he sorted through translations faster.

“We do what we have to do?” she asked, turning a worried face to his.

Nikolai pushed his thumb against the worry lines rutted between her eyebrows. Her skin was damp and warm to his touch. Her brown eyes glazed, before she ducked back away from his hand. “*Da*. Sorry. Not worry, but skate needs work. Puppets no win.”

“You’re right. I’m just not sure skating together more is going to solve the problem.”

“I think share apartment help.” He had thought that. He wanted to be able to express his thoughts, but his English was so poor.

“No, definitely not. I need my own place,” said Brandi, turning her face away.

“Help us learn each other,” he said, brokenly. “Help us used to touching.”

“No touching. We don’t need to touch each other all the time.”

“Want make natural. What part make stiff, Brandi?”

She dropped to a bench and bent over to unlace her skates. Was her flushed face from the exertion, or from the question? He thought she wouldn’t answer him, but finally she started speaking in a low voice, after casting a look around to make sure no one was listening. “I just don’t want anything with you other than ice dancing. I thought I was perfectly clear about that.”

“*Da*,” answered Nikolai slowly. “Must be okay with much touch for skate.”

“I’m afraid I gave you the wrong impression by agreeing to stay with you until I got my own place. I didn’t expect only one bedroom.”

“Is temporary. I not think...” he winced, looking for the right words. “I think help us know each other, not anything else.” Was he that obvious? He was trying hard to control his desire. He’d accepted her decree of a skating partnership only. He hadn’t thought that her staying with him meant anything other than convenience. Temporary convenience. He hoped it could mean more, but she had been crystal clear on that.

Ice first, fire, if there was to be any, had to come much later. He needed to become as familiar with touching her as she needed to be with him. So he could learn to control the irregular thump of his heart. So he wouldn’t be distracted by the curve of her neck, her shoulders. He shook his head. Skate, skate, skate. He couldn’t afford to blow this partnership. “Should I call Alexei for to talk?”

“No.”

Why was she so upset about it anyway? Even with Tatiana there had been a sort of connection that occurred off the ice as well as on. He hadn't cared for Tatiana off the ice. He'd admired her skill on it, enough to tamp down any personality problems for many years. Her complete failure to withstand the pressure of competitions ultimately destroyed their partnership. “I thought you were saner than Tatiana,” he said without thinking and fortunately without translating, because she frowned.

“What about Tatiana?”

“We not like each much, but touch. On—off ice, not think bad.” That wasn't strictly true. Tatiana had liked him a lot more than he liked her, or something. After all, she had intimated that their relationship should take an extra step off the ice. “Skate together important to me. Relax important. Want help you,” Nikolai paused to give himself time to translate his thoughts. “You no think stay together will help us closer?”

“No. I don't know.”

Okay it was more than his poor English that kept him from understanding her.

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Brandi picked up her skate bag to retrieve her shoes. Nikolai sat beside her and tugged off his skates. Staying together was likely to make them closer in a way she didn't want. Giving into these feelings of attraction was a big risk. No, staying together was probably a big mistake. Being around him twenty-four hours a day wouldn't give her a break. She needed time apart to regain her equilibrium, her sanity. Wanting to share the single bedroom in his stark apartment was a huge mistake. Personally, emotionally and professionally. It would be suicide, professionally.

“Mikelina tell us skate. We fix relax, first. Fix place you stay later.” He shoved his feet in his tied shoes and stood.

Brandi suspected he had not too subtly accused her of not being dedicated. She was just very concerned that too much proximity would force her to make a mistake that could jeopardize their skating career. She was putting skating first, over a very strong desire to throw it to the wind by inviting Nikolai to share his own bedroom. An idea that seemed so out of character for her, she didn't even know how to handle the thought, let alone anything else. And maybe she was a little upset that Mikelina decided she could wrap her whole day around a ridiculous skating schedule.

Okay, so lately she was a little resistant to coaching suggestions. He'd started it, when he'd said that bit about coaches working for them, not the other way around. She wanted to be able to review everything she was told, decide if she agreed, and then follow the instructions. She generally would end up doing as she was told. She wondered now, if she had questioned some of the things Gina told her, would she and Kevin have made it farther together. Brandi had decided to take more personal responsibility for her career and make sure her coaches pushed her in a direction she wanted to go.

And if she was getting her money's worth. After all, now that she was on a very limited budget, she wanted every dollar to count.

"Skate first. English later. Job, place later," he repeated while pushing back his sleeves.

"Number one priority." She didn't need him frustrated with her, too. "I just can't forget all the other things that need to be done. You don't understand. You already have a place."

"We share until we have more time," he said tightly.

Controlling, that was what he was. But not her. She wouldn't let him. They would be equal partners in this if she had to scratch and claw every step of equality out of him. This was America. They would skate on her terms. He had sought her as a partner. She hadn't sought him. She buried her face in her towel. Her thoughts were so disordered, she wondered if she hadn't sprung a leak in her thought process.

"Okay, but I don't like it."

"I know, too Russian," he said.

She dropped the towel and stared up at him. Torn between wanting to lie and convince him she liked the place and that she wanted to share the place too much. "I don't like sharing."

"Is American trait, *da*?"

"No, not liking sharing is not an American trait. I can share an apartment. You know..." She stopped when she realized he was grinning at her.

"You want shower first?" He held out his hand.

She, like an idiot, put her hand in his and had to suffer all the heart-thumping consequences.

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Nikolai led Brandi through the glass doors, pleased with the smile she'd given him. She withdrew her hand as they entered the parking lot. And that was all Nikolai got. Little pieces of relaxation, that didn't last long enough and evaporated like dew in the sunshine. One miscue from him and she was back into her wooden puppet routine. He started to wonder if it was less him—as he'd thought originally—and more her. He was careful to keep his touching circumspect, but they had to touch. He was careful to not make sexual overtures. When he asked Brandi what exactly bothered her about the physical closeness she would change the subject.

In three days they had made improvements, but not enough. Mikelina would berate him in Russian as if it was his fault. He was frustrated and exhausted. They spent five and a half hours training in the morning, hurried back to the apartment for lunch at ten and then tried to nap until it was time to eat dinner and go to the other rink, arriving there by six. They circled the ice in standard patterns then collapsed during the time the Zamboni smoothed the ice. At midnight they dragged themselves back to his apartment, fell asleep for a couple of hours before rolling out of bed and couch to start the round again.

The night before, Brandi suggested that they leave as the Zamboni resurfaced the ice for the last time. Nikolai had been tempted to agree, but Yuri walked in at that moment to check on them. They'd gone back to the ice.

This morning Nikolai had jammed his foot into his boot, knowing the blisters he had sprouted were likely to get worse. Brandi had sat through a green light and started to drive on the red. Admittedly at three forty-five in the morning there wasn't any cross traffic to worry about, but if they killed themselves they weren't going to get loose with each other.

He knew the extra time was making a difference to their skating. They were synchronized to the point that when they both fell over from exhaustion, he suspected they would do it at the same time.

"How long does this go on?" she asked, pulling into the empty parking lot of the rink.

"When Mikelina happy."

"I don't have any clean clothes."

They both needed to do laundry. Brandi had yanked open the costume closet this morning and pulled out a short turquoise skirt and a cropped

style top. She had shoved it in her skate bag. Nikolai had settled for the same black pants he'd worn yesterday and added a clean white tee shirt.

"Is this normal? Is this what I signed on for? I didn't know I was going to face this kind of grueling training schedule."

Nikolai felt like his brain was turning to mush. He wished she would talk in straight English. He had enough trouble with simple translations. He had enough trouble following her rapid questions. "Is not normal schedule. Must go in."

"Is all this extra training my fault? Is there something I'm not doing right?"

Nikolai jerked his eyes to her. Didn't she know? "Is you stiff. Mikelina want you relax with me."

"Well, then she ought to give me time to relax." Brandi shot out of the car like a jack-in-the-box.

"Brandi!"

She stopped before pulling open one of the double glass doors. He dropped his hand to her shoulder. He felt as much as saw her leaning away.

"Must tell me, why pull away from me. Happen on ice, bad for skate."

"I don't do it on the ice."

"Yes, do."

She didn't answer.

"I not hurt. I not expect..." he fumbled with his words.

"Don't you?" asked Brandi, staring ahead through the doors. "Were you and Tatiana involved?"

"*Niet*. Kevin?"

She shook her head.

"You him touch, hold hand off ice." She had her hand down the back of his pants in Bucharest...

"But it feels different with you. It feels like you want more. I want to skate with you, Nikolai, but things happening between us could really screw things up."

"What mean screw things up?"

She heaved a great sigh. "Make a mess, cause fights. It would be a total disaster."

"I not think so."

"Well, I do. So cut it out. We can be friends, but that's it."

What did she mean, cut it out? "I try be friends. I try be partners."

She yanked open the door and stepped inside.

“Brandi,” he said, stopping her. He put one of his arms across her shoulders as he pulled open the inner door. “This friends. I wish more time make friends, but season start soon.”

As they entered the lobby her brown eyes were suspiciously bright. She ducked out from under his arm so fast, he felt a little like he embraced a ghost. He dropped his arm and wondered if some of his touches were so obviously precursors to advances. He shook his head. He didn’t think so. He’d been very careful to not cross any lines. Of course Alexei, who had been staying in the states for several years, told him Americans weren’t as touchy-feely as Russians were. They didn’t stand as close when they talked, and they were used to space. Personal and public.

Brandi and he desperately needed to have a discussion. One where he would need an interpreter. And a conversation he wanted to have alone. He sighed. He needed to work on his English. He had thought living with Brandi and talking in English even for a few days would help. Maybe it was, but not as much as he’d hoped. Besides they were too tired to talk about things that weren’t entirely necessary.

This problem would need to sit until his English was good enough to handle it. In which case it might be wise for her to find her own place. Because knowing she was sleeping just a few feet away, made getting what sleep he did get, even harder.

By the way she was acting, he wondered if she knew he wanted to crawl in bed with her. He would never do that without her invitation, no matter how badly he wanted to. He didn’t know why she was so adamantly opposed to the idea of anything more happening between them. He didn’t see the big deal. He didn’t understand why she feared an affair. Did she think it had something to do with the deterioration of his relationship with Tatiana? He hadn’t had an affair with Tatiana. Why did she even care if she wasn’t planning for anything happening between them?

It suddenly dawned him as he was circling the ice, waiting for her to get changed, that maybe she wasn’t afraid of him. Maybe it was her own response that scared the hell out of her. He kept his eyes from straying to her bare midriff as she joined him on the ice. He didn’t intend to do it, but the extra hours and the thoughts running through his head, made him sloppy. When they finally got to the point in the choreography Yuri had them working on he misplaced his hand again.

He had trouble at first, because he was used to Tatiana losing speed as she spun and with her he had tried to not close in, as his partner started in front of him skating backwards and ended up forwards. Brandi was lighter on her skates, and he suspected she actually gathered speed on the initial turn. He would get so busy concentrating on the footwork, which for him was basically just sticking close, and not getting in her way, that he would forget to bring his hand down low enough. He wondered now if his hand placement had been as bad with Tatiana, not that he would have noticed with her. She didn't have the soft fullness that filled his hand every time he caught Brandi in the wrong place.

She made a sound of protest in her throat as he slipped his hand down encountering the bare skin of her midriff.

"Sorry," he muttered.

Their steps didn't falter the way they had the first few times he'd made the error in placing his hand. They made the three steps, Yuri had set up, before Nikolai pushed her hips forward, bringing his errant hand around to the back of her neck. Her arms came up and it looked as if she was trying to recapture his embrace with her hands on her chest. She leaned back into the dip as he supported her with one hand. He made the mistake of looking down her body and noticing the goose bumps across her stomach.

She was too warm from the exertion of skating to have goose bumps from the cold. She reached her hand back to touch his face. Her nipples had tightened into tight buds. Was this her response to his hand on the breast? He looked down into her flushed face. Her fingertips were warm against his cheek. The moment stretched out as the idea dawned on him. She wanted him.

He couldn't have contained the smile that broke across his face if he wanted. Brandi strained to rise, as Mikelina shouted a compliment from the boards. A compliment on their expressions.

Nikolai wasn't sure what happened, but in the next minute they were sprawled across the ice. He suspected Mikelina's shout had shattered more than their concentration. He thought Brandi had caught a toe pick, and, in his effort to keep from dumping her flat on the ice, he had dropped to his knees. Her head was in his lap, and he half-lay across her.

"Okay?" He lifted her head up, sitting beside her. He left his hand at the back of her neck.

"Fine," she said, pulling away from him.

He needed to say something to put her at ease. Mikelina entered the ice heading toward them. Fortunately they were on the far end of the rink. "I do not put hand..." he grasped for words.

He reached out not intending to touch her. She folded her arms across her chest before he came anywhere close. Well, she knew what he meant then. "I not do." He searched his tired brain for an English word that meant unintentionally. Same word for car crash. "Wreck." No, that wasn't right.

Brandi pulled her knees up. "Accident, you mean." She dropped her head to her knees.

"*Da.*" He wanted to explain he would never take advantage of their skating to manhandle her. When he did caress her, if he ever did, he wanted her full cooperation and pleasure. But his English was so limited, and Mikelina crossed the ice toward them. He held up a hand to ward their coach off, and knew he might have garnered a minute, but not much longer.

"I feel so vulnerable. I'm so tired, Nikolai. I'm afraid I'm going to give in and do something really stupid. I'm sorry. I don't know if I can keep my head on straight. I know what I shouldn't do, but I..." She looked at him then, her eyes huge in her face. "You're so close. We have to touch all the time. I think maybe I'm a little homesick. I'm so confused. Maybe we just should do it, and then I can freak out about how long before we start screaming at each other. I know having a romance off the ice is the stupidest thing in the world to do, but I don't know if I can fight these feelings much longer."

He tried to sort through all she said, and he was aware that she had tilted her head into his hand. He stroked his thumb over her cheek. He couldn't catch all of what she said, or even her entire meaning. He thought, but he wasn't sure, she had said she was willing to sleep with him. He pulled her against him. He would have kissed her, except a tear trickled out of one of her eyes.

He didn't want her like this. He didn't want her defeated. He didn't want her because skating eleven to twelve hours a day left her too exhausted to fight. He struggled for some way to let her know he wouldn't take advantage of her vulnerability. That he was willing to wait until she was sure. His brain swirled with Russian words without translations. He wasn't even sure he'd understood correctly. Mikelina moved toward them again.

"Brandi, am gay," he whispered in her ear.

She recoiled, and he wondered why he had lied like that. Because it was the only thing he was certain he could say that would make her quit worrying about what would happen between them. Because he wasn't sure he would be able to resist temptation knowing she would give in if he made the attempt to crawl in bed with her. And because when the idea popped into his brain it smacked of brilliance. Of course in reality it was possibly the most idiotic thing he'd ever said.

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Chapter Four

“You are?” Brandi asked. Of course he was. He wouldn’t have said it otherwise. She had just thrown herself at a gay man, offered to sleep with him. Had thought from his looks and touches he had wanted her. Even now he had her pulled into a hug.

Her ears burned and she wanted to dig a hole in the ice and crawl through. She tried to pull out of his arms, aware that she had just committed one of the largest faux pas of her life.

“Stay. Is okay,” he said, resisting her efforts at freedom.

“We’re sitting on the ice.” She backed away until she could see his face. He refused to meet her eyes directly. He looked like he’d eaten something particularly unsettling. But, from his dark hair contrasting with his pale skin, his long lean form, the strength in his arms, to the attractive arrangement of his face features he still appealed to her. She wanted to ask if he was sure. Maybe he had made a mistake. But he looked as uncomfortable as she felt. He hadn’t wanted to tell her. What a waste.

“Is offends you?”

“No, oh no,” she said, relaxing in his arms. She held onto him, offering comfort to him. She wasn’t offended. You couldn’t stay in skating if you were truly offended by gay male skaters. They were everywhere, although most of them worked very hard to keep their private lives private. Many of them invented fictitious girlfriends to deal with the inevitable press questions. But when you traveled and stayed with other skaters it became obvious that a disproportionate amount of the male skaters were gay.

But she had never even suspected Nikolai. In five days of living with him, eating with him, skating with him, she hadn’t seen a single clue that would indicate his sexual preference was for men. In fact, she’d thought she’d seen a fair amount of evidence that he was attracted to her. All his touches had been of the comfortable, friendly, non-threatening kind? Had she been reading more into it, because she wanted to see it? Because she was attracted to him?

“I feel like an idiot,” she said.

“Do not. Not idiot wish skate with me, *da?*”

“I wished to do more than skate.”

“Wish convert me?” he asked, holding her eyes.

There was such a questioning seriousness in his blue eyes that Brandi’s breath caught. Oh, hell, she wasn’t immune, even though she knew he was

uninterested, or was he? Did she want to convert him? Convince him he'd erred.

"No, not if you're happy. I mean..." She didn't know what she meant.

He smiled. "We skate, *da?*"

"Yes. Please."

~~*

Miracle of all miracles, she relaxed. She started to look like a dancer instead of a puppet. Oh, she was still flushing a little in the spots where she had to hold his eyes, but Mikelina was happy. Yuri was happy. Brandi was smiling. Nikolai was miserable.

He had trapped himself into this pretense of being gay, and it was working. He would rather it didn't. If she hadn't believed him, then he could go home with her, tell her he lied, tell her why, and tell her the truth. But now he was caught. He prayed that she would wish to convert him, but he doubted that would happen. And he didn't think he could explain anyway. Not in English. Not yet.

And why would he? It helped her relax, and skating was supposed to be his primary goal. Maybe when he finally did tell her the truth he could pretend his English was so bad he didn't understand what he was saying. Maybe she would forget. Maybe palm trees would grow in Siberia.

"Look good. Look good," said Mikelina. "Try new lift now."

The lift was only new to her. Nikolai had done it for years with Tatiana, but Brandi had trouble holding her extension. The move required her to lay over his shoulder with an arched back and legs in the splits, only she rarely managed to get her body contorted into position as he lifted her, holding her up with both his hands on one of her legs.

"Higher, higher," said Mikelina.

"Stop," said Brandi.

He set her down on the ice holding her waist wondering if she had hurt herself. She grimaced.

"Are okay?" he asked.

"I can't do that move that way." She turned to Mikelina who had skated up beside them. "How about if I get rid of the arched back and hold my leg up with my arms? I don't know that I can get into a full splits position in the air."

Mikelina narrowed her eyes. "Try harder." She skated away.

"She no like challenge," warned Nikolai in a low voice.

“Tough. I don’t like practicing Tatiana’s moves. I’m not leaning back this time.”

“Brandi, must do what coach wants.”

“Why? It’s not working. Let’s just see how it works my way.”

Nikolai shook his head.

“Let’s go.”

They moved back into step. When he lifted her, she did the move her way anyway. What was wrong with her? When Mikelina skated back to their side he said in Russian that he thought she would do it right.

Brandi rolled her eyes at him. He vaguely felt like a traitor. She was right. She didn’t have Tatiana’s elastic flexibility. Her strength was in her dancing and speed and determination to get the steps perfect. He just figured it was a matter of time and adjustment before his coaches figured out what would work.

He also knew, unlike Brandi, that many of the moves they were practicing were culled from the free dance Yuri had been developing for him and Tatiana. Their coaches were among the best. They would figure out what would showcase his and Brandi strengths as an ice dancing couple, but there was no sense in challenging their authority when all of them were in a learning process. After all, his coaches were still unhappy about his decision to become an American.

In a way, he supposed Yuri and Mikelina probably felt like they were training the enemy now.

Mikelina didn’t say a word, but started them on a new series of steps, keeping a highly critical eye on Brandi’s footwork, commenting often.

Brandi nodded at the criticism, and took it to heart, often asking if she had done it right or noting that she’d rolled her edges before Mikelina could comment. All the while Nikolai knew his steps weren’t nearly as crisp as normal. It wasn’t until his uncharacteristic sloppiness started to affect Brandi’s ability to move cleanly that Mikelina stopped them to give instructions. “Tonight at open session, if it isn’t crowded work on the Argentine Tango.”

“Can we take a break tonight? We need to do laundry,” Brandi answered.

Mikelina frowned. She wasn’t used to having her orders challenged. Nikolai didn’t know whether to second Brandi’s request or warn her to not question their coach.

Mikelina inclined her head, “*Da*, skate weekend.”

Nikolai groaned internally.

“Is she trying to make me burn out?” whispered Brandi. Her brown eyes were serious and questioning.

Unfortunately he didn’t understand her question. He shrugged.

“Enough for today,” said Mikelina.

Nikolai dropped his hands immediately and skated towards the boards. He grabbed his blade guards and put them on. Brandi dropped down beside him on the bench.

“Are you mad at me?” she asked.

“No.”

“Wow, English.” She bent over to unlace her skates. “Did I get us more skating time by asking to have tonight off?”

Nikolai didn’t honestly know. It might have been his lack of crispness. He shrugged.

“If I did, I’m sorry.”

Mikelina and Yuri walked over to stand in front of them. “Brandi must take ballet classes,” said Mikelina.

Yuri muttered in Russian about the unconventional ways she moved.

“I’ve already had four years of ballet.”

Nikolai jerked his eyes to hers. She stared back at him. Brandi bit her lip. He could see she was doing it as much to contain herself as anything.

“I’ll find somewhere to enroll in classes next week,” she said, pulling off her skates. She dropped her gaze down to the floor.

Yuri and Mikelina nodded and moved away.

Brandi didn’t look back up. Instead she dropped to her knees in front of him. “You’re bleeding.”

“*Niet*.”

Nikolai pulled his foot back out of her reach. His blisters were bad. It was all he could do to keep from limping when he walked. And it had affected his skating. She sat on the floor and dragged her skate bag over toward her.

“I have some Band-Aids.” She reached for his sock, peeling it down with furrows forming between her delicately arched eyebrows.

“Is nothing.”

She ignored him and pulled out a tube of ointment and dabbed it on his popped blisters. Nikolai closed his eyes, leaning back on the bench. He sat

up when he felt her tugging at his other laces.

"I do it."

"Do you have blisters on this foot too?" she asked.

Niet. No."

She didn't stop though. "Liar," she said when she had removed his other sock.

Nikolai didn't know what to do to stop her. He was more or less paralyzed. He couldn't move or stand up without his dilemma becoming readily apparent to everyone. Her fingers brushing his ankles and removing any article of clothing, no matter that it was only his socks, was playing havoc with his libido. He wanted to thread his fingers in her silky brown hair, and bring her up for a kiss. He was a fool.

He could have had that. He could have had her, but he'd been caught up in concern that she was too vulnerable. What difference did it really make? Maybe he was so tired he wasn't thinking straight either.

"Nikolai, are you okay?" She still had his foot in her hand.

Niet. "Am okay," he answered instead. "Thank you." He pulled his foot back and set it on the floor. She watched him her brown eyes wide and full of concern. He wanted to reach out and touch her face, her hair, her neck. He closed his eyes and swallowed hard.

"I'll be right back," she said. "I'm going to talk to Mikelina, and then I'm going to bring the car around to the door. You just stay here."

"I walk," he said, but she was gone.

He pulled clean socks from his bag, faintly surprised they were there. He must have put dirty ones on yesterday, because he knew he hadn't found any clean ones to throw in his bag this morning. He had regained control of himself and laced on his athletic shoes, by the time Mikelina and Brandi walked back to him.

"New boots," he told Mikelina in response to her question. But she would know that he always chose to break in new boots at the beginning of the summer, so they would be comfortable by the time the season rolled around. He just didn't usually combine it with the double skate time.

Brandi reached down and grabbed his bag, before he realized what she was doing. She pulled out his stained sock triumphantly. Nikolai snatched it out of her hand and stuffed it back in his bag, zipping it closed.

"No skate this weekend," said Mikelina, folding her arms across her chest.

Nikolai felt like he'd been caught with his hand in the cookie jar. "*Da*," he said tightly. He wheeled to the door and walked out and started down the sidewalk to the apartment.

He heard Brandi's running footsteps before she caught up with him.

"What is wrong with you? I'm trying to help."

Nikolai struggled with a translation. "Do not use me to stop skate."

"I'm not. It's not you who needs the work. It's me. There's no reason for you to tear up your feet, because I need the skate time." She swung around in front of him, walking backward and staring up at him.

"Partners skate together. You need skate. I need skate."

She was flushed. "I'm not trying to stop the ice time, but I need to get a job, or I won't be able to pay for this. I can handle ten to twelve hours on the ice, but I can't pay for it. I promise I will work my butt off to get to your level, but I only have a few hundred a month coming in from my parents to support my skating. It's going fast. We'll need costumes and traveling money. Now ballet money." Her eyes shifted down to the hot sidewalk.

She was still wearing her skate outfit. Her bare midriff and the bright turquoise outfit might not be appropriate for a stroll through the streets of Detroit. Her car was back at the ice rink. He turned around and headed back to her car, at least they could turn on the air-conditioner for the few short blocks it would take to get home.

"Where are you going now?" she asked, sounding exasperated. "I'm just as dedicated as you, damn it!"

"Car," he said succinctly and stopped. He waited for her to join him. He wanted to wrap his arm around her waist, but he knew what the feel of her bare skin under his hand would do to him. Instead he reached out his hand.

She tentatively slipped her hand in his and gave him a watery smile.

"Feet hurt. I am sorry."

"It's okay. Nice to know that you can admit pain."

Nikolai heaved a sigh. Some of the sparkle had gone out of her voice. He didn't want her to lose that. He liked the way her eyes shined when she put her skates on the ice, no matter how tired she was. He liked the way she would complain for thirty seconds and then she was done, ready to move on to the next challenge. He liked the way she attacked each new step, and repeated it until she had it down. She often insisted on practicing some move their coach was content with, until she was satisfied they were performing it right.

She was not Russian that was sure. She didn't have that deep darkness of soul that Russians carried around all the time. She didn't seem to understand that failure was possible. Or that if one thing failed there wasn't another equally good or better option to try.

He wondered if he seemed gloomy and fatalistic to her. Failures were part of the process. He was content to put aside for another day a move that wasn't working. He expected pain. It was part of the package. She didn't like it, although she dealt with it when she had to. "You skate after hurt knee. I skate with..." he nodded at his feet.

"But that was an accident. This is different. There's no reason for you to be skating when your feet are bleeding. My knee wasn't going to get worse with skating. It was just a bruise. We are not in the season. It might be different if we were, but we're not."

He squeezed her hand. Fortunately, she didn't say anything more until he had finished translating in his head.

"Brandi."

"Mmm?"

"Talk slow."

She frowned.

"I think Russian. Listen, you say. Inter-int"

"Interpret."

"Think answer in Russian." He frowned, knowing he would make a hash of the word again.

"Is translate an easier word for you?" she asked.

He nodded. "Translate to English. Understand?"

"Yes. I talk too fast."

"Too much," he corrected. She could talk fast if she just wouldn't say so much at one time.

She gave him a crooked grin. "That's usually an insult, Nikolai."

"Did not—"

"That's okay. We'll put it down to cultural differences. If you get your dirty clothes together, when we get back to the apartment, I'll make a run to a laundromat after lunch."

"I go."

"Whatever," she answered, unlocking the car door.

He shoved his hands in his pockets. Otherwise he would have reached out and pulled her hips back against his.

It was even worse at the laundromat. Once they had their dirty clothes in a line of washing machines, she had turned on some music on her phone and started telling him her vision for a dance to the song.

“Like a May Pole I could have a bunch of streaming ribbons on my gown. You know, a program with a kind of young, carefree feel. I bet we could modify one of your costumes and mine to match, by using ribbons. You’ve got something in pastel colors, don’t you? Or tan pants with a white peasant style shirt. We could have it embroidered to match my ribbons.” She gestured across her upper chest.

Nikolai watched her. The music she was playing was very western. Celtic sounding. “You mean fertility dance?”

“Well, yes. I suppose that is part of it. I was thinking more May Day celebration.” She scooted around behind him and dropped her hands to his hips. “I have this vision of us circling through each other. I could drop down and skate through your legs like this, and then you do it. I really think we could design a dance that is very equal. I think the circular pattern could make a really cool theme for the dance.”

She shouldered through his legs, and Nikolai caught his breath.

“Now you would do the same thing.”

His shoulders brushed her thighs as he followed her instructions. She hardly noticed, and he was having trouble controlling his response. She grabbed his hands and spun in a circle pulling him with her. “Don’t you think it could work?”

“In Russia May Day is for celebrate workers.” He folded his arms across his chest. He scanned the room. A young mother held a toddler who goggled at them with wide eyes. The mother gave him a tired smile. Brandi continued to watch him, obviously waiting for a sign that he found her idea at least interesting.

“You don’t like the music?” she asked, her bright expression falling.

Nikolai didn’t want to take the joy from her eyes. He just had a suspicion her idea would go over like a lead balloon with Yuri. Nikolai didn’t have any talent for choreography, and Tatiana had been too much of a follower. She had wanted to be told how many millimeters to tilt her head. While he knew that he preferred moves to come naturally, he had never questioned the judgment of his coach and choreographer. “Is not me.”

She stared at him watching him. Her gleam hadn’t disappeared; it had turned into a glare. It occurred to him that he wanted the western flavor. He

wanted to explore a dancing style that wasn't strictly Russian. It hadn't occurred to him that Brandi would be so different about coaching and choreography. That she not only wanted, but expected, to be involved in the learning and creative process. It had startled him and Mikelina the first time she had suggested they should work on something different than his coach suggested.

Nikolai knew his coaches worked for him, but he also believed you followed their dictates blindly or you moved on. Creative differences were often fatal to a coach/skater relationship. Or were they?

"I wish become more American, but Yuri might not like. He does all dance."

"It's not American music. It's Irish or something."

"Not Russian," he said, chucking her under the chin.

"No it's not dark and broody. It's light and airy, about having fun."

"Yuri very Russian. I not know him react. We try it, *da*?"

"Yes," she said enthusiastically. Her scowl transformed into a smile.

Nikolai wanted to pull her into his arms, and kiss her, but she was so relaxed, and suddenly so open he couldn't jeopardize that. All because he had given her an assurance that he wasn't interested in doing just that, or anything that could follow. He closed his eyes and turned from her, knowing that he wanted it all. Dances, caresses, kisses and practicing the moves to make new little skaters.

He didn't want to return to his old apartment and the lumpy couch, knowing she was just a few feet away, knowing that if he had been less noble he could have crawled into bed with her tonight. He could have peeled off the leotards that concealed so little and so much. He could have tasted her skin with its golden American tan. He could have pulled her shapely legs around him and sunk deep inside her, but he'd told her he was uninterested in that sort of thing with any woman.

And that made her relax for the first time in his arms.

~~*

Seven days later Nikolai felt even worse. The scheduled appointment with the immigration lawyer Alexei had told him about finally rolled around. Other Russian ex-patriots had used the man, but Nikolai hadn't found what the lawyer said particularly helpful.

Five years.

Five years of residence before he could become a US citizen. He'd been in the United States for half a year, but that still left four and a half years. It would be too late for the next Olympics. What would Brandi say? He knew she wanted to compete in the Olympics. There was only one other option. Nikolai rubbed his hand over his face. He stood on the sidewalk, waiting until Brandi arrived to pick him up. She had dropped him on her way to her afternoon ballet lesson, and said she would be back to pick him up in an hour and a half. It had been nearly two.

Three years. It would squeak them by in barely enough time. The lawyer believed he could expedite the process, especially if they did have a chance at qualifying for the Olympics. No bureaucrat would sit on an Olympic dream. But there wasn't anything he could do to shorten the length of stay requirement. Too many people wanted to become Americans.

If she would even consider it. Oh hell. He didn't think he could ask her. The more he paced, the more he worried. And she thought he was gay. Where was she anyway?

He saw her little compact car turning down the street. She pulled to the curb just beside him and reached over and opened the door. He slid in.

"Sorry, I'm late. I got a job. It's in a party supply store, part-time in the evenings and weekends. He said competing was no problem. The owner even said he'd sponsor us with a hundred a month if I carry a skate bag with his store logo on it and I do a radio promo for him. Isn't that cool? It's just a few blocks from where we're at. Except I really need to find my own apartment. How did your meeting go? What did the lawyer say?" She glanced over at him as she pulled to a stop at a light. "Nikolai?" She squeezed her eyes shut. "Okay, I'll start over."

She started running back through what she had told him item, by item, giving him time to interpret. He didn't stop her, even though he had caught nearly everything she said the first time. He was actually starting to be able to think some rudimentary thoughts in English.

Her repeat was a breather, time to consider what he would say. Although it was impossible for her to contain her natural enthusiasm. She launched into telling him how easy it would be to be to work so close and she could get helium-inflated balloons at cost. He had no idea what they would need balloons for.

"So what did the lawyer say?" she finally asked again. "What's wrong?"

“How bad you want compete in Olympics?”

“It’s a dream. I’m afraid to say it out loud. I’m afraid I’ll jinx it. Can you become a US citizen in time?”

“*Da*, one way.”

“Oh good! You were starting to worry me, with that gloomy expression.” She reached out and grabbed his arm, squeezing. “This is a great day. I found a good job. I won’t make a lot of money, but the sponsorship will really help. I mean it’s almost better than earning more. It is better than earning more, because I won’t have to pay income taxes on it, and the record store gets a tax break on the donation too. You can become naturalized. Let’s go grab a pizza for dinner, what do you think? I feel like celebrating. My treat.”

“Pizza?”

“You eat pizza, don’t you?”

“Have one time.”

“Come on, if you want to be an American you have to eat pizza. Should I change?”

Her brown hair was caught in a bun and she had on a short-sleeved leotard with a skirt. Her shapely legs were bare and he could see she wore thin pink leather ballet flats. Dance clothes. She looked damn good to him.

“Look pretty.”

She flushed, and Nikolai watched in fascination as the pink stain swept across her cheeks.

“Maybe, I change, *da*? I should change,” he said.

“Oh, of course. You probably don’t want to eat pizza in your suit. We’ll swing by the apartment. I’ll throw on some shorts.”

Nikolai raked a hand through his hair. Ask her, he told himself, but he couldn’t make himself form the words.

“If we hurry, we should have time to eat, and then I’ll drop you at your English class. How did you get there before I came? I’ll be working evenings starting tomorrow. I won’t be able to drive you. Do you have a license, Nikolai? You could probably take the car.”

“I get license soon. Take bus.”

She pulled into a parking spot in front of their building. She grabbed her bag and was out of the car in one fluid motion. Nikolai stared at her. She shut the door and was halfway to the door, before she swiveled around.

“Are you coming?”

“*Da.*” He reached for the door handle and felt it slip under his sweaty hand.

“Hurry, Nikolai. We don’t have much time.”

Nikolai slowly climbed out of the car and pulled off his suit jacket. Every day counted. He couldn’t put off this decision. Three years. He was just going to ask for three years. He would go along with whatever she wanted after that. He was sweating in the bright June sunshine. Brandi was holding the glass door with the half flaked-off gold letters. Nikolai moved toward her as if swimming through water.

“Why are you looking at me like that?” she asked when he finally reached her.

He shook his head.

She gave him a shrug and started up the stairs. She ran up in front of him, unconscious of the way his eyes followed her every bounce. Nikolai ran a hand over his face. He had no idea how she would react.

“Are you feeling all right?” she asked, turning around at the top of the stairs. She looked down on him, concern radiating out of her warm brown eyes.

Niet. “Okay,” he answered. He wanted her answer to fit in with his hopes, his dreams, his fantasies.

She took his word at face value, although she gave him a frown that made him think she didn’t totally buy his assertion that he was okay. “If you don’t like pizza, we could grab some burgers and fries.”

“I become American. Eat pizza,” he answered, walking down the hallway towards their apartment. Funny he’d started thinking of it as their apartment, even though he was still on the couch, and she was still ostensibly his guest.

“Well, hey, you can’t get any more American than burgers and French fries.”

“French fries?” he asked, wondering why she considered French fries and pizza American foods. But maybe he was missing the point. As far as he could see Americans would claim credit for anything the world at large considered beneficial. He shook his head. Did he have a hope that she would say yes?

He went straight to the kitchen and reached for a bottle of cognac he kept there. He poured himself a half glass and drank it like a Russian. He stared at it, wondering why he had taken refuge in a Russian drink. He

should have reached for a Coke, or he should be like an American, fearless and bold. He expected her to say no.

“Are you ready, Nikolai?”

He looked at her as she stood in the doorway of the kitchen, her fingers combing through the hair she had let down. She had put on a bright yellow tee shirt and jeans shorts with rolled back cuffs.

“Nick is more American sound?” he asked, setting the glass next to the bottle on the counter.

She shrugged, the yellow tee shirt moving across her breasts. “I kind of like Nikolai,” she answered.

Just ask! “You wish much Olympics, yes?”

“You already asked me that. In plain English, yes, I dream about going to the Olympics.” She gave him a perplexed look.

“Brandi, will you marry me?”

Chapter Five

Brandi stared at him, uncertain she had heard right. She stared at his blue eyes. Her gaze shifted to the glass on the counter and the bottle he had poured the drink from. "But you're...you're gay. Do you realize what you just asked me?"

"*Niet*. Am ask for marry me. Marry right word, *da*? Mean for wedding?" He stared at her and waved his arm in the air, the way he tended to do when he couldn't think of the English words he wanted.

Her emotions swirled like an untied balloon let loose. Her heart leaped into frantic overdrive. She needed to sit down. He stood there in his white shirt and tie, looking so formal and masculine. His dark hair and pale skin cried for her touch. She had been trying so hard in the last few days to make sure she touched him, so he wouldn't think she was bothered by his sexual preference. She had been trying to suppress her yearnings that hadn't accepted his declaration.

But marriage? What was he saying? Why? They had been together a little over a week and a half. Admittedly they didn't spend much time apart. They took all three meals together, skated in each other's arms for several hours, slept a few feet apart from each other, with only one thin door separating them. One thin door and one huge difference in lifestyles.

"Speak English, I don't understand you. I think you just asked me to marry you."

"I did," he said, moving a step closer to her.

Her eyes shot to his, trying to read the blue. He looked sincere. What did she know? He was a Russian. He had a totally different code of behavior. Maybe in Russia they married virtual strangers. Maybe they married women to hide their gay lifestyle. Something wasn't clicking here. She looked away. "I need to sit down."

His hand snaked out and caught her elbow. "Brandi?"

"Why?" she whispered, but her mind was tripping along at a furious pace after the brief blank screen.

Because of the Olympics? He'd asked her twice how badly she wanted the Olympics. He'd been to see the lawyer about becoming naturalized. Three years. Like the balloon she completely deflated. He needed to marry a US citizen. Oh God. A marriage to another man probably wasn't going to help.

His hand at her elbow was sending pulses of heat through her. She dropped her eyes, unable to meet his. "This is the only way to become a United States citizen in time?"

"Yes."

"How long?"

"Three years after marriage am eligible." His hand turned palm up and one shoulder lifted.

"Then we're done?"

Nikolai's hand tightened on her elbow. She wanted to jerk away. She wanted candlelight and romance. She wanted promises and here-ever-after. She wanted him to at least want her as a lover. How did her dream of ice dancing in the Olympics compare to her fantasies of a fairytale wedding?

"If what want," he said. He moved closer to her in the tiny kitchen. The warmth of his body, the masculine scent of him, already so familiar, but so unfamiliar clouded her thinking. He didn't know what he was saying obviously. What she wanted was for him to be straight and asking her to marry him because he was in love with her. No, she didn't want that. She hardly knew him, had barely made it past her desires.

"A career choice. If I say no, will you find someone who will say yes?"

Nikolai tried to swallow. It was like he'd been swallowing broken glass, his throat was so raw. She couldn't say no. He hadn't thought of asking anyone else. When he'd asked the lawyer if there was another way, and the man said marry a US citizen, Brandi's image popped into his brain. The lawyer said the marriage had to be real. They would be interviewed together and separately. Friends and family could be questioned. If there were any hint that the marriage was a sham, he would be kicked out of the process.

A skating partner would know him inside and out. If they continued to live together, they would surely know each other's personal habits. And he wanted to be her lover. He hadn't considered any other option. He tried to consider it now, but the thought actually repulsed him. "*Niet*."

"If I say yes, what does that mean?"

It meant they would be married. Man and wife, what was she thinking? Why wouldn't she look at him? "We do soon as can."

"It would be a marriage in name only, then?" she looked at him then. Her brown eyes were wary and flat.

Niet, niet, niet. His stomach fell leaving a gaping hole in his gut, or at least it felt like a gaping hole. He didn't want a marriage in name only, but

could he afford to be choosy? “If what want,” he forced himself to say.

Change the rules later. He already knew she wanted him. She just still thought he was gay. He wasn’t quite sure if he should tell or show her differently. And now or after she was his wife? He stared at her, realizing he was thinking of her as his future wife. Soon he would be able to think of her as his. In the minute, his reason, the goal of competing, flew right out of his mind.

“No, Nikolai. That is not what I want.” She wrenched out of his hold.

Well good, it wasn’t what he wanted either. He grabbed her shoulders and turned her. Her eyes sparkled with unshed tears. His heart turned over in his chest.

“Brandi.” He looked for the words to tell he would be more than happy to let their marriage be real. It certainly had to appear real to Immigration and Customs Enforcement or he’d be deported and his visa revoked.

The glitter in her eyes made him gentler than he would have been. He brushed his lips across hers, the contact meant to soothe and reassure her. His pulse leapt at the minimal contact. Heat fired his body, and he barely resisted the impulse to crush her against him, wouldn’t have been able to stop it if she hadn’t jerked away. She swiped her hand across her mouth.

“Don’t,” she hissed at him. “Don’t think that because I said what I said, that you can use *that* to persuade me.” Her breasts rose and fell with quick angry breaths. Nikolai couldn’t help but look. He wanted her so bad it hurt. He wanted to carry her in the next room and bury himself deep inside her, but she wasn’t done talking.

“If we do this *thing*, it will be a business deal. There will be nothing between us, and I expect you to have enough respect for me that you will be discreet about any affairs you might have. As far as sex between us, there’s no reason for it.”

“I have no affairs,” said Nikolai. “Marriage must be real. Lawyer say —”

The upward curl of her lips was as unlike a smile as could be. “You discussed this with the lawyer?”

She shook her head before he could answer. “Three years is a long time. You’ll forgive me if I am only willing to promise to be discreet.”

That was close enough to a yes that he wasn’t about to argue with it. Besides he never expected pots of gold at the end of a rainbow. He expected to slog through the mud to pick up a bit of gold dust here and there. A

chance at a gold medal was a good enough reason to keep slogging forward. A lot could change in three years. No reason to worry if the mud looked like it was over his head. Hell, just thinking things could work out was enough American optimism for now. "You will marry me?"

"I'll think about it," she said before trouncing out of the kitchen.

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Brandi slammed the bedroom door and flopped across the bed. She angrily brushed tears from her eyes. His light kiss had sent her over the edge. Why had he gone and done that? Was he showing her, he would fulfill his obligations as a husband no matter how distasteful he found it? Well, if she were going to do this thing, she wouldn't tolerate his lukewarm kisses. She deserved a man that truly desired her, not one who probably had to close his eyes and think of...men.

As distasteful as the thought was, she needed to keep reminding herself of that. She hoped to high heaven he was serious about offering fidelity. If she actually had to witness him...dating another man... She couldn't even think about it. Worse, what if they were attracted to the same man—assuming she'd ever get past being attracted to Nikolai. No. It was too unbelievable, too out of character, too humiliating.

A business deal. A marriage of convenience. A path to take that would pave their way to the Olympics. She'd kill one or the other of them if they didn't qualify. She had some conditions of her own to set. For one thing, no touching in private. Okay that wouldn't work. She couldn't think. She still had too many questions. She yanked the door open.

Why was it every time she walked out of the bedroom he was changing? Okay if they were going to consider marriage she couldn't act shocked or blush when she saw him in his black underwear. His blue eyes met hers across the room. He turned his back as he pulled his jeans up and zipped them. One side was just as bad as the other. Good as the other. She clenched her eyes shut.

"Where would we live?" she asked.

"Here."

"Together, like this? Shouldn't we at least have our own bedrooms?"

"No. Will need look like share." He shrugged. "Cheap live together."

"This was supposed to be temporary."

"Become citizen suppose easy."

“Supposed to be,” said Brandi pacing across the floor. “You have to start saying to be.”

“I work English. I much better than start.”

“I suppose you think we ought to share a bed.”

“*Da*, yes.”

Brandi walked the length of the floor. She knew he was following her with his eyes as he tucked his too tight tee shirt into his too stiff jeans. “Then we have to get a king-size bed. You stay on your side. I stay on mine.”

“Always?”

“There is no reason for us to do anything. We certainly aren’t going to want pregnancies interfering with our skating. You aren’t interested in women. I wouldn’t consider it any other way. There’s too much risk for hurt. I don’t want to get hurt. I want to be perfectly clear about why I’m doing this.”

“Will marry me?”

“I’m thinking about it.”

Nikolai’s smile seemed a little strained.

“Why are you doing it? You could probably find a decent Russian skater,” she fired back.

“Not match good like you. Want partner competes like you.”

“You’ve only seen me compete once, Nikolai. How can you know?”

“I get video. I see much before decide skate with you.”

That jolted her. She hadn’t known he was so serious about pairing with her for so long. “You did?”

“*Da*, yes.”

“Oh.” She plunked down on the couch, his bed. “How can you be so sure?”

“Feel in heart,” said Nikolai, sitting down beside her. He reached for her hand. He threaded their fingers together. “Will work. Brandi, I be good husband. I do what you want.”

She snatched her hand away. “This is a marriage of convenience. We can pretend in public, but when it’s just you and me, I want to be clear we are only doing this, getting married, to make it possible for you to become naturalized.”

“None else know.”

Brandi hadn't even thought about anyone else. She had been too wrapped up in the ramifications to herself.

"My mother will no like. She no learn English."

"We aren't going to tell our parents the truth?"

"No. Must be secret."

"Oh hell. What will I tell everyone when it's over? Oh jeez, we aren't ever going to be able to tell the truth."

"Maybe," he said skeptically.

Brandi peeked over at him. He had laced his fingers together and stretched his hands out in front of him, as if he was restraining himself. His expression was flat and distant. Every now and then she caught a look of anguish, hunger? She couldn't read it, or interpret what it meant. In those seconds he seemed so foreign and different. Her thought wasn't to recoil though. She wanted to probe deeper and understand.

"I suppose I'll have to learn some Russian."

His glance shot back to her, his eyes startled. His look was so intense she wished her suggestion supported a real engagement.

She shrugged. "A woman who loves her husband would make at least a token effort to please her mother-in-law. Do you think you could teach me some basics? I'll see if I can find a community college class this fall."

"Brandi, I do anything to make work."

Convert to heterosexuality? Was that like a religious conversion? Maybe he was mistaken. Maybe something had happened, and he felt like it meant more than it did. Certainly she hadn't seen him, making any effort to even talk to other male skaters, except Alexei. This time she didn't resist as he pulled her close.

"What excuse will we give when we divorce? I assume we won't break up our skating partnership."

Nikolai stroked her hair. "Maybe stay together. Maybe we happy. Maybe you have my child," he whispered softly.

Brandi ignored the pull of his words, even though a hot flush drifted down her body. She would not allow her emotions to be jerked around by that kind of scenario. She pushed back against the arm of the couch. She reminded herself how tepid his kiss had been earlier.

Tepid to him, temptation to her. She'd wanted to throw herself at him, feel the hard length of his body against hers. She wanted hard biting passion, and she barely got a gentle affectionate brush of his lips. She kept

her hand against his chest, keeping distance between them, and unfortunately reminding herself of his hard masculine strength.

"No. I won't stay in a sham marriage forever. I want to know how we will handle the end. I want to know how I can explain a split in a perfect couple, when it comes. If we do make the Olympics, it won't only be our families wanting explanations. We can't stage a huge fight, because that would break up our skating too."

"You say you learn husband gay." He shrugged.

She could tell the shrug was forced. She could feel the tension under her fingers. His face was closed, and he looked forward. He didn't want that knowledge made public, but for some reason he was willing to risk it.

"I suppose we've got three years to come up with something better," she said.

"*Da.*" He turned to her and said something in Russian. He smiled when she shook her head. "Will you marry me, Brandi?"

"*Da.*"

"*Da.* Yes?"

"Yes. I do. I will. *Da*, jeez. I thought you might appreciate me answering in your native language."

"Thank you," he said, putting his hand over hers where it still rested on his chest changing her pushing him away into a romantic thing.

"When do you want to do this?" she said, withdrawing her hand.

"Tomorrow."

"I'll call tomorrow and see what we need to do. I suppose we'll have to settle on hamburgers and fries. We don't have time for pizza before you need to get to school now."

"I play hook—hook—"

"Play hooky? Not on your life. You have to speak English better. Maybe if you could have said play hooky without help."

"But celebrate you say yes *to be* wife."

"Oh God, I'd rather forget," she said, grabbing her car keys off the coffee table, and moving towards the door. "Brandi Petronof sounds too weird as it is."

Sounded fine to him, but he supposed that was what he got when he tried to use a colloquialism. And of course it would be Petronova for her in Russia anyway. "Wish change name? Make American?"

“No, of course not. This is temporary remember. Besides I’ll still compete as Brandi Yeats. And I’ll just go back to that when it’s over.”

Nikolai suppressed his frown. One step at a time. He’d get the ring on her finger, and then he’d worry about correcting his erroneous impression. “Rings.”

“We’ll take care of it tomorrow.”

For a guy that wanted to become an American, he was sure choosing a Russian way of doing it. Sleeping beside her, but not touching her, or kissing her, or making love to her was going to be a nightmare.

He suppressed his feelings of guilt. He was the one suffering for it anyway. And just a second ago she had said she wouldn’t consider marriage if the circumstances were different. He didn’t know if that was true or not. He wasn’t particularly willing to risk it. She had also said their marriage would be convenient. If things didn’t change drastically, it would be damn inconvenient.

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Brandi called first thing in the morning and learned there was a three day wait after applying for the marriage license which meant the soonest they could be married was early next week. So after their morning skating session they drove downtown to fill out the paperwork.

Nikolai deferred to her in filling out the form, but he had his arm around her when he wasn’t digging out his passport or answering a question. She asked the questions and managed to schedule the wedding mid-morning at the clerk’s office next Tuesday.

“We go for get rings?” asked Nikolai as they left the oppressive atmosphere of the government building.

“Let’s just do it tomorrow,” said Brandi. “I’d rather go home and rest before I need to leave for work.”

He nodded and shoved his hands in his pockets. “In Russia, sometimes takes many months to get appointment.”

“I guess it’s a good thing we’re not in Russia.”

He smiled at her, making her realize how tense she really was. Even the impersonal congratulations from the clerks had made her feel like blurting out, but it won’t be real. And the pretense wasn’t over. She needed to call her parents.

Nikolai put his arm around her waist and steered her toward her car. She realized she’d been standing on the sidewalk, chewing on her lip. He

was silent as she drove home, but he watched her like he had something on his mind.

"It's not too late to reconsider," she said softly as she pulled the car into a parking space in front of their building.

"You not marry me?" His blue eyes drilled her, and he rubbed his hands against his jeans.

She looked down, giving him a moment to consider.

"Brandi, I wish marry you. Are you say no, now?" The roughness in his voice betrayed concern.

She pulled the keys out of the ignition. "I'm not backing out. I just want to know that you've thought this through, because thinking things through isn't always my strong point."

He started to answer when a tap on his window startled her. She looked up to see Nikolai's friend Alexei standing beside the car.

She forced a smile she didn't feel onto her face.

Nikolai opened his door. He barely managed to get out a greeting before Alexei began speaking in a torrent of foreign words.

Brandi frowned. Alexei usually spoke English unless he was translating for Nikolai.

"*Niet*," said Nikolai.

"*Da*," answered Alexei.

Then Nikolai repeated, "*Niet*."

Brandi rolled her eyes. No, yes, no. Not that understanding that part of the conversation was very helpful.

Nikolai threw his arm around his friend's shoulders and led him to the building entrance leaving Brandi to follow. Brandi watched the two men. Nikolai's dark head bent down next to Alexei's blond one. Their conversation in Russian continued as they moved inside the apartment.

Alexei plopped on the couch and buried his face in his hands.

She moved inside the front door and felt like an outsider. After shutting the door she edged along the wall, not knowing if she should leave and grant them privacy to discuss whatever was upsetting Alexei, or stay.

"Would stay him? I get drink for," Nikolai gestured to his friend and she nodded.

Alexei scrubbed his face and looked up at her. His pale eyes were rimmed in red. "I am sorry to be rude and talk in my language. How are you, Brandi?"

She moved to the chair next to the couch and sat down. "I'm fine, but you're not."

"My partner Vera gave me bad news today."

Brandi waited to see if he would share it with her, but instead he stared across the empty living room. She searched her mind wondering what his bad news was. She had met Vera briefly in Lake Placid a few weeks ago at the ice dancing training sessions. As Brandi remembered Alexei and his partner had turned professional and had signed with the Ice Stars for the coming winter tour.

Brandi frowned. Alexei had often spent the mornings working with Nikolai's abandoned partner Tatiana, but when Vera arrived he always moved to skate with her, while Nikolai had left Lake Placid early.

"You are still staying here? I thought you would have found your own apartment by now," said Alexei, forcing Brandi out of her speculation on the disaster to befall Alexei and his partner.

"She stay here now," said Nikolai, handing Alexei a glass of what she suspected was cognac.

"Is Vera sick?" asked Brandi remembering that there had been some concern when Vera missed some of the morning sessions at Lake Placid.

"Not exactly," answered Alexei. "I can not believe she does this, now."

"She is have baby," said Nikolai, moving around in front of her to sit on the couch.

"Is it his?"

"No! Do you not tell her anything?" asked Alexei.

Nikolai winced, and Brandi felt the beginnings of an uneasy suspicion form in her mind.

"I should insist she have an abortion," said Alexei.

"You can't do that!" exploded out of Brandi.

Nikolai frowned at her, while moving to sit back down beside his friend. "Is common in Russia."

"But even there it is surely the woman's choice. You can't just tell a woman to have an abortion." Brandi shuddered.

"It is too late. She did not tell me until it is too late. I thought she was eating too much," Alexei muttered. "We have no money, and if we make mess of this contract we never get opportunity again."

"Oh, come on. It's not that bad," said Brandi.

Nikolai frowned at her. She noticed that he had put his arm back around Alexei's shoulders.

She stood up feeling out of place, uncomfortable and...jealous? Her eyes flashed over Alexei, surely not. She'd liked him when she first met him. He had seemed kind, explaining Nikolai's frustration with Tatiana and then skating with her when Nikolai refused, although Nikolai could have continued to skate with Tatiana through the seminar. Since Kevin paid for his spot, Brandi felt obligated to skate with throughout the rest of the training. Nikolai had remained partnerless rather than skate with Tatiana.

But surely Alexei wasn't...not that Alexei wasn't a nice man, but he wasn't *that* attractive, and he certainly wasn't pretty. Oh jeez, Brandi didn't know what to think.

"But since you're skating professionally, you don't have to do all the lifts, you just have to choreograph programs that aren't dangerous to her. I'm sure Vera can skate through most of her pregnancy."

"No, you no understand. Her doctor says she must not. She not skate, I not skate," Alexei said. "This is how it always goes."

"Well there is another solution," said Brandi, staring at the way Alexei rocked on the couch and Nikolai spoke softly to him in Russian, rocking with him.

"Maybe, maybe Tatiana could fill in." Brandi hardly knew what she was saying. She just knew she didn't like Nikolai comforting his...friend. He had promised he wouldn't...

"Niet," said Nikolai.

Alexei looked up at her.

"Did Nikolai tell you we're getting married?"

"Brandi, is not time," said Nikolai.

Alexei turned to Nikolai and threw his arms around his neck and kissed him on the cheek. Brandi couldn't take any more. She grabbed her keys and rushed to the door. "I think we need some groceries." She scooted out the door ignoring Nikolai's call, ignoring the fact that she had less than twenty dollars in her purse, which she had of course left on the coffee table.

She was not going back for it. She rushed down the stairs. She'd beg for an advance at her new job first. Or surely she could dig enough change out of her car's ashtray to buy a half-gallon of milk. Or a bag of flour, or a box of Jello. She'd roam the aisles until she found something she could afford.

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Nikolai watched his future wife unlace her skates. The Saturday practice session was short, because the rink would be open to the public much earlier in the day. He should have stopped her yesterday when she ran out of the apartment in the middle of Alexei's congratulatory hug and enthusiastic *friendly* kiss. He had yet to see American men exchange the kiss on the cheek the way Russian men did.

He knew that she had thrown out a challenge to Alexei because of her suspicions. He didn't know whether to be grateful she fled the scene or chase after her, but he hadn't thought he could contain his amusement. The last thing he needed now was to laugh at her mistake that was brought on by his stupid pretense that he was gay.

Admittedly her actions puzzled Alexei, who had accused him of having a house like a full cup. Holding to the rules, he'd agreed with Alexei. He couldn't tell anyone the truth of their marriage either. He hadn't realized how much it would bother him.

They could have a real marriage as soon as he corrected his lie, perhaps, but he had a healthy dose of superstition about jinxing it now that they already had applied for the license and the ceremony was scheduled.

Yesterday afternoon, Brandi had returned with a bag of flour and a box of margarine and said she intended to make cookies. He hadn't pointed out that they didn't have a cookie pan. She had acted embarrassed and in a hurry to get to her new job.

"Would get rings?" he asked.

"Yeah, we might as well," said Brandi, stuffing her skates in her bag and not looking at him.

"Alexei very happy for us. He wish tell you."

She stared at him with startled brown eyes. "He is?"

"Alexei is friend." He closed his eyes and searched for the right words. "Only friend."

"But he...you...aren't?"

Nikolai shook his head and drew in a deep breath, ready to tell her the truth.

"That's good because I'd rather not know, but then I'm not sure I would do this any other way."

Nikolai let out the breath. "What mean?"

“I mean the more I think about it, the more I’m glad you’re the way you are. It’s better than us becoming involved together in a temporary marriage, and having all those other issues to work out. I’m sure we’re more likely to remain friends this way. You know, I didn’t like the idea at first, but now, the more I think about it, the more I’m sure that it is better this way. And we’ll be young enough to get married again. I mean I will be young enough.”

No, it was definitely *not* better this way. Now he didn’t dare risk telling her the truth. But there was no way he could pretend for three years.

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Chapter Six

Brandi moved to the counter with Nikolai trailing after her. He seemed lost in another of his deep dark moods. “We want to look at wedding rings,” she told the clerk.

Nikolai moved behind her and put his hand on her waist. Heat moved out in radiant spikes from his touch. For the thousand time, she wished he was a heterosexual male, and he was touching her because he desired her. It’s an act, an act, an act, she recited in her head. She had to somehow start thinking of him like a best girl friend.

“Will you be needing an engagement ring, too?” asked the clerk as she pulled a tray of rings out from a glass display case.

“No. Where are the prices?”

The clerk showed where the little white tags were discretely tucked under the rings.

Nikolai’s hand shifted against her back. “Would want engagement ring?”

“What’s the point? We’ll be married on Tuesday. We only need some simple bands.”

“Excuse us, moment,” said Nikolai.

The clerk looked back and forth between them.

“She can’t leave the case out,” pointed out Brandi.

“We be back,” said Nikolai, pulling her out of the store into the walkway of the mall. He turned her to face him. “Want engagement ring?”

Brandi felt heat rise on her face. “No, I don’t need one.” She’d like to save some of the rituals for when she really got married some day. “Besides we can’t really afford one. We should just get the cheapest wedding band set that we can find.”

“You no worry. Get what want.”

No, she wouldn’t get what she wanted. She wanted a real marriage. No, she didn’t. She wanted Nikolai to want her. The marriage thing just confused everything. The concerned way his blue eyes searched her face confused her more. No, no, she wanted to compete in the Olympics and hear the Star Spangled Banner played. That was why she was here, buying wedding rings with a taciturn man who was nearly a stranger but would be by her side day and night for the next three to four years.

“Must do what...expected. What parents say? Three year notice cheap ring.”

“Okay we’ll get fourteen karat gold bands, but just simple ones.”

“Is what would do?”

“We can always tell people we plan to replace them when we turn pro after winning a medal.”

“Or I promise you diamond when get world Bronze.”

“Bronze? I want gold.”

His smile made her feel like melting in a puddle at his feet. “I not dream too big.”

“What’s wrong with dreaming big?”

He touched her cheek. “Not get cheap. I pay for nice ring. Others notice.”

She nodded. They walked back to the counter and looked at the bands. Nikolai stopped her when she kept looking at the price tags. He removed a ring with embedded diamond chips and pulled her right hand over to him and started to slide it on her ring finger.

“That’s the wrong hand.”

He blinked, shook his head slightly. “Is right hand, *da*?”

“No it isn’t.”

He held up both her hands in his and lifted her right hand a little. “I say wrong? Is right?”

“Well, yes it’s the right hand, but it’s the wrong hand.”

He scowled at her.

“Wedding rings go on the left.”

“*Niet*.”

She pulled the ring off her finger. “This one is too expensive. What do you like? The white gold one here is nice.”

“What white gold? Is silver?”

“It’s gold, just not yellow.”

“I know not yellow.”

The clerk plucked out a man’s ring and handed it to Nikolai, “Here try this one.”

Brandi grabbed his hands as he slid the ring onto his right ring finger. “Nikolai, wedding rings go on the left hand.”

He met her eyes and something passed between them. A current of heat that struck Brandi down to her toes.

“At home is right hand.”

She dropped her gaze and concentrated on the rings. His simple sentence said it all. This was not his home. Russia was. This was not his lifestyle. She was not his woman, although he could scorch her with a single look.

The clerk tried to make small talk, asking him where he was from and how he liked the states, while Brandi scanned the rings and asked if all the matching sets included engagement rings.

Nikolai leaned close to her ear and whispered. “Want match, get engagement ring.”

The clerk blithely replied that the engagement ring didn’t have to be included. Brandi nodded and picked up a simple band with an engraved border.

“Oh these are on sale. Forty percent off,” said the clerk.

Nikolai reached around her as she slid the smaller ring on her finger. “Is like?”

Brandi nodded, unable to speak around the lump that was forming in her throat. Nikolai tried the larger ring and put it on his left hand this time. He put her smaller hand over the back of his where they could look at both bands together. The heat from his body fed into hers. She wanted to lean back against him and bask in his warmth.

“Well, they both fit.”

“Is strange. Would put ring on you right hand some day.”

She froze unable to look at him or the clerk.

Nikolai’s voice was a little lower as he told the clerk that they’d take them. He wrapped his arm around her, trapping her in his embrace as he removed his ring and handed it to the clerk.

Not that she wasn’t used to being in his arms, but this wasn’t in the middle of a rink.

The clerk replaced the tray and locked the display case taking the rings to a cash register.

“Is okay?” said Nikolai.

Brandi nodded. What had he meant? Or were the words an act for the salesclerk? She thought of the day he proposed and had suggested that she might have his baby. She assumed then and now that he just meant he might want a child and would need a woman to give birth. That he might be able to get over his distaste for the act long enough to impregnate her.

He turned her in his arms, his hands on her shoulders. "I would be what want."

He was probably talking about the rings, but the words seeped into her and gave her hope. Course it didn't take much to make her start thinking things could be better. Eternal optimism could be a curse sometimes, especially when she thought about the obvious pitfalls of attempting the conversion of a sullen gay man, who barely spoke English into the kind of husband she dreamed about.

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Nikolai enjoyed the view as Brandi bounced up the stairs ahead of him. She just didn't seem to be able to resist the lure of speed on stairs. He smiled, not that he minded the sight of her athletic legs bounding up the steps. And climbing behind her, he could look to his heart's content, and she would never notice.

She turned around and caught him. He raised his eyes to hers. She tilted her head sideways and her brown eyes were puzzled. He wanted to shout that yes, he was a normal male, but if she really meant what she said about not being willing to go through with this if the circumstances were different, waiting until after the marriage was legal seemed more sensible.

"Did you hear something?"

Besides the echo of his blood pounding in his ears? No, someone probably could have fired a cannon behind him and he wouldn't have registered more than the thought that he wanted to have her tan legs wrapped around his waist, his hands on that cute behind of hers, his body joined with hers. "*Niet*," he answered.

Brandi's eyes widened, and Nikolai wondered if she realized the state he was in, that the mere thought of slipping the wedding ring on her finger and the normal accompanying husbandly rights left him hard as a rock, and his condition was getting more difficult to conceal.

"Kevin," she squealed, and her feet hit the stairs briskly churning back down the steps.

His heart skipped a beat as she neared him near the mid-flight of the stairs. He wanted to reach out and grab her to him, to believe that she was flying into his arms. Only his name wasn't and never had been Kevin.

Nikolai turned as she hurtled herself at her former skate partner, throwing her arms around his neck. Kevin grabbed her around the waist,

lifting her from her feet and spinning her around in the tight space of the bottom landing.

“What are you doing here?” asked Brandi with far too much happiness for Nikolai’s liking.

Yes, what was he doing here?

“Is time for to hear good news,” said Nikolai. He regretted the words as he saw some of Brandi’s joy flit away.

Kevin looked back and forth between them and said, “I came up for the weekend to see the campus at Purdue, but after I saw the hall where I’ll stay, there wasn’t that much to see. Besides it’s only a little over a four hour drive, so I thought I’d come up and see how you’re doing. Your mom gave me the address, and she wants you to call her.”

“I need to,” said Brandi with a touch of grimness around her lips.

“I tried calling, but I didn’t get an answer. Man, I’m beat. So you’re still staying here with Nick? How you doing, Nikolai?”

“Am good,” said Nikolai, wondering how long Kevin would stand there with his arm around Brandi. Of course Brandi didn’t look like she wanted to move and her arm was around Kevin’s waist. “Would come in?”

“Yeah, come on up, but don’t expect much. Your dorm is probably more exciting. Gosh, I can’t believe you’re here.”

“It’s good to see you again, Brandi.”

Nikolai could see the extra squeeze that accompanied that statement. He wanted to tell Kevin to take his hands off of her, but the reaction would startle both of them. Brandi certainly wouldn’t expect jealousy from a man who had no reason to stake his own claim.

Kevin didn’t know that they would be married in three days.

“Can I crash here with you, or are you going to make me drive back to Indianapolis tonight?”

Brandi’s eyes grew wide, and she chewed her lip.

The words were alarming to Nikolai too, but he suspected he didn’t understand. “What mean crash?”

“Sleep over. The floor’s okay with me,” said Kevin.

“Can sleep couch,” said Nikolai.

“Yeah, sure, of course you can,” said Brandi in a patently bright false tone. She gave Nikolai a what-are-you-thinking kind of look.

He shrugged. She would have to share the bedroom with him, like any normal about-to-be-married couple would. It wasn’t as if they weren’t all

adults here. Although Kevin was barely one.

Surely, she didn't intend for Kevin to share the bedroom with her, or him for that matter. Nikolai wondered, not for first time, about the level of intimacy between Brandi and her former partner.

"So how's the skating going?" asked Kevin, as they moved toward the apartment.

"Is good." Nikolai unlocked the door, the plastic bag containing their rings in his hand.

Brandi finally dropped her arm from around Kevin's waist.

"Where put these?" Nikolai held out the bag.

"I'll put it in the dresser," she snatched the bag from his hand and trounced into the bedroom.

"Excuse me," Nikolai said, following Brandi.

He shut the bedroom door. "Will tell him?"

"How are we going to work this with him staying the night?" She opened the top drawer of the dresser and stuffed the bag inside, closing it with a hip.

"I sleep here with you tonight. Must look real to all. I not tell Alexei that marriage is for citizenship. You no tell Kevin."

"Great. I haven't even told my parents yet."

"Is phone," said Nikolai crossing his arms and nodding to the phone sticking out of her purse.

She cast a half-hearted glance at it, gave a tiny shake of her head, and moved to the door. "We're being rude."

She opened the door.

"Wow, guys. This place only has one bedroom. I don't have to stay. I just figured that—"

"Is okay, Brandi marry me."

"Really?" Kevin looked back and forth between them, his expression flitting from stunned to curious. "That's fast."

Brandi looked down, and Nikolai slid his arm around her waist. "Is just decided."

"I guess that means you won't be my date for homecoming, huh?"

"We'll be competing," said Brandi in a small voice.

"When go California?" Nikolai didn't understand what they were talking about.

“No, not home to our home. It’s a fall football game and a dance,” said Brandi, moving to sit down in the chair beside where Kevin sat on the couch.

Nikolai felt foreign and out of place as both she and Kevin understood the reference. Brandi hadn’t looked directly at either one of them since he’d announced their wedding.

“Would like drink? Is tea or—”

“A glass of tea would be great,” said Kevin.

“Me too,” said Brandi.

Nikolai shook his head and walked to the kitchen. When he got there he put his head in his hands and leaned against the counter. He wanted to storm back in the living room, pick Kevin up by the scruff of his neck, and toss him out of the apartment. On the other hand, his presence meant Nikolai would share the bedroom, if not the bed with Brandi. And that was reason enough to let the kid stay.

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Her stomach churning, Brandi watched Nikolai move down the small hallway until he turned into the small kitchen. Was his determination to tell Kevin about the pending marriage revenge for the way she had blurted the news to Alexei? She still couldn’t forget the way the two men hugged, and that kiss. Admittedly the kiss was on the cheek, but still.

“Are you okay?” whispered Kevin. “He didn’t like...force you or anything.”

“No it’s not like that,” said Brandi. She made herself smile even though her lips seemed weighted at the corners. “It’s just that I know it must seem ridiculously fast. I mean he asked, and I said yes.”

“Are you sure it’s not just...well, you know...just lust? I know you, Brandi. I know that you don’t like sleep around and maybe you’re thinking it’s more than what it is.”

“Trust me, it’s not that.” Well, maybe there was a little of that in why she said yes, but lust on his side was definitely absent. And there wasn’t going to be any of that in their marriage anyway.

“Well, you are in love, aren’t you?” Kevin looked at her with a seriousness that belied his age. Of course he wasn’t thirteen anymore. And he no longer took her blanket assurances at face value.

Brandi’s face heated. “Well yeah, of course I am.” In love with the idea of skating in the Olympics as an American. When she looked at it that way

she felt like she'd prostituted herself for her dream. Of course she wouldn't be called upon to play the role any further, but that thought was more repellent than comforting. The least that should happen when you sold yourself for a goal was that the buyer wanted to sample the wares.

She shook her head. She absolutely had to get her mind out of the gutter. She had to start thinking of Nikolai as no more interested in sleeping with her than a donkey would want to make it with a sheep. Nikolai and she were entirely different breeds, when it came to that.

Nikolai entered the room with glasses. He handed one to her and one to Kevin. Nikolai's movements were jerky unlike his usual smooth glide. So he felt awkward too. Of course she had a suspicion based on the short time they were together that he expected her to play hostess, although he hadn't commented when she told him it was his turn to do dishes. But since she'd been dividing the kitchen chores in the middle, he probably was willing to accept her decrees for division of labor. It only occurred to her now, that there had been a flair of surprise in his blue eyes when she put in her drink order a minute ago.

"Thank you, sweetheart." She nearly choked on the endearment. Why she had chosen sweetheart for a man that was more often dour than sweet she couldn't have said.

She needed to convince Kevin that all was well. If not, his curiosity was liable to cause her problems. She stood up and slid her arm around Nikolai's waist. He responded by pulling her against his side so tightly she put her other arm around his waist. "Did you know that in Russia people wear their wedding rings on the right hand?"

Brandi could see Kevin shake his head out of the corner of her eyes. "That bag was holding wedding rings?"

Nikolai turned to face her. She continued to hold on, hoping he would play along. He did, better than she could have hoped.

He raised one hand and cupped her jaw, sliding his other hand up her back and pulling her against his tall frame. Brandi sucked in a deep breath as her breasts encountered the hard wall of his chest. His blue eyes held hers as a soft flow of Russian words slid over her as he bent his head down and kissed the side of her neck. Her heart pounded in a mad cadence, and the language of his words didn't matter. She could pretend they were the words she wanted to hear, as his dark hair brushed her cheek. She breathed

deeply of the scent of him and wanted to stay locked in his solid, tender embrace forever.

“Uh guys, if you want me to leave just say so.”

Nikolai backed away a step. A soft sigh of disappointment escaped her lips, embarrassing her with the neediness of the sound.

“*Niet*. I go, so you talk before Brandi work.” Nikolai’s blue eyes were bright. “Would need food, *da*?” He was probably making fun of her escape yesterday.

“Hey, let me take you guys out to eat to celebrate.”

Brandi floundered. She knew the ground was there somewhere. If she kept stretching out her toes she would find it. The problem was she wasn’t sure if the ground was below her, or she had already pitched ten thousand feet down to a place that was well underneath it all. Either way she felt ridiculously giddy.

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Later after Brandi returned from work, Nikolai went to the bedroom to allow her a chance to talk with Kevin. He lay back on the bed on top of the covers anticipating the coming night with dread and a hungry eagerness that had no place and would have no reward.

He wondered if he should get up and take a cold shower. He was forestalled by Brandi swinging through the doorway.

“Kevin wants to watch us practice in the morning. When I told him we practice at four, he said he wanted to turn in. So I’m going to take a shower now instead of in the morning when we’re all trying to get ready.”

So much for cooling down in a cold spray of water. Nikolai looked at the clock beside the bed and saw that it was nearly nine-thirty. They would all need to be up in six hours. He had already given the blanket and pillow he normally used on the couch to Kevin.

Pulling the remaining pillow down over his lap, he leaned up on his elbows as Brandi pulled an oversized tee shirt from the dresser. “Would want I sleep floor?”

She turned her big brown eyes in his direction. “No,” she said slowly. “We don’t have another blanket, and I’m sure the floor would be too uncomfortable.”

Given his condition and her impending nearness, the bed might be worse. “*Da*.”

“You’ll just stay on your side, and I’ll stay on mine. It’s not like anything would happen anyway. Just like a slumber party with any other friend.” She gathered her clothing and left the room, closing the door on her way out.

Nikolai pulled the pillow off his lap and gingerly removed his jeans. He groaned as the shift of material against his engorged flesh almost hurt. He wanted her more than he knew how to handle. He removed his shirt and slid under the covers in his underwear.

Using the willpower and determination that had made him a world-class athlete, he forced his brain to other matters. Even if Brandi was open to an intimate relationship, he couldn’t bury his flesh in hers the minute she crawled into bed. Like any woman she would need to be seduced, kissed, caressed, explored, treasured, fondled, reassured... “*Niet*,” he told himself sternly.

He made himself think of Alexei’s problem. Vera’s pregnancy ought to temper his own desire. If he and Brandi were to make love and he made her pregnant, the whole purpose behind their marriage might be in jeopardy.

The thought gave him pause, even if it didn’t particularly cull the desire. Poor Alexei had always been plagued by bad luck. When he and Vera took third in the Russian nationals they were unable to compete at Worlds because Alexei broke his foot. The next year Tatiana and Nikolai bumped Alexei and Vera down in the rankings, although with Tatiana’s falls in major competitions, the other couple would have had a better shot at ranking. The falls had another consequence in putting at risk how many slots were available to the Russian team at the international competitions.

Nikolai and Tatiana had made it to Worlds twice, but had proved an embarrassment for the Russian contingent. Just before he’d broken the partnership with Tatiana giving Vera and Alexei another shot at the last Russian slot, they had renounced their Olympic eligible status to turn pro. Another streak of bad luck in Alexei’s case, and now as they were on the verge of a professional season that could mean the difference between steady work for the next few years or scrambling for fill-in spots.

The door opened and Nikolai stared as Brandi darted in. She dropped a handful of clothing on the floor. He crossed his feet at the ankles to make sure the bedspread didn’t reveal his arousal, which was again aching as he watched his future wife rub her head across the dimly lit room.

She shed the short robe and underneath was a towel wrapped around her and tucked in between her breasts. He sucked in a stiff breath and closed his eyes willing down the painful need. He opened them again to see she had turned her back to him. She sat down on the far edge of the bed. He started to ask her what was wrong, when he could see her hand's reflection in the mirror over the dresser. His ability to speak was temporary halted as he watched her tug at the twisted edge of the towel.

The towel slipped slightly, and she held it up with one hand pressed flat against her chest. He willed the towel to fall with every fiber of his being. He wanted to see the soft curves he had caught in his hand on more than one occasion. She twisted to look at him, and he shut his eyes rather than allow his curiosity and hopeful interest to be blatantly obvious.

Not that he would keep his eyes shut more than a second. He peeked. She was sliding her tee shirt over her head, her arms upstretched. The towel pooled around her hips. His eyes sought out the part of her he wanted to see.

He watched the material slip down over her perfect breasts, catching slightly for a half-second on the nipples and then skimming down over the under-curve. He wanted her, her wanted to pull the nightshirt up and look, touch and taste to his heart's content. He wanted her more than he'd ever wanted any woman. This woman who was soon to be his convenient, but untouchable and inconvenient wife, he wanted more than he wanted anything else.

He must have made some small sound because she twisted to look at him. He blinked. He needed to think with his brain. He wanted his skating to succeed. Ice first, fire melting the ice would be a major problem. He had to think of more than his own desires in this partnership. He had to make sure that Brandi's needs were met too. A successful skating partnership had to be strong on mutual respect and understanding.

"I thought you were asleep."

"*Niet.*"

"I couldn't change in that dinky bathroom. I bumped my head on the wall again."

"Is okay?"

She stood up and gathered the towel off the bed. "It's not like I should treat you any different than a girl friend, right?"

Niet, but then again, he didn't mind being given the opportunity to look.
"Is no problem."

"Right just a sheep, goat thing."

He had no idea what she was talking about.

She pulled back the covers on her side and slid in with a wary trepidation that didn't bode well for him making his sexual preference known to her with any hope of success.

He groaned under his breath. Sleep was a long time in coming. But of course his eyes popped open the minute he heard her move. He watched her tiptoe across the bedroom, slide open a drawer and pull out clothes. She sat gingerly on the edge of the bed and pulled off her tee shirt with a jerky haste. She struggled into her bra, quickly, too quickly as she got a strap twisted and struggled to fasten it.

He sat up and reached for the strap. "I help."

"You probably need to get ready."

His fingers brushed the skin of her back and with a strength of purpose he wasn't sure he could exercise, he kept himself from leaning over and pressing his lips against her shoulder. He fastened the bra and patted her shoulder. "Is good."

"Thank you," she said brightly. "You better get up and moving."

He couldn't get up, or he was already up but his condition would be far too obvious. The alarm beside the bed started to buzz.

She shut it off. She grabbed socks off the pile of clothes on the bed and pulled her foot up to pull one on. He groaned.

"You should have gone to sleep earlier," she said. "Come on Nikolai, get up. You need to wake up Kevin."

"You do."

"No, I can't. I'm not dressed yet. After all he is a normal male and I can't be parading around in my underwear in front of him."

No, just in front of him.

She padded across the room in her socks, and he followed her movements with his eyes, hunger burning in him.

She put her hands on her hips and turned to face him. "Nikolai!"

"Da, I up." He couldn't take much more of this, and he couldn't get out of bed until she turned around. Which she finally did to open the door and call out to Kevin. He scrambled out from under the covers grabbed his jeans and yanked them on with his back to her.

Two more days of this torture and he was done with it. He would stand by his promise to let her dictate the terms of their marriage, but he'd be damned if he sat by and let her treat him like he was an androgynous drone. He raked his hands through his hair as he tried to make his brain work.

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“Oh hell!”

Not exactly the first words he hoped to hear from his new bride. Oh well nothing was conventional about his marriage. He could hope it meant his swift kiss at least affected her a little. She was walking away from him, her skirt molding her cute—well he wanted to be cupping his hands around there while he leaned down for his kiss, but a warning flashed in her eyes and kept him from indulging in a vulgar display. But he had slipped the simple band on her finger, a minute before, and followed the bare bones vows in English.

“Mom, Dad, what are you doing here?”

Nikolai's curse was in Russian, fortunately. He shook his head and followed his wife to where she had crossed the floor to the waiting area. He took in the sour look of the woman in a pale lemon linen suit and the salt and pepper hair of the man in a suit. They both watched him cross the room. The woman alternated between looking at him and Brandi, and the man looked more directly at him. Neither one of them gave him the slightest sign of welcome. He resisted the temptation to shove his hands in his jeans pockets. Fortunately the clerk stayed his execution by handing him the license and shaking his hand.

“Did we miss the whole thing?” asked the woman.

“Oh the whole thing only took five minutes,” said Brandi with too much brightness.

Their voices echoed across the empty space.

He maneuvered up beside her, sliding his left hand with the certificate around her waist. He prayed his English wouldn't fail him. On the other hand maybe it wouldn't be a bad idea if it did. Perhaps he should have been better prepared to meet his new in-laws after hearing Brandi repeatedly telling them last night on the phone there was no reason for them to come for the wedding. He supposed somewhere in that long drawn out conversation she must have given the particulars, when and where.

“Relax,” he whispered in her ear, dropping an affectionate kiss on her hair, as if their hurried wedding had been a pure love match.

She had to have inherited her determination from someone. Nikolai looked between her two parents and wondered which one. The silence had gone on so long he could have translated most of an encyclopedia. He thrust out his right hand, pulling Brandi tight against his side. "Hello, I am Nikolai. I am pleased to meet you." Basic English. Almost the first words he learned to speak.

Her father grabbed his hand just before he was about to lower it.

"Welcome to the family, Nick." He covered his hand with his other, shaking warmly. "I'm Brandi's father. Is it Petronof?"

"*Da*." Brandi's nudge prompted him to say, "Yes."

Her mother took his hand. She patted it, holding it instead of shaking it. "Oh yes, this is just such a surprise."

And another delay in telling Brandi that he wasn't gay.

"I am happy you come," he said.

Brandi frowned. He nudged her. She pasted on a big smile that was obviously fake.

"Well," said her mother.

"We have dinner, *da*?" He knew his nervousness was making his accent worse than normal. His have sounded like heb. He was frowning now too.

"Why that would be lovely," answered Brandi's mother. "But did you two have plans? A honeymoon? I didn't know if you didn't want us to be here, if you had some place you needed to leave for." Her voice trailed off.

"No, Mom. I told you, we have to train tomorrow morning."

Nikolai turned to Brandi. He wasn't sure what a honeymoon was, but he was pretty sure he knew what the word meant. Russian custom dictated time alone for a bride and groom too. But that was usually after the families were invited to the wedding feast and allowed to participate. "We take parents to dinner, *da*?"

"*Da* means yes. The first time I saw Nikolai in Budapest he kept saying *niet, niet, niet*. It was driving me crazy. *Niet* means no. He had a different partner then."

"I not marry her. Brandi better," Nikolai said to interrupt his bride's nervous chatter.

"No, Tatiana's a much better skater than I am."

"I not love Tatiana," he said sharply.

She stared up at him, her brown eyes widening. She slowly blinked. Nikolai was torn between offering a demonstration of affection in front of her parents and not offering a demonstration of affection in front of her parents out of respect for them and concern about propriety.

His head started to spin with the ramifications of any action. And her lips parted as she stared up at him, her pupils dilated. From fear? Nervousness? Anticipation of another kiss? He doubted he could keep a kiss impersonal. But she had to relax or her parents would never believe this marriage was real, and if they didn't, the whole thing could be lost. He settled for brushing her hair back from her face.

"Well, we won't keep you two long, but dinner would be nice. So you two didn't just meet at Lake Placid. You've actually known each other longer? Bucharest was over a year ago, wasn't it, Brandi?" said her mother.

Brandi was blushing. Nikolai stepped up. "*Da*, we meet in Bucharest. She watch skate. I watch her."

"Skate," added Brandi hastily. "He watched me skate."

Nikolai smiled. She was giving her parents the wrong impression. Actually maybe it hadn't been so wrong. He had gone out to watch her, and been surprised at her ability and toughness under pressure.

He been totally impressed with the way she saved a fall. Her partner's grip had failed, and she had caught his leg, instead of reaching down for the ice. She'd even had the presence of mind to avoid placing her hand on Kevin's boot garnering a deduction. Really, if it wasn't for Kevin's expression of horror, the move might have worked. But he hadn't expected to see a great skater when he watched her. He had simply been intrigued by her. But the way they had noticed each other then offered a decent explanation for their haste.

"Perhaps you could show us your apartment, and we can decide on a restaurant to eat," suggested her mother.

He felt her tightness under his arm. If she wound any tighter she was going to start shaking or spinning out of control like a top.

"Did you take a taxi?" asked Brandi. "How long are you staying? Our apartment is really small."

"We rented a car at the airport," answered her mother.

"We won't intrude on your privacy. We planned on staying at a motel. Is there one close to your place?" said her father with a shake of his head at Nikolai.

Nikolai felt like protesting. It wasn't like privacy was likely to be any advantage to him, even if Brandi was attempting to give that impression.

"Why don't we follow you two back to your place. We can spend a little time getting acquainted and then go out to dinner," said her mother.

"*Da*, this is good. Brandi?"

She dragged on his arm, holding him back as her parents went out into the hallway towards the main elevator. "No, we can't," she whispered. "I can't let them see how we live." She called out louder to her parents. "Maybe we should just check you into a motel, first, Mom, Dad."

He caught her around the waist and pulled her back against him. He smiled at her father as he turned around to see them. "Apartment is temporary, *da*?" he whispered in her ear. "Not ashamed. Mother, Father think ashamed of me."

"Okay," she whispered.

"You follow us to home. Brandi worry is small," Nikolai said as he led Brandi to join her parents waiting for the elevator.

"Ugly," she added, earning a frown from him.

"We skate much time. Not there much. Is temporary," he added a shrug.

"It's economical," added Brandi.

"Reminds me Moscow," he said. He released his bride. She was ashamed of his apartment. "Brandi teach me appreciate America." He sure as hell hoped he'd managed to say that word correctly.

"And will you teach her to appreciate Russia?" asked her mother.

I doubt it. He shrugged. "*Niet*. I become US citizen."

"I don't know. I wouldn't mind visiting someday," Brandi said, wrapping her arm around his and leaning into him.

Nikolai found her hand and laced their fingers together. He stared down at his new wife for the entire ride down. He looked up as the elevator doors opened and caught a knowing smile being exchanged between her parents. Whew! They'd passed the test. Brandi had the anxious eager newlywed act down well enough to fool her parents. Wasn't much of an act for him. He was anxious and eager.

And it seemed eternally damned to live in a perpetual state of frustration. How could he spring the truth on her with her obvious nervousness around her parents?

"Well, this isn't so bad," said her mother as he led them into the apartment.

Her sniff wasn't quite so generous, but she was trying. Brandi on the other hand was standing out in the hall as if she couldn't face showing her parents their little place. He remembered her reaction the first time she had seen it. He had felt like apologizing then too.

"I'm sure that first flat we had on Elm was smaller, wasn't it, honey?" said her father.

Brandi's mother said, "Oh much. It was a studio."

That didn't mean anything to him, but he'd ask Brandi later if she ever decided to come in the apartment.

"Would like cognac?" asked Nikolai, wondering what was appropriate. "Or is tea." He hoped there was tea. Brandi usually had a pitcher in the refrigerator. But things had been rushed the last few days with the marriage arrangements and no breaks in their training or classes or her work.

"If you point us, Nick. I'm sure we can take care of drinks for ourselves. I think your bride is waiting," said her father.

"I'll just powder my nose," said her mother.

Nikolai flushed as Brandi's parents left them alone. Only Brandi was still standing out in the hall. "You can come in, Brandi," he said, passing the doorway. "They have get drink." Or at least her father had, Nikolai wasn't sure exactly what her mother was doing to her nose.

Brandi had her face in her hands. Was she that embarrassed? His stomach started to burn and his fingers curled into fists. Her parents had to wait on themselves because she wouldn't come in their apartment, and he was expected to coax her in or something.

"You don't know, do you?"

"That you embarrassed, and my English bad."

"Oh, Nikolai, that's not—"

"You hide face. Not come in. Shut door. You let hot inside." Please let her come in. He didn't know how he would make conversation with her parents when she insisted on standing out in the hallway.

She looked up and her eyes were filled with amusement. "Come here. You need to learn an American custom."

"What?" he asked flustered. She wasn't embarrassed?

"You are supposed to carry me across the threshold."

"What is threshold?"

She crooked her finger at him.

He'd had it. He crossed the living room in determined strides, picked her up, tossed her over his shoulder and closed the door. He didn't set her down in the living room, but carried her into the bedroom and dumped her onto the bed. "I show you Russian marriage custom."

He heard the bedroom door that he hadn't shut click softly behind him.

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Chapter Seven

“Bravo,” said Brandi, clapping her hands softly. She drew in a deep breath after Nikolai’s he-man display. “I’m sure we’ve totally convinced my parents we have married because we are in lust.”

Nikolai looked at the door blankly. One of her parents must have closed the door, while she was too busy staring at him, surprised by his quick burst of anger.

“Good reason for quick marriage,” he answered, sinking down on the bed beside her. He raked a hand through his dark hair.

“Oh, smooth move. Planning on messing up my hair, too? We have to get out there before they think we’re doing it already.”

“Maybe should do it.”

“You don’t know what you’re saying,” said Brandi, scooting off the bed.

“Brandi?”

His quiet voice stopped her. She turned slowly.

“You are ashamed I Russian.”

“*Niet*. I ashamed I’m lying to my parents.”

He smiled at her slowly. “Then we do it, so you no have to lie.”

“I’m going out there, before they think we’re rabbits or something.” She was afraid of staying in here arguing with him. Tempted she might give into his effort to make sure their marriage was real. She stared at him wondering why he seemed so damn determined to consummate their marriage. She wouldn’t give him away. She had as much riding on this as he did.

“Need look messy,” he said, grabbing her arm and tugging her down to the bed while lifting her onto the mattress in one smooth move. His hand stayed under her thighs, warm against her bare skin. The advantages of being a dancer. He could make moves that would be Neanderthal with another man, seem graceful, effortless, seductive.

He leaned over her, and she found her heart starting to pound. “Don’t,” she said, turning her head to the side.

“What mean rabbits?”

She made the mistake of looking back up at him. His lips found hers. There was more pressure, and her breath caught. His hand stroked against her thigh. She was so surprised by the slow invasion of his hand that she

opened her mouth for him when he pressed his advantage. He deepened the kiss.

Brandi spiraled in the warm wet sensations. She threaded her arms around his neck. He accepted her unspoken invitation, shifting his weight over hers on the bed. She flushed, hypersensitive to the heavy weight of him, the hard firm feel of his shoulders under her fingers. He pulled back, and she could feel the thundering beat of his heart, against hers. He brought his hands up and cradled her face.

“Don’t?” he asked, his blue eyes holding hers, asking if he should stop or not.

She stared up at him, confused by the rush of feelings. And well, the very obvious erection pressing into her. “You’re not gay.”

“*Da*, not gay,” he answered.

Her heart beating a million miles an hour, she scrambled out from underneath him. “You lied to me.”

“Yes,” he said, rolling to his elbow and watching her.

Brandi backed toward the door.

Nikolai levered himself off the bed. “Talk later. Parents wait for us.” he said.

It had been cowardly to tell her now when she couldn’t yell at him.

“Oh hell.” She felt like she was sliding off the edge of the floor, everything had turned upside down. “You promised me that we would have a marriage in name only.” She reached for the door handle behind her.

“*Niet*. I promise have marriage you want.” He closed his eyes a second—as if he were pained—while he reached over her shoulder and held the door shut. “What you want?”

“I want a marriage in name only,” she answered.

He held her eyes for a long time. “Behind doors, name only. Out there look real.” He nodded towards the door.

She felt almost bereft when he moved away from her. He yanked off his tee shirt. She watched the smooth ripple of muscle under his skin. “What are you doing?”

“Change shirt.” He yanked the closet door open and sent a hanger rocking as he pulled a white and blue striped oxford shirt out, and shoved his arms into the sleeves. “Change mind?” he asked as he turned around to button it.

Brandi shook her head slowly.

“Maybe tomorrow,” he said.

“Don’t count on it.”

“I count the days?” he asked.

“Oh, learn English, will you?” she muttered.

“No need talk...” he gestured to the bed. “I learn you.”

That comment had an unexpected affect on her. Her blood pooled in her nether regions. “Not on your life,” she snipped back.

This was not good, not good at all. How was she going to resist him for three years? How was she going to walk away from this heart whole and happy? She was too vulnerable.

He unzipped his jeans to tuck his shirt in. She wheeled out of the room, pulling the door shut. Her parents sat in the living room, her mother on the couch thumbing through her latest copy of a figure skating magazine and her father held a glass of what looked like Nikolai’s cognac.

“Your father and I were thinking we should get you and your new husband a nice suite for the night. After all, this is your wedding night.”

Great. Nikolai would probably take that as encouragement. Permission. Damn him. “Oh, that’s okay, Mom. It isn’t going to matter where we are.”

“Obviously,” added her father dryly.

Heat rose up her face.

Her mother gave her father a look that said, can it. “Well it’s the least we can do. Since we didn’t have to pay for the wedding.”

“No, Mom, really. We have to be at the rink early tomorrow. And Nikolai has classes, and I have to work later this evening.”

“You’re working on your wedding night?” asked her mother.

“I told you we just didn’t have time to make a big deal over this. We just wanted to get it done.”

She heard the click of the bedroom door behind her. She tried to will down her flush as Nikolai wrapped his arms around her waist. The hard length of his body pressed against hers and made fireworks go off inside her.

“Have decide restaurant?” he asked.

“We haven’t even discussed it yet,” said Brandi. “I know it’s early, but we do need to go soon. I need to be at work in a couple of hours.”

Her parents exchanged a glance that said they wondered about the lack of ceremony in their wedding.

“Is there somewhere nice to eat close?”

Brandi named off several chain restaurants.

"We should look up a nice restaurant in the phone book," said her father.

"Oh, Dad, I'll check my phone."

Nikolai let her go.

Brandi heaved a sigh of relief or regret. She wasn't sure which.

"I have gold book for to look in bedroom."

Her parents looked puzzled.

"Yellow book," she told her parents. "He knows gold, silver, bronze. The other colors he needs to work on." When had she started making sense of his halting English?

"Nick, this is good. Did you bring it from Russia?" asked her father following Nikolai into the bedroom where he apparently had stashed a phone book.

Her mother patted the couch. Brandi settled on the couch beside her mother. She nervously clenched her hands together.

"Nikolai seems very nice. Are you happy, dear?"

"Yes."

"This marriage seems awful sudden. You're not pregnant are you dear?"

"No...I...we...we've talked about having a child after the next Olympics." She flushed. It was sort of the truth. "He and I think we have a shot. He's a very good skater."

Her mother patted her hand. "I understand, dear. I was young once. But I'm more worried about what kind of husband he will make, than his skating ability. I do hope you didn't rush into anything."

I rushed into everything blindfolded. She wanted to tell her mother. But she had made her bargain with Nikolai, and he had seemed to promise to honor her terms. The purpose was still intact. It would be the only way he could get his citizenship in time to represent the United States. Besides she was an adult. "I seem to be making a lot of major decisions lately."

"You seem a little nervous, dear."

"I just got married, Mom. I guess I'm a little jittery. I'll be fine, and Nikolai is very understanding." Was he? Right now he seemed like an A-number-one jerk. She wondered how he was faring with her father's interrogation. Suddenly it occurred to her she should rescue him. She

looked at the bedroom, straining to hear individual words in the low murmur of masculine voices.

“Well, I tell you, I was very worried, but he obviously cares a great deal about you.”

He does?

“Oh, for heaven’s sake, Brandi, your father is not going to hurt him. Really, he’s just giving us a moment of privacy.”

“His English isn’t that good, yet.”

“You two don’t seem to have much of a problem.”

She couldn’t stand it. She popped up and moved over to the bedroom doorway. She winced as she noticed the obvious disorder to the putty colored bedspread. Her father was flipping yellow pages while her husband held the book open.

Her husband.

His blue eyes flashed to hers and her knees felt weak. Oh jeez, what had she gotten herself into?

“Dad say pizza not good with champagne,” he said, stretching out his hand.

She melted. He was suggesting pizza because they hadn’t managed it after the other night when she said that was what she wanted. She almost missed the half-smile her father flashed in her direction.

She crossed the room and took Nikolai’s hand. “I haven’t forgiven you,” she whispered as her father carried the phone book into the living room.

“You will,” he whispered back.

~~*

Brandi’s head was in a whirl when she made it to the party supply store later for work. After a couple hours of working the cash register, the manager Roger greeted her and called her back to the office. She wondered if she had done something wrong. Especially since her thoughts were on the shifting pattern of her hours-old marriage.

She didn’t even know what she wanted, let alone what she should do. Focusing on anything was impossible right now. She knocked on the open office door and stepped inside.

“Here. This came today.” He handed her a bag with the store’s logo emblazoned on the side.

“Wonderful,” said Brandi taking the bag from Roger’s hands.

He gave her a smile. "I hope it's big enough."

"It'll be fine." She would have carried it if it were only big enough to carry toothpicks. The bag, while not as big as she liked would certainly work. If she needed more space, she could stuff things in Nikolai's bag. "The sponsorship means a lot to me."

"I'd like you to start working closing."

Brandi felt caught as she stared at the short heavyset man. What choice did she have in setting her hours? She didn't want to work any later than her normal eight o'clock quitting time, not with needing to be on the ice at four in the morning. "How late will that be?"

"After the store closes at nine, whenever everything is stocked and straightened up. Normally takes less than an hour."

Now that she had married Nikolai, she felt much less comfortable asking her parents for more money. She felt uncomfortable asking anyway, since her parents had spent thousands on her skating career already, and she was of an age where she should be supporting herself. She needed this job. Really the extra hours meant extra pay and she could contribute more to the partnership. "Okay."

Last night Nikolai had been frowning over the figures of his bank accounts. He didn't wish to discuss it with her, and insisted he was only reviewing his budget to see if he could afford some things, not that there was any problem. She insisted with their marriage that she needed to understand their financial position. He showed her the rather tight budget he had worked out for living expenses. There wasn't a lot to spare, although the wolves weren't at the door yet.

But not included in his budget were expenses she brought to the table. Her dance lessons, her car expenses, her personal needs, not to mention the wedding expenses.

In more than one way she felt like the weak link in their partnership. He was a better skater. He had more sponsors, and he was sacrificing more than she was. She wanted to contribute more. Working more hours was one way she could.

"Don't worry, you won't be alone. I'll be here," said Roger.

She had probably been frowning. "I wasn't worried about that."

"Why don't you start working closings tomorrow," said Roger.

Brandi nodded. She was worried about once again getting enough sleep, although it wouldn't be too many hours on the ice. She wondered

what Nikolai would think. His reaction to her working hadn't been terribly enthusiastic. Although it didn't really matter what he thought, they needed the money.

Although when she returned home to the apartment telling him about the change in her work schedule was the last thing on her mind.

~~*

His wife wasn't pleased, but he was trying to make everything seem normal.

"I can't believe you said yes. All you ever used to do was say, *niet, niet, niet*. Now when I don't want you to, you start saying yes," said Brandi as she crammed clothes into her new skate bag.

"You no like, *niet, niet, niet*. I wish make you happy," answered Nikolai calmly, watching his flustered wife. He hadn't known how to respond to his new in-laws. But he figured they knew their daughter better than he did, and he was worried about giving them any reason to question the validity of his and Brandi's marriage. So he accepted their offer the third time they made it, before Brandi could respond.

"We're just wasting my parents' money. We didn't need a hotel room."

Her parents had already disputed this claim. They said, and he believed they meant it, that they wanted her daughter to have special memories of a special day in her life. If they could help by making her wedding night a little special, they wanted to do that. And the only argument that would persuade them otherwise, that it wasn't a special day, was one they couldn't voice. "What color you wear skate tomorrow?"

She looked up at him. Wisps of hair were escaping from her ponytail. Her cheeks were flushed with anger or embarrassment.

"Gold, silver, bronze?" he asked, letting a smile curl up the corners of his mouth.

"What difference does it make? You've never wanted to know before."

"We match first day marry. Parents watch."

"Fine," she said and pulled out her lilac unitard. "I'll get a black outfit."

He followed her to the dresser. She yanked out a black leotard and flesh colored tights. She started to pull out a black wrap skirt, but Nikolai pulled it out of her hands. He dug in her drawer until he found a red wrap skirt. He put the black skirt back.

"What, red for passion?" she asked.

"Black easy. Must look like we think to do."

He opened his dresser drawer and pulled out a red tee shirt and a black tee shirt with a red stripe across the center. The red skirt wasn't a good match with either. And the lighting in ice rinks could be incredibly harsh. Brandi stood beside him, looking like she was about ready to start tapping her foot.

"Move," she said, shoving him with her hip.

Nikolai backed up a step. He wanted to pull her closer. She bent over and pulled out her bottom drawer, where she kept her the oversized tee shirts she slept in. She yanked out a folded tee shirt. "Try this."

Nikolai unfolded it. "Just Do It" blazed across the front with a big red swoosh. The red was a perfect match with her skirt. He held it up against him. It would be a little tight. "This good. Thank-you. You wish follow what say?"

Her eyes widened and her jaw dropped for a tiny instant before she glared at him. "No."

"Is good advice," he said.

"It's a slogan."

"*Da.*"

"Why did you lie to me?" She folded her arms across her chest and stared at him.

"Make you relax. Like wood puppet when skate. You no stiff, again, *da?*"

"I don't know. I'm really mad at you."

"I know," he said with a shrug. "I wish have you. You no want to want. I wait until you want love."

"You might be waiting a long time. I agreed to a marriage in name only. We don't love each other, Nikolai."

He remained silent. He meant something different than what he had said. He'd meant make love. Three years was a long time. A long time to deny something you wanted. A long time to ignore desire. Enough time for what you wanted to change. He blinked, willing the thought down. Someday he would return to Russia. He suspected he would leave a part of himself here with her, but sorrow and suffering were what Russians did best.

Her eyes flashed to his. There was a question and confusion there. He reached out and brushed her hair back. He leaned forward and brushed a kiss across her forehead. "I wish say more, but English is bad."

He pulled her against him. She didn't resist for which he was grateful. He wanted to offer comfort, but her soft curves fanned a hunger he couldn't quench. He would wait until she wanted him again. "I no force you," he whispered against her hair.

"I know."

"We go now. Bring music to dance wish do, okay."

"Okay."

Later as they lay with their backs to each other in the motel bed, Nikolai stared into the dark. He reached for the lamp beside him, when he thought she had fallen asleep. He picked up the Russian/English dictionary and started reading.

"Can't sleep?"

"*Da*. Light make you awake?"

"No. What are you reading?" She rolled to her back beside him.

"English words."

She was silent a long time. When she spoke again her voice was tentative, "I had a love affair with my first skating partner."

"Kevin?" asked Nikolai, putting the dictionary down.

"No before Kevin. It ended badly. It destroyed our partnership. I don't want that to happen ever again." She rolled away from him.

"I not him."

"There's just too much at risk."

"Okay," he answered. He rolled back to put his book under the circle of light falling from the lamp. He took one of the extra pillows and put it behind him so the light wouldn't shine on her side of the room. There was a lot at risk, but they had agreed on a three-year marriage. He'd told her he would honor her wishes at the end of that. He wondered if that was a lie too. He didn't believe she would want him to be her husband forever. She was too embarrassed by his foreignness. She was too optimistic and bubbly to be pulled down by his dark moods.

She had recoiled when he suggested she might one day have his child. He wasn't even sure why he had said it. This marriage was for him to get his citizenship. He'd had no other reason for pursuing it. She'd agreed to it for that very reason, and obviously none other.

She flopped over to her side and sighed.

"I turn off light," he said.

“Niet. It won’t matter,” she said. *“I’m going to watch TV, if that’s okay with you.”*

“Okay,” he answered softly.

She tossed back the covers and padded across the room to the armoire. She opened the cabinet doors and turned on the TV. She stood flipping desultorily through channels. He watched her in her big tee shirt. His wife.

“Brandi?”

She turned around.

“Is something I can do help relax?”

“I’m just restless, Nikolai. Besides everyone will probably expect us to be tired tomorrow. That’s what you want.”

He tossed back his covers and walked over to her. She turned her back before he reached her. *“Yes, but I not wish you upset.”*

“You should have thought of that before you lied to me.”

“I think that. That why say I gay. You upset. I wish make you relax.” He put his hand on her waist.

“Why didn’t you tell me the truth before we were married?”

“Want marry you very much.”

“You mean you want to become a citizen in three years very much.”

“Maybe, not so simple.”

She drifted away from his hand. Nikolai turned away. He knew the light touch had provoked a problem. He’d thought he had better control of himself, but it was their wedding night, and she wasn’t ready. If they had any chance of making this work, there had to be trust. There had to be respect. He raked his hand through his hair.

He wanted to reassure her, and calm her nervousness. He just wasn’t sure how to go about it. The obvious thing, consummating their marriage, she opposed. *“I wish marriage to be real marriage. You are beautiful wife, but I honor you want. I respect you. I wish make happy.”*

“But, Nikolai, real marriages are based on love, not on making it to the Olympics.”

“Da,” he answered.

“So?”

“I promise not lie to you, again.”

She made a sound of distress. *“Just everyone else. We both have to lie to everyone else.”*

He turned around. *“Am sorry.”*

“Yeah, me too. I just thought maybe you were trying to tell me something.”

Was he? He searched his brain for the English words that meant less than love more than like. He wanted to tell her the things he admired about her, the things that drew him to her. Her sparkle, her determination, her impulsiveness, even her Americanness. He moved back to the bed and picked up the dictionary. He wanted to touch her, but he wasn't sure his control would hold.

“Much I would wish say. No know how,” he said, putting the book down. “Many things I like about you.”

She tilted her head sideways, watching him with her gentle brown eyes. She sighed. “Things have just been happening so fast,” she said as she crossed the room, pulled back the covers on her side of the bed and slipped between the sheets.

He closed his eyes thinking about her golden legs so close to his own. He wanted to peel back her underwear and see the true color of her skin, the contrast to her tan. He wanted to explore every inch of her delicious body. Things weren't happening fast enough. “Yes,” he said.

“I appreciate all you did to ease my parents' minds.”

He flipped through the dictionary to find the word ease. “You are welcome,” he said as he read the meaning. “I call Russia tomorrow.”

“I don't know anything about your family,” said Brandi. “Is your father...” she broke off and bit her lip.

“He is gone. I must tell my mother am married.” He wasn't looking forward to the conversation at all.

“Maybe you should teach me to say, ‘hello,’ and ‘I look forward to meeting you’ in Russian. Or if there is something else appropriate I should say. Will she be very upset?”

“*Da*. Russians are good at be upset. Expect disappointment,” he shrugged.

She flipped to her side and looked at him. “You don't.”

He frowned. He didn't? “*Da*, do.”

“No you don't. You keep pushing until things work out.”

“*Niet*, you do. You have American determination.”

“Ah that will be the secret of our skating success. I have determination, you have a Russian's passion.”

"I teach you passion. You teach me determination," he flipped hurriedly through his dictionary. "Op-op—this word," he said, thrusting the book under her nose, pointing to the word he was trying to say.

"Optimism. Are we talking skating here? Because if you are talking the terms of our marriage, that subject is closed."

Nikolai fell back against his pillow and put the book over his face.

"I'm impressed. You are using big words."

"Not help," he muttered.

"I don't know, Nikolai. We'll see when you can use them without looking them up every second.

He threw the book across the room. "Is not easy."

"No, I'm sure it's not. I don't think you were very loquacious in Russian either. You kept saying *niet, niet, niet* to Tatiana. Not much information there."

"You tease."

"Don't tell me no one ever teases anyone in Russia."

"*Niet*, we serious, serious..." he searched for a word to add onto that sentence. He fought to keep his lips from curling upward.

"No wonder you want to become an American so bad."

"I do this for you."

"God, Nikolai, I thought you promised you wouldn't lie to me, again," she said, her voice bubbling with amusement.

"I do this for us," he said. He rolled over against her. "I do this for me."

He found her lips with his thumb. He traced the soft shape of her lower lip. He was close enough that she could feel what she did to him. Her eyes widened. He levered himself up to an elbow and lowered himself to press his lips against hers. Her swift intake of breath, the instant before he kissed her made him lightheaded.

Her lips clung to his as he tasted her sweetness, but her palm pushed against his shoulder in a wary display of resistance that tore at him. He splayed his left hand against her cheek. He wanted her to think of the ring when he drew away.

Her brown eyes fluttered open, dark and questioning.

"This I do for you, Brandoosha." He rolled away from her to his side of the bed. "Good night, my wife."

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Chapter Eight

Brandi's arms and legs were on delay as if she was controlling her body from a remote. Her arms weighed more than normal, too. She hadn't slept more than twenty minutes before the front desk was calling with their three-twenty wake-up call.

"Parents here," said Nikolai, as he swept Brandi through a turn.

She dropped her head forward to his shoulder. She wanted to skate well for her parents, but she wasn't sure she could pull out her best performance with her sluggish body.

Mikelina and Yuri had eyed their outfits and frowned before offering lukewarm congratulations. Yuri had left angrily when Nikolai offered the MP3 of the music Brandi wanted to dance to. Her husband had remained firm on the issue even though Brandi was willing to forgo the idea.

Her husband. She couldn't get used to the idea, although he was making sure she was reminded.

He would hold her face with his left hand and make sure she could feel the gold band with a subtle shift of his fingers. He held her hand and twisted her ring on her finger. He even called her wife at every opportunity. He'd left her hungry when he turned away from her in the bed.

She felt a little like she'd gone through the looking glass backwards. She'd thought things were one way, and they were totally different. And she had no idea what she was looking at with Nikolai. Partner? Friend? Husband? Potential lover? All of the above? Or was he just a lying conniver? And if it had been his intent to trick her into marriage, why? And why wasn't he taking advantage of the situation. Her token resistance last night was surely transparent.

"We say hello, *da*?"

"Yes. I suppose we should." She didn't know if she wanted her parents to leave or stay longer. She didn't want to deal with misrepresenting her marriage to her parents, and she wasn't even sure what the truth was any more.

"Try look like happy," he whispered in her ear. He put his arm around her waist as they skated to the boards.

"Hi, Mom. Hi, Dad," said Brandi brightly as they reached the side of the rink.

"Hello, honey," said her mother reaching out to hug her, while she saw her father stretch out his hand to Nikolai.

“Wish thank you for room,” said Nikolai. His hand settled on her shoulder.

Her parents looked at the tee shirt he wore, and no doubt recognized it as one she wore to sleep in at home in California.

She looked up at him, and his blue eyes fixed on her indulgently. She gave him a wan smile before leaning her elbows on the edge of the barrier. “Yes, it was a treat. They gave us champagne.”

She didn’t mention that they hadn’t opened the bottle. It was outside in their car. They would take it home to their apartment and stick it in the refrigerator. She couldn’t figure out if it was waiting to celebrate their real wedding night, or if they’d save it for their first win in competition. That was what Nikolai said they could save it for when he pulled it out of the melted ice this morning.

Nikolai stroked his hand over her shoulder. She wished he wouldn’t do that. Or she wished she wasn’t so aware of the path of heat that torched from his touch and traveled down the length of her body. She wanted to get off the subject of the room and what they were supposed to have done there, and what they wanted everyone to believe they did there. What she half wished had happened there.

“We start work on new dance today,” said Nikolai. “But most work compulsory steps. Would like see?”

“Of course. We’d love to see you two skate together,” answered her mother.

“Brandi, would like tango?” he asked, his blue eyes questioning hers.

She nodded. She was too tired to wonder why he had picked the tango, other than red and black were obvious tango colors.

He called to Mikelina, introduced her parents, and then had a quick conversation in Russian. He pulled her back onto the ice. They needed to work on intros. He dropped to a knee. She tried to remember if she’d seen him and Tatiana use this start position before. She draped herself across his leg. Hey, she could fake it. He brought her hand up to touch his face.

“Look away. Tango angry dance.”

“I hate you, but I want to sleep with you,” she replied. She knew the mood of the dance.

“*Da*, I want for to sleep with you.”

“You have,” she said, turning her head away.

“Not way I want,” he answered. His eyes swept over her and returned to her averted face. “I think you be angry with me.”

The music started. He ran his hand over her body. She flinched. His touch was far too intimate.

“*Niet*. You know my hand.”

“I do not.”

“Do now,” he said as he caught her arm and pulled her around in a quarter turn of a modified death spiral. She managed to hold her position through sheer willpower. It must have taken a lot of strength for him to pull her around him in a wide circle from a dead stop. He hauled her up to a standing position, and planting her hand in the center of his chest, she pushed away from him. Her move surprised him, and he was out of position for the start of the steps. She started without him, ignoring him. Classic tango.

His blue eyes were amused as he caught her steps. She leaned deeply into her strokes, and worked with the speed and sharpness Mikelina and Yuri coached. Their hips were brushing as they performed the dance steps. She was too far forward when she went through the quick twizzle spin, but Mikelina’s sharp rebuke was buried under encouragement. She tried to think about her edges, but the heat of Nikolai’s hand, splayed against her back, distracted her.

They had traced through two patterns almost too quickly. Nikolai reached under her arms and held her against his chest as he skidded to a stop. She obliged by dragging one skate, the other boot across her knee.

“Nice, nice,” said Mikelina. “If start dance with that move, must make sure in position at the start of music. But is good look.”

She could hear Nikolai’s heart pounding under her ear.

“I screwed up the twizzle. We need to do it again,” Brandi said.

“Later. Want skate different, while parents here?”

“Yes.”

After skating practice, her parents took them to eat lunch. Nikolai aggravated her by not only resting his hand on her leg, but rubbing his fingers in a slow circle all through the meal, which she thought was carrying their charade too far. It was one thing to rest his hand on her leg, another to concentrate so annoyingly on making her aware of her refusal to consider making their marriage real. Then he snuck in under the belt by telling her father, he would treasure her. A low blow.

Her faked smile was rewarded with a kiss as her parents turned away to get in their rental car and return to the airport.

"Would like sleep now?"

She frowned.

He stroked his fingers over her cheek.

"They're gone now. You can stop playacting."

"Come, Brandoosha. You are sleepy, da? Go bed. I wake you for to go work."

He took her hand and led her back into their stale building. She followed docilely. She was tired.

"I have to be there at four," she said.

"Have two hours for to sleep. I pack dinner for you, okay."

"Sure, thanks," she said, as he closed the apartment door.

"I'm going to start working later tonight."

"What late?"

"Until ten or so."

"For why?"

"My boss asked me to, and we could use the money."

"*Niet*, not need," he said, raking a hand through his hair.

"Yes, we do. You know that when we start competing we'll have a lot more travel expenses."

"*Da*." He sounded frustrated. "I see to have visa changed. I work."

"Don't be silly. You don't need to have your visa changed."

"I can no work. Is says I here in America only train. Only for to skate."

"It's no big deal."

He rolled his eyes. "What mean deal?"

"I mean I told you when I came that I planned to work part-time to help pay for my share. Nothing's changed."

"Is no need to pay own apartment." He pushed back his sleeves.

"I can't believe we're having our first argument about money. We aren't even really married."

He blinked. "I keep you from sleep. Am being hoghead?"

"Pigheaded. Yes, you are. Good night."

He nodded. Picking up his tattered Russian/English dictionary he sank down on the couch.

Brandi went into the bedroom and kicked off her athletic shoes. Second day of marriage and she felt strangely bereft that she was crawling into bed

alone. She shook her head. She was more tired than she had realized, if she wanted Nikolai to be with her. Especially since they'd probably be disagreeing about whether or not she should work.

His tall male form next to her in bed was exactly what she didn't want. Exactly what she didn't need. But then she always knew she was too vulnerable to his good looks, and when he acted caring on top of that, she was turning into a marshmallow. A toasted one, all gooey and melted on the inside.

Except caring didn't mean love, and a three-year marriage to get his citizenship didn't mean anything beyond that. And she was getting all confused about the natural order relationship stages should happen. Love, sex, marriage. She ought to at least have part of that sequence right. And surely it didn't all happen in a few weeks.

She still remembered the bone-deep hurt from the fallout of her first relationship with a skating partner and the deep repercussions that still affected where she was in her skating today. Everything was at risk, her career, her dreams, her future and her heart. Better to hold onto them than let Nikolai have too much control over her life.

Already the signs of his natural tendency to dominate were patently obvious. It would be bad enough that they would lock heads on the issues of money, honesty, and dealing with family. When you added physical intimacy to that, emotions played too big a part. No, better to keep to the original plan of a marriage of convenience in name only.

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As soon as she left for work, Nikolai went to the bedroom and scooped all her practice outfits out of her drawer. He tossed them in a shopping bag and carried them to a nearby tee shirt silk screening shop. An hour and a half later, he had the majority of her leotards and skate dresses on the counter and a shop girl had matching long-sleeved tee shirts lying across them. She frowned at a pink outfit and laid a pale blue tee shirt on top of it.

"What would you think if we put this pattern on this shirt?" She showed Nikolai a pink rose that matched Brandi's skate dress. "I could even put a little blue rose here on the dress shoulder to match your shirt. I never knew skaters went to so much trouble to match clothes. Where is your partner?"

"She is work. I surprise her. How much cost?"

He winced as he forked over the one hundred and seventy-five American dollars, but that was nothing compared to what they would need to pay for their actual performance costumes.

He hoped that spending money would help show her he accepted her decision to work. She had thought he was upset about the money, but he was more worried about how she would have enough time to sleep. Then he realized he was arguing at cross-purposes with her and keeping her from the very thing he was worried that she wouldn't get enough of, her rest.

After he returned home from his English class, he walked to the party shop to wait for Brandi. The closed sign hung in the door so he leaned against her little compact car in the parking lot. She gave him a smile as she left from the back door. A man hung out the door watching her.

"My boss was worried you were some creep stalking me," she said as she neared him. "I told him you were my husband."

"You wish me not wait for you?" he asked, while reaching for her.

"No, but it's almost ten o'clock. You shouldn't wait up for me. We have to be up in a few hours."

He caught her elbows and gathering her against him without moving away from the car. He drew her in between his legs. "Must work so late?"

"I need to work. We need the money," she said dispiritedly. "It's not like I'm putting in a lot of hours, and evenings before closing is when he needs me here."

He caught her face and tilted her head back. She was tired. He could tell by the limpness in her body. He kissed her gently. Her resistance was low. Part of him wanted to press his advantage, knowing that she wouldn't put up much of a fight right now.

He slanted his mouth across hers, kissing her more deeply. He inhaled the scent of her, fresh and a faint hint of spice. He held her loosely, fighting the urge to pull her hips against his, to bend her backwards. He broke away, feathering a couple of gentle kisses across her soft mouth. He watched her indulgently.

She blinked as if suddenly aware that she was allowing him to hold her and kiss her casually, comfortably. She leaned back in his arms. "Okay, I think we've convinced my boss that you're not some psycho."

Her boss had closed the door some time ago, but Nikolai wasn't about to point that out. He gave her a gentle hug, before moving away from the

car and leading her to the driver's side. "We go home. Maybe we skate different time. I ask Mikelina. Would want share ice?"

"With another couple?"

"*Da*, pay not more."

"Less?" she questioned with a smile. She started the car and pulled out onto the street.

"*Da*, pay less."

She shrugged. "We should have some private ice time, but maybe we could share part of the time. How are your blisters doing? Are they healing?"

"*Da*. I talk Mikelina. Yuri like late skate."

Brandi reached across the space in the car and touched his arm. The small gesture started a swirling in his gut. He would spend the night aching again. He should not have kissed her. He should not have allowed himself to experience the soft drape of her tired body against him, it made him wonder too much how she would feel laying across him when she was sated and sleepy. How would she feel when he had caused the limp relaxation?

"We don't have to work on creating a dance to that music if it upsets Yuri. It's just an idea I have. I don't want to destroy the dynamic of your relationship with him and Mikelina. I'm just a novice compared to you guys."

He wished he could follow what she was saying better. "Brandi, we are ice dancers. We must like dance. We must feel dance."

She withdrew her hand to turn into their parking lot. He wanted to reach out and pull it back.

"You don't think I can do Russian style of dancing?"

He stared at her. He hadn't thought that. "You no think I do western dance?" he asked instead of responding. "I wish for mix. Russian passion, American..." he searched for a word to explain the concept. American's were so much more looser in their style, freer. They pleased the public. They could dance to rock and roll whereas Russians were often too formal, too classic and stiff—just a tick off when they went for pop culture dancing styles. He hoped that in three and a half years they could have the technique to satisfy judges and the style to please the audience.

"American optimism?" she asked with a smile.

Nikolai was charmed. Her dark mood was gone, barely expressed and shoved aside with her natural ebullience banishing the lingering traces.

"I think I say freedom."

“A blend of the oppressed and the liberated. We’ll have to be careful it doesn’t look like I am an imperialist, and you’re still oppressed,” she teased.

“Brandi, use words I not know. Write down I look up.”

“Don’t worry about it. In other words, you think we can mix our different styles and come up with a whole greater than the sum of it’s parts.”

In so much as he could follow that concept in her words he agreed. “*Da*. I not want make you Russian dancer. I wish become more American dancer.”

“But I should try to become more Russian, without losing my American traits.”

“Yes,” he said.

“*Da*,” she answered, opening her car door.

He stared at her, desire sweeping through him in a wave, but he wanted her to feel that making love was right too.

“But normally you wouldn’t have challenged Yuri like you did this morning, would you?”

No, he wouldn’t have. Not before. But he did feel strongly about doing the dance Brandi wanted. Tatiana wanted to be led. Brandi was used to being a driving force in her skating. Even he was used to being led, but he was determined to support his new bride in her drive for artistic expression. “I do best thing for us.”

“Okay, but be careful, Nikolai. Don’t support my ideas at all costs. Losing a great choreographer like Yuri would not be worth having artistic freedom. I may need you to rein in my wild ideas. Decisions about dances should be made by all of us.”

He nodded. She was offering a level of trust he hadn’t thought to achieve for some time. But Yuri should have allowed them to try their idea, except part of Yuri’s tirade before he stormed out had been the limited amount of time they had to develop two dances.

He watched her bounce up the stairs ahead of him. He could only think of a couple of times when she was tired enough to trudge up the stairs. He wanted her so badly it hurt. She stopped suddenly and turned.

“Did you call your mother?”

Nearly as good as dashing cold water in his face. “*Da*.”

She walked sedately up the rest of the stairs. “What did she say?”

"I ungrateful son." He'd looked up the translation so he could be sure to tell Brandi the right word if she asked. Which she just had. He shouldn't have bothered. Worry lines marred her forehead.

"Oh, Nikolai, don't you think it would have helped if I could have said something nice to her in Russian. I would have, you know."

"I know. Maybe we go Moscow after season. Maybe she to be happy. Maybe she see I happy husband."

"You're her only child, right?"

"Da."

~~*

Brandi chewed her lip as Nikolai unlocked their apartment. The drone of the air-conditioner greeted them. He put his hand on her waist as he waited for her to enter. The smooth warmth of his gesture sent a warm buzz through her. Still she sensed his quiet about his conversation meant it hadn't gone well.

She wanted to do something to ease what must have been an uncomfortable discussion with his mother. He had done so much to make sure the meeting with her parents had gone smoothly. Her parents had gone back to California secure that their daughter had made a good marriage, even if they thought it had been hasty.

"I guess it means a lot to parents to be involved in the wedding."

"You no want my mother involve."

"I wouldn't have minded, but I understand." She understood he had no intention of letting his mother have anything to do with her. It probably was out of consideration for his mother and the eventual divorce. He wouldn't want his mother to get attached to a temporary wife.

"Is okay," he said cryptically. "I make better with her later. She not like Americans."

Yeah, once his mother understood his marriage to an American was finished, she probably dance in the streets. Or whatever Russian women did to celebrate. Maybe Brandi should send her some party supplies.

She tossed her purse on the coffee table. The stark apartment hardly bothered her, anymore. Maybe if she brought home a couple of bright posters for the walls. She looked around. She could find a nice afghan to cover up the mud-colored couch. The place wouldn't look so drab if she just brought a little color into it.

Nikolai dropped back from her, closing and locking the door. When she turned around he was coming out of the bedroom with a pillow and blanket tucked under his arm. She watched him as he dropped them on the couch.

"I would you get sleep," he said in answer to her unspoken question.

She nodded, ducking into the bedroom to change, wondering why she felt so alone. He was respecting her wishes. Although he'd ignored her willingness to make friendly overtures to his mother. She felt excluded, and she had to acknowledge that part of it was self-inflicted. For a good cause, she reminded herself. The little telling things like his not wanting her to interact with his mother only went to show his intentions. Marriage for citizenship. That was the bargain, and she was the goose who kept getting confused on that issue.

When she emerged from the bathroom after brushing her teeth and washing her face, he had already fallen asleep. The blanket had fallen to the floor. She stood in the hallway. The fall of light from the partially open bedroom door spilled across the floor in front of him, but she could make out his even features. His long dark hair fell across his forehead in a way that made her fingers itch to push it back. His smooth chest rose and fell with his deep breathing. She was almost used to seeing him in his black briefs, although the blatant exposure of his masculine shape still caused her to draw a sharp breath each time.

The air-conditioner cycled on, and he moved. The cold air blew across his bared body. Brandi jumped back afraid to be caught watching him sleep. Fine dark hairs sparsely covered the pale skin on his long and muscular legs. Her eyes were drawn to them as he drew them in, curling up on the couch.

She knew the experience of those legs against hers, rubbing, sliding against her in their dance. She had even felt the heavy heat of his thigh resting against the juncture of her body, or perhaps the heat had come from her. She crossed the room and picked up the blanket. She draped it over him, gently tucking it behind him so it wouldn't slide off again when he shifted positions.

Unable to resist, she brushed back the stray strand of hair that threatened to drop across his eyes. She knew in that minute she had gone too far. He didn't wake, but with that simple touch, she had changed. She couldn't sleep with him, because she cared too much about him. And that made her far too vulnerable to hurt. She was too close to falling in love with

him. It wouldn't take much to tip her over the edge. She wouldn't be able to survive a divorce and continue partnering him. These feelings didn't belong in this kind of relationship.

She had to stay focused on the benefits of their deal. He would get an American citizenship, and she would get a real shot at the Olympics. If they worked their tails off. A three-year marriage was the price. If she kept these feelings to herself, maybe she could survive.

It was ridiculous anyway. He could hardly speak English, although he had improved since she arrived. How could she think she was falling in love with him, when she barely knew him, didn't even like him sometimes? She had almost hated him when he kept yelling, *niet, niet, niet* at Tatiana. These feelings were probably infatuation, they couldn't really be the start of love. If she didn't let the infatuation blossom into more, she could probably get out of this thing relatively unscathed.

She backed away, closed the bedroom door and slid into the bed feeling cold and alone. The worst part was that Nikolai was the only person she could talk to about their marriage, and she couldn't tell him about these feelings.

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In the morning Nikolai entered the bedroom as Brandi pulled out a practice outfit.

"Is what wear today?"

"Yeah," she answered.

"Are tired?" He crossed to the dresser to find the matching shirt he had just purchased.

"Not too bad."

He found the light purple long sleeve shirt and pulled it out of his drawer. "Is good match, *da*?"

Brandi didn't answer. He looked over at her. He thought he saw a glitter in her eyes that didn't speak of amusement or her usual sparkle. He wondered if he had done something wrong. "Are mad?"

She shook her head no, with tightly pressed lips.

"What wrong?"

"I thought you always wore black."

"Tatiana want me shadow to her." He shrugged. And that had been fine with him. But with Brandi he wanted to show the world they were together, in sync. "You want I shadow to you? You, Kevin wear same color." On ice

and off. In fact the Saturday that Kevin had spent with them he and Brandi had managed to wear tee shirts in matching shades of bright blue.

“No. Of course not. I just...” She bit her lip and turned away.

Nikolai stood with the light purple shirt in his hand feeling awkward and wondering if he should put it back in the drawer, wondering if he’d made a huge miscalculation. He’d thought she’d appreciate his effort to make them color-coordinated.

“You want I not wear?”

“No, go ahead.” She walked out of the bedroom.

The short drive to the rink was silent. He pushed up the sleeves of his shirt a half dozen times and then pulled them back down. “Is black pants,” he said finally.

“I’m just tired, Nikolai. You look fine.”

He wondered what had happened last night to make her withdraw. He thought when he picked her up from work and she allowed him to hold her and kiss her that things were improving between them. Had he made a mistake in not sharing the bed? Although sharing the bed and not her body would have been sheer torment, and he hadn’t thought things had improved that much between them.

He hoped she was simply tired, not withdrawing from him. But he suspected a retreat.

Chapter Nine

He spoke to Mikelina and Yuri about changing their hours of training after the practice session. The coaches said they would look into the times available.

Brandi and he returned to their little apartment and he fixed her a sandwich and then insisted she lie down before her ballet lessons. She nodded and moved to the bedroom.

While she was at her lessons he started making phone calls to start the process of soliciting sponsors.

The way she tore through the apartment after ballet made him hope she was back to her normal self. "I have to hurry. I'm not going to have time for dinner."

"Brandi, I bring dinner to you at store. You have break to eat, *da?*"

"Hell, Nikolai, you already fixed me lunch today."

"I not mind."

"Okay," she said, but a frown settled between her eyebrows. "I need to go to the grocery store tomorrow."

"I go. You rest."

She slipped into the bedroom and closed the door almost all the way. "What did Mikelina say about changing our skating times?"

"She find out what available. May find time at other rink."

Nikolai could hear the rustle of clothing as Brandi changed. He swallowed, wanting to be in the room with her, but she needed to leave for work.

Later he wrapped foil over a plate of food. Nothing fancy, he was a survival cooker. Brandi bought boxes and frozen bags of add-your-own-meat dinners, and he could manage those. He walked the seven blocks between their apartment and her work. He entered the party shop and held the plate up to show Brandi.

She nodded at him as she rang up a customer. He walked over to stand beside the counter.

"Here comes another one. Nikolai, our break room is just through there." She pointed to a hallway to the side of the counter. "Would you go put it on one of the tables for me, please?"

Nikolai nodded. He passed two doors, one with a man's stick figure and the other with a stick figure with a skirt, a water fountain sandwiched between them and found a partially open doorway just beyond that. Two

small square tables with a haphazard assortment of tables were there. Nikolai sat the plate down on the cleanest of the two tables. He picked up an empty chip wrapper and a crushed pop can, and carried them to the trashcan beside the vending machine.

“What are you doing in here?”

Nikolai turned and encountered the short dark-haired man who had stood at the door the other night. Her boss. “I bring dinner to Brandi.” Nikolai gestured toward the plate. He didn’t want to cause Brandi any problems.

“This is for employees only.”

The animosity came off the man in waves. Perhaps he had frightened the man. “Excuse me. Brandi have customer. She ask me to bring plate here. I leave now.”

“Roger, is it okay if I take my break now? My food is here,” said Brandi swinging around the corner. “Jay is keeping an eye on the register.” Her eyes shifted from her boss to Nikolai. “Oh let me introduce you to Nikolai.”

“We’ve met,” said Roger. He turned toward Brandi. “You know this break room is for employees only.”

“Oh, I didn’t think you’d mind if he came back for a minute.” Brandi’s brown eyes widened in her face. “I mean he is my h-husband.” A flush crept up her cheeks.

Nikolai wanted to spare her further embarrassment. Although he wasn’t sure if it was caused by her boss’s mild correction, or that she had to claim him as her husband. “Is okay. I leave now.”

Roger gave a smile that reminded Nikolai more of a grimace. “If I let you bring one person back, then Jay will want to let one person come back and then everyone will want to let someone else come back. And the next thing I know the break room is filled with people who don’t work here.”

“I leave,” said Nikolai feeling a little desperate. He would leave as soon as the two of them moved out of the doorway.

“I understand.” Brandi ducked her head. “I won’t tell him to come back here again.”

Roger’s dark glare turned on him.

“Don’t you see this sign?” He stabbed a sausage like finger at the Employees Only sign on the open door.

“Am sorry—”

“Don’t be mad at Nikolai. He doesn’t always understand English.”

He understood English just fine. It was the weird colloquiums she used that made him misunderstand her. He’d seen the sign, but hadn’t thought too much about since she’d directed him to the room.

“Is mistake. I leave now.”

“Good. Brandi, you have fifteen minutes.” Roger walked away.

Brandi raised her eyes as Nikolai passed out into the small public hallway. She stepped out into the hallway and looked left and right before speaking. “I’m sorry. I don’t know what’s got into him. I mean usually he’s pretty nice to me.”

“Maybe he have trouble with many people where do not belong.”

“He must have. I mean there are a lot of teenagers that work in the store.”

Nikolai wanted to cross the space and gather her in his arms, but she didn’t have a lot of time to eat, and he didn’t want to risk antagonizing her boss even more. “I see you later.”

“Yeah, you don’t have to wait up.”

“Not wait up. I take nap,” he offered with a small attempt at humor.

She didn’t smile.

A woman walked to the water fountain and bent over to take a drink.

“You have not much time for to eat.” He resisted the urge to shove his hands in his pockets.

She winced slightly. He didn’t know if the wince was at the thought of eating in a hurry or his less than perfect English embarrassed her. Or if there was something else wrong. While walking home, he mulled over her less than enthusiastic responses to him today.

The night before when she came willingly into his arms made him think she wasn’t totally opposed to a real marriage, but today there had been a wariness in her warm brown eyes, as if she was waiting for something. He continued walking past their building. He needed a real marriage, or he at least needed her in his arms at night.

Her presence, her scent in the air drove him to distraction. The memory of the glimpse he had of her pert breasts tormented him. In three years his passion may have played out, but now her very nearness and her insistence that they adhere to the original rules of their marriage, in name only, was driving him insane. He couldn’t on one hand violate her trust and his

promise to allow the marriage to be what she wanted. On the other hand, he had hoped that she would want a physical relationship too.

At one point she did. He searched for a reason she would have changed her mind. Other than she was a woman and therefore unfathomable and inconsistent, but what a woman. So close to being his, but so far.

He walked past a closed florist shop. He backed up and looked in the window.

He returned home a new purpose in his stride. When had he made any attempt to woo his wife?

Brandi was disappointed when she left the closed store and didn't find Nikolai waiting for her. But why should he lose sleep just because she was working late? Why should he lose sleep when he had nothing to gain by it?

She drove the short distance home and quietly opened the apartment door. Nikolai slept stretched out on the couch, fully clothed with his shoes still on. Had he intended to meet her after work? Her disappointment was erased with a soft wash of gratification.

And it would be a perfect opportunity to check his blisters, since he always brushed away her questions with a gruff, "Is okay."

She set her purse and keys down and moved to sit by his feet, untying his shoes, loosening the laces and trying to slip them off without waking him. She bent over and soundlessly dropped them to the floor. She hooked her fingers in one of his socks and slid it down.

A low rumbling flow of Russian words washed over her. She shifted around. Nikolai's bright blue eyes blinked at her. He looked sleepy and sexy. She so wished the words he spoke were what she wanted to hear. Even if she couldn't understand them.

"What are you saying?"

He blinked again and stared at her. He shook his head. "Not know," he finally said.

"You don't know, or you can't translate it?"

"You are home, done work?" He shifted up partway to his elbows.

She pulled his other sock off and checked his most of the way heeled blisters. "Nah, you're just dreaming."

"*Niet*, in dream wife not stop after remove socks."

"Then it's a nightmare. Go back to sleep."

"Might need you have check for blisters higher."

Satisfied that he was well on the way to healing and forming calluses where his new boots rubbed, she patted his feet and stood up. "I don't think you had any blisters any higher."

The edges of his mouth curled up slightly. "Have hurt, want check?"

She lied. "Nope. Good night." She backed toward the bedroom.

Nikolai stood up and stepped toward her. "I mean to come for to get you work."

His blue eyes were intense, until he stumbled over his shoes.

Brandi fled to the bedroom not wanting to guess what his look meant. Or rather she had a good idea what it meant. The rush of blood in her veins made her suspect that she knew all too well what it meant, and part of her wanted it too. The part of her incapable of rational thought. If he hadn't stumbled over his shoes, she would have stayed there waiting for his touch, his kiss, his love...and no doubt she would be waiting forever on that. He'd never indicated that he wanted more than sex, a skating partnership and citizenship. Not necessarily in that order.

She closed the door on his protest.

She couldn't risk it. And what the hell had he said to her before he was all the way awake? Before he remembered to talk in English. She simply had to learn Russian.

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He'd brought five flowers when he met her after work the next night. They were only daisies, but they reminded him of her, open and bright. Except she seemed less open and less bright.

He hoped that she would slide into his arms the way she had the first time he waited for her. Instead she stopped two feet in front of him. So he pulled the flowers from behind his back and held them out to her.

She ducked her head, hiding an expression that he thought might be dismay when he handed her the small bouquet.

"Oh, Nikolai," she whispered with a husky catch in her voice.

He stepped forward to kiss her, but she ducked to the side, moving quickly to the driver's door.

"Not like flower?"

Should he have spent more? Money was something neither of them could afford to spend imprudently. And he knew she worried about their finances. Otherwise she wouldn't be working this job, with stupid hours.

She inserted her key in her car door to unlock it. "They're sweet. You didn't have to."

"Is bad thing for to buy wife flowers? I not spend much."

She smiled, and he realized how stupid and unromantic that sounded. "I not mean—"

"I understood. You didn't waste a lot of money." She opened her door and slid in behind the wheel.

"Not waste," he muttered. It occurred to him that it would be a good time to tell her about the pending interviews and the mission he had set himself of getting new sponsors. When he settled in the passenger seat, he said, "I have make phone calls. We do interviews with reporter for Skating Times and for newspaper of city and some others magazines I call."

She blanched.

He wanted to wash away her distress. "Is for get money help us skate."

"We aren't talking to them at the apartment are we?"

"Is some do practice at ice rink for to take pictures."

"And the rest?"

"Is not set."

"I don't want them to come to our apartment."

Did she hate their apartment that much? "Is so bad?"

Her brow furrowed. "We don't want to look too desperate. My father always says it's easier to get a job or a loan if you don't look like you need the money. I'm sure the same is true for getting sponsors."

"Brandi, you no like interviews?"

"They're going to be more interested in our marriage than our skating."

"We pretend happy marriage."

"I know."

But she didn't look happy about it. The flowers had gone over like rotten cabbage and lay carelessly between them. Now she didn't like the idea of interviewing, which was something they wouldn't be able to avoid anyway.

"Is mistake? I can no work. You worry for to have money."

"It's okay. I just don't like the lying part."

"No lie. They not ask if we make love."

She flashed him a wary look. He wondered if he sounded as frustrated as he felt. If his efforts to ease her burden and seduce her went so well he might as well become gay. Well other than he didn't think he could function

that way, which meant he was doomed to perpetual abstinence. He was starting to think he only wanted her. Even other women had lost their appeal.

“It’s nice that you meet me after work, but really you should stay home and get more sleep.”

He looked over as she drove. Wisps of her soft brown hair had escaped the clip she had tucked into her hair. Her shoulders drooped. He reached across and brushed her arm. “I get hours changed soon. You are tired, *da?*”

She nodded.

“You get sleep.”

She bit her lip as she parked. He put his palm on her back as they walked into their apartment. She turned her wide brown eyes on him when he paused by the bedroom door. He would let her sleep in peace, but he just wanted one taste of her before moving to his lumpy couch bed.

He tightened his fingers on her lower back pulling her toward him. He leaned down to brush his lips on hers.

Her squawk of alarm wasn’t quite the response he expected or wanted.

“The flowers! You’re crushing the flowers!”

She could throw them in the trash for all the good they were doing him. “*Niet*, forget flowers.”

She pushed out of his embrace, her eyes downcast. “I know you forgot, but I need to put them in water. I don’t want them ruined.”

He hadn’t forgotten them. He’d wanted her to forget them. She ducked away to go into the kitchen. He heard the water running, and his hopes for a goodnight kiss swirled down the drain.

He wondered if he made a mistake not following her into the bedroom the night before, or the first night home after their marriage, but they both needed to sleep some time. Lying beside her, wanting her, needing her was too hard. Their wedding night neither of them had slept more than half an hour, nor had the night Kevin spent with them been much better. He wanted their marriage to be real, but she had set the terms. He wasn’t desperate enough to forcefully seduce her into doing something she didn’t believe was right. Yet.

Trust seemed like a trivial issue at times when his blood was pounding in his veins. He knew it wasn’t. He knew to violate her trust could have worse consequences for their relationship than a few million cold showers. Only now it seemed he wasn’t allowed to even kiss her.

“Um, Nikolai?”

He stopped making his bed on the couch to look at her.

“I really think we need to stay with our agreement that our marriage is in name only when we’re alone.”

“Is what want?”

She shook her head slowly as if not totally certain of her answer. “Our marriage is to get your citizenship. That is what I understood, and that is what we agreed to, isn’t it?”

Well, the flowers had definitely not helped. He swallowed down the bitter taste of frustration. There was a hesitation in her answer that warned him to not rage against it. Although he wanted to.

“I mean nothing with flowers.” He slapped the pillow on the sheet over the couch, and then gestured to where they had stood near the bedroom door. Where half a minute ago he had tried to kiss her.

“I know. That’s the problem.”

Niet, he didn’t think she did know.

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It seemed like Brandi’s head had barely hit the pillow, before the alarm clock was buzzing her out of bed. Most mornings this last week, it had been like this. She stumbled into the kitchen and poured herself a glass of juice and dumped two slices of bread into the toaster. While she waited, she filled their water bottles. The toast popped up, and she buttered it while standing at the counter.

Rubbing his eyes, Nikolai entered the room. He reached for a box of cereal and opened the cupboard to reach for bowls. “Would want?”

“No thanks, I’m just having toast.”

“I fix for you.”

She shook her head. “I’m not hungry.”

She took her bottle and moved back to the bedroom to finish getting ready. She was exhausted. Between skating, work and ballet lessons, which were totally unnecessary in her opinion, she was starting to drag, but she knew as soon as she put her blades on the ice she would be fine.

Nikolai gave her a wary glance when she emerged from the bedroom. “Would eat now?”

“We need to leave.”

“We can skate eleven morning to two with skate Alexei and Vera, and other couple who train, but are home now.”

“That’s only three hours.”

“Is not only problem. Skate with Yuri for choreography at rink on Elmhurst from ten at night to one.”

“Is that too late for you?” Brandi picked up her skate bag and purse. The later start meant she could sleep longer in one stretch. She counted seven and a half to eight hours, depending on the drive to the other rink. But that late at night traffic wasn’t likely to be a problem. Getting there after work might be though.

“I get you yogurt,” said Nikolai. “Not worry late. Worry skate with Alexei.”

She called down the hall. “But you’re friends. What’s the problem?”

“Is Vera not skate much. He ask Tatiana be partner.”

“If she doesn’t go around slapping you, I don’t have a problem with that. Is she going to skate with Alexei?”

“She practice with him, but not say yet.”

Brandi moved to the door. “Will you have a problem with her?”

Nikolai shrugged and looked uncomfortable. “Not know. Not talk to her since break. Problem not me.”

“Personally, I like the hours, but if you really don’t want to be on the ice with Tatiana, we don’t have to change.”

“We change. I tell Mikelina. Is cost same. Ice time other place more.”

She was glad he thought about the money. She hardly remembered it was a consideration. “That’s okay. I’m working more hours. So we should be able to afford it.”

He scowled. “Is not more, no need more work.”

Nikolai probably thought her boss Roger was an ogre. Every time he came around Roger would get upset. Roger had explained to her that he’d had a lot of trouble with employees having their friends loitering in the parking lot, hogging the too few spaces, and not leaving them for real customers. So she understood that he didn’t want non-customers hanging around. And she understood when Roger didn’t want his employees hanging around in the parking lot either.

On the other hand it could be that Nikolai was worried about skating at the same time as his former partner. She turned to him outside their building. “You don’t like the idea of Alexei skating with Tatiana, do you?”

He raked a hand through his dark hair. “I worry for Alexei. Tatiana bad performer.”

Brandi had seen her practice. She was a great skater. She'd also seen her nervous knee knocking before the competition in Bucharest. "Well maybe the professional circuit would be good for her. You have to perform almost every night. Maybe she would get over her anxiety."

The stubborn line of his jaw said he'd believe it when he saw it and no sooner. After she unlocked the car doors, he opened the passenger door and slid inside.

"How did you get paired up with her anyway?"

"We children, matched by ability. I wish be men's figure skater, but is decided I better to dance."

She started the car and put it in gear. "You didn't have a choice?"

"Niet."

"Because that's how it's done in Russia?"

He gave her one of his rare grins. "I no land double axel, spin too slow."

"Oh well hell, I can land a double axel, but not a triple, but I always liked dance best."

"With you, I have no wish skate alone."

"With Tatiana you did?"

"Da."

Brandi felt a smile forming. "That's because you can show off more with me as your partner."

"Niet!"

"Da-a," she flashed him an incredulous look. He had to realize he constantly perfected his moves for performing not for the love of ice skating but for the eventual competition. She did it too. Perfected her moves that is. She would skate every day, even if she had no hope of ever competing. But Nikolai's skating was different than hers. He was more goal driven than she was. She wasn't sure if he loved it, or just felt driven to do it. "It's not an insult. It's good that you like to perform as well as dance."

"I like you love ice much."

She paused as she put the car in park. "Would you skate if..." She hesitated looking for a scenario that made sense. She had thought about saying if he were rich, but skating and being the best wasn't about money.

"If was no compete?"

"Yeah."

He hesitated only a moment. “With you, *da*. Is feel right.” He reached for his door handle and got out of the car.

She stared as he walked to the glass doors before he turned around to see if she was following him. She scrambled out of the car, grabbed her skate bag, and locked the doors, before hurrying to follow him into the rink.

She told herself sternly not to read more into the words than was there, but she hoped that he meant more by them, hoped that he at least wanted to skate with her the rest of their lives, not just their career.

She wondered far too cynically if his words were just another attempt at seduction. After the night with the flowers he no longer attempted to kiss her when they were alone in the apartment, but he had no hesitation when he met her at work. Although mostly she kept him to husbandly-like pecks, there was no doubt as to his intention. He wanted to sleep with her, but he offered nothing more.

He only called his mother if she was not around. He rarely spoke about his childhood, although he had to know most of her life story by now. He listened with intensity, but she half-suspected he thought of her long-winded monologues as English lessons. He asked questions to be sure he heard right, but he never probed her feelings or shared his own.

Her suggestions that he should talk more, tell her more about himself to practice his English were met with a puzzled look, and a “What wish know?”

“Anything,” she’d answered. She wished to know that he cared about her, that he didn’t just want to sleep with her because she was conveniently his wife, and sex with another woman would be inconvenient.

“Teacher say is better I read out loud newspaper.”

She had gone to bed.

Chapter Ten

The first day on the ice with their new practice times had gone smoothly. Tatiana and Alexei had been engaged in intensive practice when they arrived. As soon as they stepped off the ice, Nikolai tore off his skates and walked outside barefoot.

The next day hadn't gone as well. Tatiana had made sure everyone there including a rounding Vera knew that she was the best skater and dancer. She had pulled Nikolai away as he, Mikelina and Brandi were discussing a particular move that Yuri had them working on. Brandi watched the exchange of Russian words with curiosity. Nikolai originally delivered his normal *niets*, but a command from Mikelina silenced them and they skated off together. Brandi skated to the boards as her husband performed a complicated lift with his former partner.

Alexei moved beside her. "She says I do not do lift as well as Nikolai."

"They skated together a long time," said Brandi leaning her elbows onto the boards, trying to will down the jealous surge in her. Why was he skating with Tatiana now when he had refused a couple of months ago at Lake Placid?

Brandi looked at her skates unwilling to watch the woman in her husband's arms moving through contortions that she could never do.

"I tell her she fall in show, she cannot blame both Nikolai and me."

"Is she going to skate with you?"

Alexei shrugged. "I think she has not accepted that Nikolai will skate with you."

Brandi turned to face the boards. "Maybe he should skate with her still. She's better than I am."

"No, she is just Russian trained longer," said Alexei.

Brandi smiled at the encouragement and conceit all wrapped up in that statement.

"She not understand Nikolai."

Join the crowd, thought Brandi. But she didn't dare voice the thought out loud for fear that it would be readily apparent to Alexei she didn't know her husband as well as a real wife should.

"I am happy he marry you. I know he is interested in you, but he always plan to go home and marry Moscow girl."

Brandi almost felt sick. She tried to sound casual. “Any particular one?”

“His mother always find him pretty girls to go out with when he home. I think perhaps when he done with career he would marry one of them. Is a few he dates when in Moscow.”

She frowned. “Why, when he’s done with his career?”

“He’s always said a marriage would be too hard on wife while he is competing.” Alexei shrugged. “I think he is in no hurry. I guess I was wrong. He was in big hurry to marry you. You are not like Vera?”

Brandi shook her head. No she wasn’t pregnant. Although she felt sick at her stomach. So basically their marriage to her didn’t alter anything in his life plan. He could still go home to Moscow after the competing part of his career was over and his marriage to her was done and marry one of his pretty Moscow girls. He probably still planned to do just that.

Alexei looked at her speculatively.

“I’m going to go get a drink,” said Brandi skating to the entrance.

Their marriage was seemingly more complicated by the minute, but it meant little or nothing to him. Thank God, she hadn’t slept with him.

Brandi watched Nikolai and Tatiana skate as she put on her blade guards. They were so good together. So perfectly practiced, and Tatiana was taller than Brandi, a better match with Nikolai. And the woman was so damn flexible it made Brandi sick.

As she turned she saw Vera standing near the boards watching wistfully. Poor Vera had been warned to stay off the ice by her doctor, but was here nonetheless and watching her partner pair up with another woman with a lot of talent.

Brandi wondered if she should have suggested herself as a possible temporary replacement for Vera, and let Nikolai continue to partner Tatiana. Her dreams of an Olympic medal were probably just pipe dreams. But Nikolai had a real shot, and if she were to skate with Alexei in the ice shows, nationality wouldn’t be a problem for anyone.

Perhaps Alexei meant with the marriage that there was no way that Nikolai would leave their partnership. But if he wanted to rejoin Tatiana, she wouldn’t stop him. She would hate it, but she wouldn’t stop him.

~~*

Nikolai had never felt more like dropping Tatiana than he did right now. After all the years of accusations that he deliberately caused her to fall, and

he had been so careful, now he felt like intentionally letting her drop to the ice, preferably on her head.

Now she was seeing a psychiatrist. Now she was admitting to faults. Now she said she understood his frustration and would try harder. Except now she was doing the same thing to Alexei that she had done to him for years, belittling his talent, trying to upstage him. He hoped that Alexei was smart enough to see through it.

The lift he was supposedly demonstrating for Alexei's benefit had taken them months to learn. It was no shame or reflection of his talent that Alexei hadn't perfected the move yet. Tatiana's smiling insistence that Nikolai should demonstrate how it was done right and Mikelina's agreement made Nikolai want to bounce Tatiana on her head—two or three times. As they moved across the ice in preparation for the lift he was reminded how awkward skating with Tatiana could be. Mikelina constantly reminded her to use her knees, to use more powerful strokes.

Even though Brandi was shorter and should be harder to match strokes with, she wasn't. She always skated with more speed and power than Tatiana. Nikolai couldn't remember once in their training when Mikelina had to single out Brandi for instructions to skate faster or use more strength. That part came easily to them, and without the concentration on the basic synchronization, they could put more effort into the maneuvers. Eventually that was bound to pay off in more ways than just the feeling of flowing through the dance.

When Tatiana's skates were back on the ice, he let go. She didn't.

"No, we should show them the proper follow through," she said in Russian.

"I have no desire to skate with you."

"I am a better skater than she is."

"She is a better competitor."

"Oh come on, Nikolai, I know you just fall in lust with her and marry her quick. That doesn't mean you have to skate with her. After all what is she going to do, divorce you if you have a better shot skating with me."

Nikolai stopped looking around the ice for his wife. Yes, she would divorce him. Their whole reason for being married would be gone. "I don't care if I have a better shot with you. I skate with her now." He blinked, realizing what he said.

Tatiana stared at him.

He wondered himself at the words. No, even if she didn't have the talent he stood a better shot with Brandi. She would not crack under the pressure of competition. She didn't crack when she worked too many hours and had too little sleep. She stood firm on her decision to keep their marriage in name only. She was tougher than Tatiana. He wanted nothing more than to find her and kiss her.

"I haven't relinquished my Olympic-eligible status yet."

He looked at Tatiana. "Do not play with Alexei. Make decision to skate with him or not waste money for practice time that won't matter."

"But he will go back to Vera," said Tatiana.

Mikelina and Alexei joined them. Nikolai loosened Tatiana's talons from his arm and turned to Mikelina. "Do not waste my wife's ice time again."

He skated away before his coach did more than grimly nod. He found Brandi sitting bent over on one of the benches. She unlaced her skates without looking up at him.

"*Niet* time leave," he said.

"We only have twelve more minutes." Her voice was low and there was a slight quiver in it. "I figured I might as well take off my skates."

He sat down beside her. "Brandi?"

"If you want to go back to skating with Tatiana, I would understand. She's so much better than I am."

"This not like you," he said concerned.

"No, it's not like me to be practical, is it?"

"But I was thinking that maybe I should fill in for Vera, and then no one would have to worry about nationalities or marriages or learning other languages."

It was as if the Zamboni had run him over. His intention of telling her he wouldn't skate with Tatiana again, not even for a demonstration flew out of his mind. If he wanted to skate with Tatiana, it might have made sense. No it never would have made sense. "*Niet*."

"Think about it, Nikolai. I'd understand. I mean what chance do I really have of getting a medal? I'm holding you back. I'm driving your coaches crazy."

"*Niet*."

"Just think it over."

“What want?” he asked a little desperately. Did she want out of the marriage so badly that she would throw everything over, their plans to compete together? He knew she wanted to go to the Olympics. He thought that they would make it. In three years they would be ready. Had he pushed her too hard? “Is wish away from me?”

She hesitated before answering. “No.” She tied on her tennis shoes. “I just thought it might make more sense for you and Tatiana to continue to skate together.” She stood and tossed her stuff in her bag.

He grabbed her arm, forcing her to look at him.

She looked more upset than she had that morning in Lake Placid when she had just learned Kevin wanted out of the partnership.

“I want you.”

She blinked, and he realized he’d said the words in Russian, which was perhaps for the best, because she didn’t think they should have a real marriage. Tatiana’s taunt on the ice hurt. He knew the answer although the question didn’t bear asking, “I skate with Tatiana, you wish divorce?”

“Of course, what reason would there be to...” her voice trailed off.

Out of the corner of his eye he saw Mikelina.

This reason, he thought and pulled her down to his lap, holding her captive and finding her mouth with his own. Her kiss felt as desperate and hungry as he felt, until she broke away and turned her face into his neck.

“She’s gone back to the ice,” whispered Brandi.

How could she know? How could she have paid any attention in the middle of that wild kiss to where anyone was other than him? He sighed, knowing that it would be a long time before the throb of his body slowed to a manageable hum. He would not be able to stand up and walk out of rink any time soon. Was it all an act on her part? Was her ducking away from him in the apartment the true measure of her feelings toward him?

He let her go. “I skate you.”

She moved off his lap and stood in front of him. “I want you to promise me you’ll think about it.”

“Da, I think.” He gave it two seconds or maybe a second and a half. It didn’t deserve that much time. What troubled him was the increasingly wary way she responded to him. He leaned down to untie his skates.

“I’d like to go on ahead, if you don’t mind walking.”

“I no mind.” Not much anyway. He minded her resistance to consummating their marriage. He minded that a whole lot.

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Brandi drove home and hurried into the shower. She needed to leave for ballet lessons soon. He was thinking about going back with Tatiana otherwise why the question about divorce? She leaned her head against the tiled wall wondering what she should do. It wasn't like her to be willing to sacrifice her own future, but she really didn't want to stop Nikolai from achieving his best.

Watching Tatiana skate Brandi was forcibly reminded of how far she had to go. She wondered if she was getting the reverse of her situation with Kevin.

The water, rarely more than warm, grew icy cold and Brandi turned off the taps.

She didn't want to give up skating with Nikolai. It was too much fun. More than fun, she felt like the dancing flowed through them as if they were one. It was just that the free dance they were working on, her suggestion, wasn't going as well as she hoped. Yuri insisted on moves that were beyond her abilities.

She examined a bruise on her hip. There had been a lot of falls, and Nikolai would push up his sleeves and blow air out of his mouth. She almost wished he would yell at her, but he didn't. There was always a gentle look in his eyes as he helped her stand or stood himself.

She expected better of herself. She wanted a better partner for him. She towed herself off and grabbed her robe. She didn't bother pulling it on in the small bathroom, since Nikolai wouldn't be home yet. The walk from the rink was a good twenty minutes.

She heard the key in the lock just before she made it to the bedroom. She rushed the rest of the way into the room, but not without seeing his blue eyes widen in surprise and anticipation. She shut the door.

His tap came shortly after. She froze, knowing she hadn't locked the door.

"Brandi, would talk?"

"Hang on, I'm getting dressed."

"No need."

Yes, there was definitely a need.

He had never asked to talk before. Perhaps he had decided to skate with Tatiana after all. Sick dread coursed down her spine as she pulled on a leotard and tights.

She opened the door to find him leaning against the frame. His gaze flicked over her. She felt heat flair in spite of the nervous churning of her stomach.

“Brandi, you make promise to skate season with me.”

That seemed like an odd start to telling her he was returning to his partnership with Tatiana. “I know.”

“You no wish now?”

“I just think you might have a better shot with Tatiana.”

He made a karate chop in the air. “*Niet*. What you do? Skate Kevin?”

She looked down at her ballet slippers. “I don’t know.”

Nikolai puffed air out of his lips.

“I’m not doing very good with learning the free dance. I don’t think I’ve made any improvements in the last week. You and Tatiana know a lot of moves already.”

“I learn too. Is not always you mistake.”

“Oh come on. What, you’re two centimeters out of position? I’m the one falling all the time.”

“Maybe Tatiana right. I make fall. ”

Brandi shook her head.

“Is much time for to learn new dance, new partner. Tatiana, I do same again, again. Maybe little change, new...” He waved his arm.

“Moves?”

“*Niet*, no new moves. How say do first, do next?”

“Order? Sequence?”

“*Da*. Change order move.” He waved his hand. “Is new dance. Is no challenge. You no wish dance easy?”

She blinked. Put in that light, no she supposed she didn’t. With Kevin she had rarely had trouble learning a new dance, but she hadn’t felt challenged enough.

“I think you tired, not sleep enough. Always go here, go there.”

“It’s not my idea to take ballet lessons. That makes it more difficult to get good ice time. Jeez, speaking of which, I got to get going or I’m going to be late.”

“I go, talk more.”

“No!”

She regretted her quick protest when she saw his wince. But she listened to the CD she bought on the way to and from ballet, since the drive

to work was so short, and she didn't have any other time without Nikolai present. She wasn't ready to try out the results on him yet.

"Brandi, you good skate. You learn."

"I guess if I don't, we can modify the dance."

"Will not need." He looked away as if no longer interested in the conversation.

"If you decide to skate with Tatiana, I will understand."

"*Niet!*" He pushed away from the doorframe. An angry spate of Russian words followed. Brandi backed into the bedroom, surprised at his rare outburst and not understanding a word of it.

He stared at her and stopped mid-sentence if she was any judge. He drew a deep breath. "I stay America. I marry you. I become US citizen for to skate with you. This mean nothing?"

She stared.

"I no sleep you. This for *you* wish. Is make me crazy," he paced across the room. "I give marriage you wish. I no want."

"The marriage was your idea," she said softly.

"Convenience you idea."

"You just expected to live like normal married people for three years?"

He turned away and leaned over, putting his hands against the dresser. "*Da*. Know is not marriage you want. Not I want," he said quietly.

His words ripped at her. No, it wasn't the marriage she'd wanted or dreamed about. But now, if he could love her, it was the marriage she wanted to keep. But he spoke no words of love or desire to make the marriage more real other than to have sex. His ego was hurt by her refusal to sleep with him, and her feelings were torn in a thousand different directions.

"It's too complicated. There's just too much at risk now."

"Is what you say."

She wished he would turn around so she could gauge his meaning not only by his words, but by the expression on his face. She wished he would cross the room and override her objections by sweeping her into his arms. She wished he showed just a smidgen of real caring. She didn't want to know that she wasn't his ideal wife. So many boundaries had already been blurred by their fake marriage.

"You to be late."

She didn't want to go. She wanted to believe they were on the verge of some understanding. Ballet wasn't helping her with the complicated spins and pivots Yuri required in their dance.

"I..."

Her tentative start was cut off by the ring tone of her phone. She crossed the room and pulled it out of her bag.

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Nikolai stared at his hands on the dresser as he listened to her side of the conversation.

"Jay quit?"

There was something right in front of him that he was missing. Although her reflex response to him accompanying her to her dance lessons stung. Was she so ashamed of his foreignness that she didn't want to be seen with him? He remembered her apologies to her parents for his inability to understand all their questions. She had done the same with Kevin, the clerk at the grocery store. He wished he would have started learning English before moving here to train, but he hadn't. His mother was so anti-American that some of her resistance had worn off on him.

"I'll be in as soon as I get back from my ballet lesson." There was a pause. "Okay, I'll see you then."

"More work?"

"Jay quit without giving any notice. Roger is running the store short-handed. I gotta go."

Nikolai sighed. He heard her move out of the room through the front door.

He reached down to open his drawer to remove clothes to change into. He set a clean pair of socks on the top of the dresser only to notice that Brandi had put both of the phone books there, white and *yellow* pages. He wondered why she had moved them from the nightstand. He picked them up to move back to the nightstand only to notice that there was a single daisy pressed flat in waxed paper underneath them.

He looked at it and put the phone books back down. He turned and saw the glass holding the four remaining daisies in an advanced state of deterioration by the bedside. The ends of the petals were brown and crisp, and the stems drooped.

He sat down on the bed. Maybe his efforts to woo his wife hadn't gone as badly as he thought. As a performing skater she would have received lots

of flowers, many times. It couldn't be the novelty of receiving flowers that had her saving one that he had given her. Perhaps he hadn't stuck long enough with the plan to seduce his wife. There were other little tokens of affection he could buy her that would not get in the way of a kiss. Little gifts to show her his feelings.

He thought of candy and wondered if she'd eaten anything for lunch. He went to the kitchen and found no evidence that she'd eaten. He fixed two sandwiches and put one in a plastic bag for her and stuck it in the refrigerator.

Since he'd arranged for different training times, he wondered what was the point when she spent every waking moment not training away from him. Now they skated from ten at night until one alone with Yuri, and nine until noon with Mikelina. They pretty much had the ice to themselves, since Tatiana had flown back to Russia and Vera was unable to skate more than basic warm-ups due to complications with her pregnancy.

The new training schedule meant they still only had about seven hours of sleep at night, but that wasn't nearly as bad as trying to get by with only five hours at a stretch. Although Mikelina kept muttering about them needing more sleep, as if they were spending half the night locked in each others arms. No, he just spent half the night dreaming about that, tossing on the couch that seemed increasingly uncomfortable.

~~*

A week later, his little gift of a small teddy bear dressed in the American flag, left on the bed for her hadn't been mentioned, nor had the small box of colored clip barrettes that he had found and purchased for her garnered more than a little smile and a soft apologetic, "Thank you. I know my hair is always slipping down, but don't worry I use gel in it when I compete."

He hadn't bought them as a criticism. He liked the soft flyaway texture of her hair. He liked the way it looked, smooth and warm, always on the edge of falling down as if her hair was ready to tumble for him. Unlike her.

She just seemed increasingly wary of him and his gifts.

He asked her in exasperation as she whirled out the door one day going to her work, if she was meant to do the work of Jay who quit as well as her own job.

"No, it's just temporary until Roger finds a replacement, and we can use the money."

He admired his wife's determination and dedication, but he wanted to see the sparkle back in her eyes. He felt like he had drained her glow from her. The last thing he ever wanted was to do that, but he couldn't help but touch her in the only time left to do it, while they were on the ice.

The only positive thing happening was that she had pushed past her learning plateau and had started pushing past her limits. Their free dance to her music was coming together. Bits of it went well and within the week they would skate the whole four-minute dance in one try. This morning Mikelina had them working on one of the sequences in their short dance.

"Are you paying attention?" Brandi asked.

"What?" he replied.

"That's the third time Mikelina's told you to raise your arm up. You haven't done it yet."

"I had rather hold you."

"Nikolai," protested Brandi.

Had Mikelina told him something three times already? And he hadn't heard. "She say in English?"

"Yes, but she said your name. She's not talking to me."

"I think about you. Cannot think skating too."

"What? Am I doing something wrong?"

He heard Mikelina's shout across the rink this time. He pivoted, dragging his toe picks for a quick stop, turned and looked at his coach. "We need five," he said.

"No, we don't need a break," Brandi said.

"Yes, do. What wrong, Brandoosha?"

She looked away. Her eyes narrowed as she looked across the ice. He guided her to the boards, and kept an arm on either side of her so she wouldn't skate away.

"Nothing's wrong."

"Yes is. I wish make you happy, and I make you sad instead."

Her eyes flashed to his with a vulnerability that made her seem fragile. "We have a marriage of convenience, Nikolai. Please stop trying to make it something else. I don't want any bad feelings when we end this farce in three years," she whispered.

He skated away from her, making a slow circuit of the ice. She might as well have punched him in the gut. She still wanted to end their marriage in three years. He wanted a real marriage, but she didn't want him. It was her

choice. He had made that clear, hadn't he? She wasn't even considering that their marriage could continue if things were working. She wasn't even trying to make it work.

He skated to the opening to the ice. He grabbed his blade guards.

"Fire melt ice?"

Nikolai looked up to see Alexei standing on the spongy flooring outside the rink. He put his guards on his skates. He didn't bother answering.

His friend grinned. "Lover's quarrel?" he asked.

"No," answered Nikolai. He wished it was a lover's quarrel. Then he might at least have the hope that it could be worked out.

"Old Russian saying; 'If you want to go to war, think once; if you want to go to sea, think twice; if you want to get married, think three times.'"

"I ask three times," Nikolai answered. Maybe it was four, he wasn't sure. He crossed to the bench where he and Brandi had left their skate bags. He reached into his for his sport bottle and uncapped the lid.

"*Think, not ask,*" replied his friend. "She looks sad."

"I know," answered Nikolai, taking a drink. Kool-Aid. He smiled, realizing that Brandi had filled his drink bottle with strawberry-kiwi Kool-Aid. She'd turn up her cute nose when he asked her if she wanted some, but he was fascinated with the American drink and the dozens of different flavors it came in. He didn't care much for her American pizzas either, but he usually threw a frozen one in the shopping cart when they were in the grocery store. He turned to his friend. "Why are you here?"

"This Sunday a group of us are going to visit Belle Island. Vera's husband cannot come to be with her. She feels bad her pregnancy interferes with our partnership. I think the day in park might cheer her up. I came to ask if you and your wife would like to join us."

"I ask her. Tatiana decide not to skate for Vera?"

Alexei shrugged. "She has not said. She thought you would go back to her."

"I skate Brandi." Nikolai said stubbornly. Why didn't they get it? Alexei of all people knew what he had gone through with Tatiana.

"She's a better skater than I thought."

"Thank you."

"I think at first you make bad decision because of desire for her. I see why you switched for skating now, but I thought you planned to wait on the fire."

Nikolai shrugged. He wanted to confide in his friend, but he was bound by the silence of his and Brandi's agreement.

"Three years to become citizen when married to an American," observed Alexei.

"I love my wife," answered Nikolai. He stared down at the multicolored carpeting. He realized the words were true. He loved her, but she still wanted to end their marriage in three years. "She give me Kool-Aid," he said in awe. He wondered when he had started loving her. It seemed like he had loved her from the first minute she had said, *yes, yes, yes, think positive*.

Alexei stared at him like he was crazy. "Hey, you can get Kool-Aid anywhere in America."

"I ask her," he said, while capping his sport bottle and then walking back to the ice.

Brandi was about ready to step off. She looked up at him, her brown eyes full of questions.

"Much can change three years," he said softly. Hell, much could change in three weeks.

"What are you saying?" she asked sharply, the words a challenge.

He didn't know what he was saying. He loved her. "I become more American in three years, maybe not embarrass you then."

"Nikolai, you don't embarrass me."

"You give me Kool-Aid," he said, just before he kissed her. She probably didn't understand the significance of the remark, and his mouth was engaged in showing her what he meant. And she kissed him back like she understood.

Chapter Eleven

Mikelina had to clap, before they sprung apart. Brandi stood staring at her husband. Her chest was heaving as if she'd skated around the rink at top speed. Her legs even felt rubbery. Oh hell, she wanted him with every fiber of her being. She was too far gone to save herself from being hurt. She was too lonely at night to keep denying this attraction. If he had supplied the least amount of pressure when they were alone in their apartment, she would have been his wife in more than name by now.

She didn't even notice Alexei until he said something that sounded suspiciously like an apology in Russian to Nikolai.

"So was that a yes?" Alexei asked her.

Brandi didn't have a clue what he was talking about.

"Alexei asks if we would go with him to—where was place?" said her husband turning toward his friend.

"Belle Island. Is a park there. Some skaters are going there Sunday."

"Sure, why not," said Brandi, staring at her husband. Was all that passion because she put a kiddie beverage in his water bottle? It wasn't the first time she had done it. There was a water fountain if he really wanted water.

"I call you and tell you when we go," said Alexei, before walking away. His friend.

Was all that sudden heat to impress Alexei with the realness of their marriage? Her heart fell. Alexei knew that Nikolai was looking into becoming an American citizen. Maybe he even knew that the waiting period was shorter for a foreigner married to a United States citizen.

"Mikelina getting angry," Nikolai removed his blade guards and guided her into a dance hold. They started the steps their coach had them working on.

"Do you think we convinced him?" asked Brandi, staring at the pale rose on her husband's long-sleeved tee shirt. Her eyes flicked to the little contrasting blue rose on her shoulder of her pink dress. All the little outward signs to prove their marriage was real. That their partnership was deeper than skating.

"Who?"

"Alexei."

"Not do, to convince Alexei anything."

"Then why did he apologize? In Russian?"

“How you know?”

She flushed. “*Dobroe utro. Ya ne ponimayu.*” Good morning, and I do not understand. Not exactly fluency, just two phrases from her How to Learn Russian In Three Easy Steps CD. Two that she could remember without having heard them three seconds earlier. One that she was sure she would need to use all the time. She played the tape on the way to and from ballet class and to and from work, when she was alone. She wasn’t sure that she could relate the exact word that Alexei used, but she was pretty sure it was one that was part of the apology somewhere in her lessons.

“Your accent is horrible,” he said with a wide grin.

“Well, so was yours at first.” His English was improving by leaps and bounds too. He worked hard at it.

“Oh for heaven’s sake, Nikolai. Put your arm up before Mikelina blows a gasket.”

“What this look like—blow a gasket?” he asked, raising an arm.

“Well usually means you have some awful liquid spewing everywhere. I blew a gasket on my old Dodge Neon, and I drove it home. Dad never did get all the oil stains out of the driveway,” she smiled up at him.

His blue eyes held hers as he lowered his hand to caress her face before dropping it to his side. “Neon is car, *da?*”

“Yes.”

Mikelina interrupted their nonsensical conversation with commands to practice steps that required all of their concentration. Although he found opportunities to run his hand over her shoulders, down her arm as he switched to a new handhold. Hell, he was seducing her with the dance now, too.

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Brandi stumbled tiredly as she stepped off the ice. Seemed like she had been running all day. They had arrived home from skating at noon. She had taken a quick shower, tossed her skates on the floor, threw her ballet slippers and a clean leotard in her bag, and rushed out the door to her ballet lesson as Nikolai handed her a sandwich. She’d barely had time to change, eat some fruit and yogurt, before she made it to work at three.

Nikolai had brought her dinner there. He showed up later with both their skate bags properly stocked so they could drive to the other rink as soon as she finished her after-closing cleanup and restocking chores. The party supply store was always busier on Fridays. Weekend parties.

Tonight they would do their first complete run-through of their free dance. After his initial resistance, Yuri calmed down and started working with them on the music following the circular May Pole type dance she suggested. He said after all they were only competing against American teams.

Brandi was sure that thinly veiled in that comment was his belief that American teams were inferior skaters, and that, if they didn't succeed with a Celtic dance, next year they would be more amenable to music chosen and choreographed exclusively by him.

So they were going to win with her dance if it killed her. They were doing the foreign city tour too. They would place in international competitions. She believed it wholeheartedly. A May Day type dance was a perfect dance to splash into the competitive world with. It made a statement. We are here, and we are bringing change with us. Just like spring.

Maybe, when they were in the winter of their career would be the time to dance a full out Russian style, dark, deadly passion. It would probably suit her mood the year after the Olympics. That year there would be no reason to continue their marriage. She'd be ready to express the ugly hurt side of love.

She stood in the middle of the ice, her arms over her head. As the music began. Nikolai skated around her and caught her arm, entwining his elbow with hers, pulling her around in a circle as they started to move across the ice.

Before today they had only worked on sequences in the dance. Tonight they had already attempted three run-throughs. She had ended up on her back twice and the third time Nikolai had crashed onto all fours. Yuri had stopped the music and made them practice the sequences that tripped them up, before another attempt at a full dance.

She was determined to make it through the dance this time. Their lesson time was nearly over and she didn't want to wait over the weekend to make another attempt. It would be much better to end on a note of success rather than failure.

She mistimed an early pivot, but now wasn't the time to stop and redo. They needed a complete run-through to find the areas that needed the most practice and to see if they could keep on time with the music and generate enough speed between the intricate spins and circles they would dance.

Their boots hit each other and Nikolai stumbled away, but quickly moved back into the pattern. She again hit his thigh as she moved through his legs, and they struggled to regain their speed. She ended up on the side of her boot in one low spin. Nikolai pulled her up and moved into the lift where she rolled across his back, her back to his and then back down to move between his legs. They were off the music and finished after it had ended, but they had made it through without stopping or falling.

Yuri moved out from the boards. "We work more clean skate next time."

Brandi breathed deeply, only realizing after the stop how strenuous the full program had been. The dance was physically demanding as well as skill challenging, but she felt invigorated that they had made it through. They'd get better each time they skated the whole program.

She nodded as she glided toward the entrance. When she sat down and mopped her face with her towel, she discovered she was alone. She looked and saw Nikolai speaking to Yuri. She started to move back on the ice, when she realized they were speaking in Russian. No point in her returning. They wouldn't be saying hello or good-bye or any of the other rudimentary phrases she understood. She frowned as she unlaced her skates.

Nikolai was silent when he finally sat down beside her. There was always a sense of accomplishment and anticipation that accompanied the first complete run-through of a dance, but both of them had been quiet. They had been rough, but they had done a credible job. He should be excited and pleased, but Nikolai looked broody.

She hoped they could get some time on the ice tomorrow, during an open skate. They should try and get through the dance another time, before Monday. And Sunday they would be going out with another group of skaters.

They also had to do grocery shopping, laundry, and she would be working the whole afternoon and evening Saturday. She wanted to figure out a way to get more ice time, even if it was open skate sessions.

"Is Yuri unbending?" she asked.

Nikolai frowned.

"Does he think the dance has any merit?"

"Am sorry. You mean is has any value?"

"Yes, does he think that, or is he still against us dancing to that music?"

"He okay. He worry have too much work."

“He’s not the only one. We need to find more time to skate.”

“Quit job.”

Brandi wiped off her blades. She shook her head. “I’d rather quit ballet. I can do the exercises and stretches at home. Do you think I need it?”

“I am Russian. Think need fifty years ballet to dance.”

“Then I’d be too old to skate.” She wiped her towel across her face again.

“Maybe, I should take modern dance class,” he said.

She dropped the towel. “What do we need more? Ice time or me taking ballet lessons?”

“Us time,” he said with a small smile.

“Us wasn’t one of the options.” She dropped the towel into her bag, pulling out her athletic shoes.

“Ice time,” he answered.

“How are your feet? Do you have your boots broken in all the way?”

“*Da*.” He dropped his skates onto the carpet.

“I’m going to look. You better not be lying.”

“No lying,” he said, shoving his feet into his athletic shoes.

“I think the dance went well,” she said finally, tired of waiting for him to say anything about it. She stood in front of him.

“Need much work.” He pulled his towel out of his bag.

“But we’ve made a lot of progress. Or am I the only one who thinks so?”

“Not only one who thinks so.” He looked up at her. “You are beautiful.”

Her ears rang. She stared at him. She didn’t know if he was talking about her presentation, or more personally. Her performance needed work. Right now she wanted it to be a personal comment. She shrugged and leaned forward, kissing him on his cheek. “You look pretty good yourself.”

She grabbed her bag and headed for the door. She should have known she wouldn’t get away with a simple kiss without a response. He caught her around the waist as she was walking out of the lobby. Their skate bags clunked together.

“Tie shoes before fall,” yelled Yuri across the empty space.

Nikolai let her go and bent down, tying his shoes as instructed. Brandi held the door, watching his dark head. The warm summer air drifted into the vestibule. Brandi closed her eyes and let the warmth seep through her. She

was tired and relaxed and strangely keyed up at the same time. His blue eyes rose to hers before he stood again.

She slipped through the door, before he could fulfill the promise shining in his eyes. She made it to the car, before he tugged her skate bag off her shoulder, letting it drop beside his on the parking lot. He slid his hand along her jaw, tilting her head back questioning. They were virtually alone in the night as Yuri locked up the skating rink, climbed into his car and drove away.

Nikolai leaned forward. "Brandi, I want you."

She knew that. He couldn't have been more obvious if he painted a sign. "Okay," she answered.

He blinked.

She gave him a soft smile, and reached out to thread her fingers through his too-long hair and pull him down for a kiss. She was tired of denying what she wanted. Three years seemed like a long way away. Maybe he wouldn't want to leave her. Maybe she would be ready to try Russia.

~~*

Okay? Nikolai's mind swirled with her sudden capitulation. He didn't believe it. Couldn't believe it. She had actually pulled him into the kiss.

Who was he to look a gift horse in the mouth? He pulled her warm soft body against his, and delved into her sweet mouth. Passion swirled in him as he held her tightly against him, as if he could make them become one, by fusing their bodies together. Her touch sent bolt after bolt of unbridled heat strikes through him. He wanted her now. He wanted her forever.

Her fingers on one hand threaded through the hair lying against his neck. Her other small hand splayed out over his shoulder, her fingers stroking and kneading. He was so aware of every inch of her petite form against his. He wanted more. He wanted her skin naked against his. He wanted inside her. He slid one of his hands down to cup her, tilting her hips to cradle his hardness. His heart thundered like a freight train. He sucked in the warm night air, looking for sanity and finding only hunger.

He wanted to touch her everywhere. He didn't want to let go of her long enough to do that. He pressed his mouth against the smooth column of her graceful neck, tasting the faint salty sweetness. His mind flooded with images of her stretched out naked, her hair mussed, her body flushed, and he groaned. "I need you."

"Okay," she whispered, stretching up on her toes.

The slide of her body against his, her breasts shifting against his chest made him shudder.

“But I think maybe we ought to go home. I don’t think the back seat is big enough,” she said softly. She caught his earlobe in her teeth and tugged.

Shudder after shudder ripped through him. Was she really saying what she thought she was? “Brandi?”

“Okay,” she said. Her hands slipped around to his chest, and she tried to lean back.

He didn’t want to let go of her.

“Really, Nikolai, I don’t think we should do it in a parking lot. And we need...we need to talk about birth control.”

Not quite an icy blast of water in the face, but enough he could think sanely for a minute. But then he supposed one of them needed to be rational about this. It certainly wasn’t him. Her body softening and rounding with his child suddenly seemed an appealing picture. A new wave of desire crashed over him.

Her fingers moved against his chest, and he found her lips again. He touched his tongue to hers. The warm wet swirl of heat threatened to erase his last gasp of sanity. She shifted her hips against his, and Nikolai thrust his thigh between her legs. He pulled her against him, encouraging the rock of her hips against him, with him. He slid his hand from her hip to her breast, his thumb brushing the tight tip. He heard her soft moan with a sense of conquering the world. He cupped his palm over her breast, enjoying the way she filled his hand.

She broke away from his lips, twisting her head sideways. “Nikolai!”

He watched the deep rise and fall of her chest, felt it under his hand. He had to get control of himself. He brought his gaze up to her wide brown eyes, so dark in the night, and perhaps a little frightened. He pulled his leg back, and skimmed his hands down her flushed body. He could feel the dewy heat of her skin, the pearl drops of moisture, through her skating outfit. He didn’t want to seem frenzied to her. He wanted to spend all night making love to her, satisfying her, but he felt he had been denied her too long, and he was like a man drowning, and she was the only thing he had to cling to.

Tiny strokes.

He brushed his lips across her forehead. For her, he could do this slowly. He could restrain this overwhelming need to be a part of her for

long enough to give her the tenderness she deserved. He kissed her closed eyelids, her cheeks, her nose as he backed away from her. She blinked her eyes open as if surprised at the shift in intensity.

He bent down and grabbed the skating bags. He discovered her car keys lying on the pavement at their feet. He picked them up and handed them to her, before circling around to the passenger side. He set his bag on the hood, as Brandi fumbled with the keys. He unzipped his carryall and reached inside for a tee shirt. His long-sleeved shirt was uncomfortably hot in the warm night air. He needed to take care of his skates, remove the blade guards and wipe the moisture off. After she kissed his cheek, he had tossed everything in his bag and run through the lobby after her.

He pulled off his shirt, and met her eyes as he pulled the tee shirt over his head. She watched his every move, and he saw her swallow. She dropped her gaze. She stopped trying to open the car door. He smiled at her and leaned across the hood. "Would rather stay here?"

She dropped the keys, and bobbed down to get them. "I think we better go to the drug store."

The drug store?

She didn't look at him as she unlocked the door and leaned through to unlock the passenger door. Her cheeks were flushed.

He tossed their bags in the back seat. He closed his eyes. "No take chance?"

"Are you crazy?"

Apparently.

"A pregnancy could screw up our plans totally. I don't think we should take that kind of risk."

Which plans? Their plans to end their marriage in three years? A pregnancy this year was the only time they could consider it, if they intended to compete in the Olympics. Admittedly it would make their road a little tougher, but—what the hell was he thinking?

"We don't want to be in Alexei and Vera's situation," she added.

"I have..." He couldn't remember the English word for them. "For make safe," he finished ineffectively. These were words that didn't seem to be included in his classes or the books from school.

"Not good enough. I have a prescription," she shrugged. "I stopped by a clinic today. I should be on the pill if we really don't want to risk pregnancy. I want you to understand, if there is a slip, I won't have an

abortion. It's not that I think they're wrong. It's just that I don't think I could live with myself if I did that for a reason like inconvenience. I know it's common in Russia, but taking chances could be devastating for our career."

He brushed the back of his hand against her cheek. The way she leaned into his hand made him suck in a deep breath. "I need you, Brandi." He caught her right hand and brought it to his lips.

He had watched her flit in and out of their apartment all day. He'd been worried that she didn't have enough time to eat, let alone make love. He let her have her hand back to steer the car and reached across and put his palm on her leg. He lazily let his fingers rub in a small circle. He could feel the way she shifted in her seat.

"We slip and make baby, I take care of you," he said.

"I don't think so, Nikolai. I don't want to be a divorced single mother, whether or not you would help. That wouldn't be fair to a child."

"Be married mother."

"For two more years. Look, Nikolai, I don't want to have children right now."

"Some day wish have children?" He tried to ignore the part of her answer that reinforced her desire to end their marriage in three years. What had she called it earlier, a joke? A farce. That meant joke, didn't it?

"Yeah, maybe one or two, when I'm done competing, when I'd have time to be a mother, but not now. It's not a big deal. We'll just make sure that there isn't much chance for an accident."

His hand had tightened on her leg without him realizing it. He deliberately released tension from his fingers. He stroked his fingertips down towards her knee, and back up. How long did they need to wait before her pills would take affect? He closed his eyes. He realized it was important to her, and she was probably right—But hell, he did not want to wait a minute longer. He would, though. For her he would.

He raised his fingers and touched her cheek. "How long must I wait for you, Brandoosha?"

"You can wait until we get home, can't you?"

"*Da.*"

"Okay."

He stared at his wife, as the night breeze from her partially opened window ruffled her brown hair, while she drove through the quiet streets.

He frowned. His English was much better these days, but he didn't think he'd misunderstood their conversation. He didn't want to destroy the small hope with asking her to clarify.

Wasn't it taking longer than normal to return to their small apartment? He didn't care. He loved being with her, alone with her, the moonlight glowing on her skin, the soft caress of the summer breeze in her hair. It seemed like she was always rushing here and there. To practice, to ballet, to work, to practice again only to collapse in the wee hours of the morning. Other than ice time, they had little time alone. Funny, that he would miss the first mad frenetic week when they had done double ice time, but at least it had been with her.

Lights flashed in his eyes as Brandi turned into a parking lot. Not their parking lot. He squinted at the brightness.

"You coming in?" she asked, ducking out of the car. "I don't know how long this will take." She reached into the back seat and rummaged around in her skate bag until she unearthed her purse.

"Da."

America was an amazing and wonderful place, he thought as he followed the bouncy sway of his wife. A drugstore open after one in the morning. He stared as she made her way through the aisles and rang a little bell. The clerk watched her with a disinterested shrug. Brandi seemed totally at ease with the way she was dressed in a skate dress as she walked past the shelves and shelves of medicines and toiletries.

He was still amazed by the choices there were in the stores. In Russia, even though according to his mother things had improved since the years of communism, there were few choices in medicines, or soaps and shampoos. Here they had huge stores devoted to shelf after shelf of different items. Bandages came in bright colors, cartoon characters, light or dark skin tone, or clear, and in big, small or mixed packages.

She handed a slip of paper from her wallet to a yawning man in a white lab coat. Nikolai walked up behind her, slipping his arm around her waist. The man disappeared.

"These not work tonight, Brandoosha," he said softly. He pressed a kiss against her temple.

"Da."

"Tomorrow?" he asked, hopefully. He knew better. The pill needed to be started at the beginning of a woman's cycle.

“*Niet*,” she answered, swaying against him a minute, before pivoting away.

He followed her with his gaze, uncertain if he should stay to pay for the prescription she had turned in. She returned with a fat plastic tube.

“What is this?” he asked.

“Sunscreen.”

“Moon is in sky. Are you tired?”

“*Da*.”

He wondered if she knew how much it charmed him that she chose to answer yes and no questions in Russian. “Why do we have this?”

“For Sunday. You’ve very pale, Nikolai. I don’t want you getting a burn. I wonder if the sun ever shines in Russia.”

“Yes it does. You come see with me some day, *da*?” He put his hands on her shoulders.

She ducked her eyes away, and then was shooting across the store again. The man in the white coat returned. Nikolai reached for his wallet and realized it was out in the car, since he was still wearing his skating pants.

“You have to pay up front,” he said, walking away before Nikolai could tell him he didn’t have his wallet.

His wife was frowning over boxes of contraceptives. “You already have some of these?” she asked, tapping a box of condoms.

“*Da*,” he said, flushing. “Buy more,” he said, grabbing a box.

She carried a blue box in her hand.

“What that?”

“Sponges.”

“We need for to clean?”

“Not those kind of sponges,” she said as pink swept across her cheeks. “They’re supposed to be very safe, especially when combined with those.” She whirled and headed towards the front. “Let’s go.”

The checkout clerk was going to think they were obsessive about birth control. She didn’t even blink. Brandi handed him the bag as they walked outside.

“Here, you’re all set-up, sailor,” she said, pulling her car keys out her purse.

He reached to hold her arm, but she suddenly seemed nervous, darting away from his outstretched hand. She unlocked the car, and he slid into his

seat. He didn't even know what it was she bought. He'd never heard of sponges, but all the choices in the world were undoubtedly found in that American all-night drugstore. He fished the square box out of the bag.

"Three?" he asked shocked. "That is all, three?"

She flashed her eyes to him. They were suddenly wide in the darkness. "You were planning on a marathon?"

The rest of my life. "*Niet*, Brandoosha. I not know these. How work?"

"Good, I hope," she said while backing out of the space.

He leaned across and brushed his lips against hers. "I think you tell me wait for these." He held up the little white sack from the pharmacist. "I not realize America so prepare, easy prepare... Brandi, I—"

"I know. I want you too."

He'd been about to say more than that, but perhaps it was best she interrupted him. Or had she interrupted him so she wouldn't have to hear what he would say? She stretched her fingers out, and then curled them back around the steering wheel. Was she afraid, his brave fearless wife?

"I take care of you, Brandoosha. Not be afraid."

"*Do* not be afraid," she said.

"I not." He was too. He was afraid he would fail her somehow. Afraid he would be too Russian. Afraid there would be nothing in the end that would convince her he could give her a good American life. He stared at her, realizing he wanted an American life, more than he wanted to return to the motherland.

She smiled a small smile. "I am."

He knew. She rarely corrected his mistakes in English. Only when they were glaringly open to misinterpretation. And she usually seemed to understand him. He put his hand on her shoulder. She pulled her little car into a parking spot in front of their building. He tossed the newly purchased items into the plastic sack and grabbed their skate bags from the back seat. They crossed to the stairs hand in hand. He would have held her closer, but he was bogged down with the two bags and drugstore bag.

"We have to do laundry and shopping tomorrow morning, if we're going to do the park thing, Sunday," said Brandi.

"We sleep late, have interview over lunch."

"But I have to work from two until close tomorrow. When will we have time?" She turned to him, her brown eyes wide.

“I do chores while you work. You I wish keep in bed until noon.” For more reason than one. He worried that she didn’t get enough sleep. He frequently could take naps in the afternoon. He brushed his lips against hers as he finished unlocking their door.

He dropped the skate bags inside the door and reached for her.

“We are turning you into a modern American male, aren’t we?” she said, flowing smoothly into his open arms.

“*Da*, my mother die to see wife not cooking dinner and cleaning while I sit in chair reading newspaper,” he teased.

“Oh, Nikolai, I’m sorry.”

“*Niet*, not marry my mother, Brandoosha.” He was surprised by the flash of guilt in her eyes. “I scrub floor, wash window, cook for to be with you,” he swept her into his arms, lowering his face to kiss her. “I learn use sponge, good.” He said with a smile, before pressing a gentle kiss on her mouth.

Her arms curled around his neck, “What, you don’t know how already?”

“Know how. I need much practice.” He ran his hands down her side and then pulled her up, settling her small frame against his.

“I’m not sure you need to practice at all,” she said softly, tilting her head onto his shoulder.

“Even world champion must practice, Brandoosha,” he murmured as he nuzzled her graceful neck. He ran a hand over her dark hair. He knew she was tired, but he banished the thought of allowing her peace to sleep now. He knew he would let her sleep in tomorrow, and he hoped he would be able to relax her enough to release her exhaustion into his keeping. He ran his hands over her form, marveling at the firmness and the unexpected softness. He heard the soft catch of her breathing.

“Um, I’d better go take care of this,” she said, backing away from him and grabbing the drugstore sack.

He yanked his bag over and took care of his skates before entering the bedroom and turning back the covers on the bed. He went back to the kitchen and retrieved the champagne bottle from the refrigerator. He pulled out a couple of glasses and returned to the bedroom with them, setting them on the nightstand, turning the small reading lamp on dim, aiming it at the wall so only a soft glow fell across the room. He wished he’d thought to buy her a flower or a candle or something. He heard her behind him and

turned to see her standing uncertainly in the doorway. She twisted her hands together.

“I think this is a mistake,” she said, and chewed on her bottom lip.

He held out his hand and prayed she would come to him. “I think is dream come true.”

She smiled. “You have a very romantic nature, you know that, Nikolai?”

He shook his head. He had a Russian nature, not so very special. He took a step towards her, and she met him halfway across the room. Cradling her to him, he pressed soft kisses across her upturned face. He wanted to ease her reservations, make her forget that she had any. He wanted to believe with good American optimism that this step would cross both of them over into a real marriage. But the thought, like anything else that required the constructive use of his brain, faded into insignificance as he kissed her.

Heat swirled in heavy currents as he folded her body against his. He stroked his hands down the length of her back, loving the feel of her. She arched against him, pressing her breasts against his chest. He picked her up and laid her across the bed, leaning away only long enough to shed his tee shirt and pants.

He hoped that her breath catching the soft way it did and the bright light shining from her eyes were the beginning signs of love. He stretched out over her, trying to show her with the tender ministrations of his hands, with the deep and soft kisses, with the embrace of his arms, how much he cared, how much he loved her. Because he couldn't risk the words out loud, knowing she expected their marriage to end with the bestowal of his American citizenship.

Chapter Twelve

“Oh, Nikolai,” she sighed as he drew back from her lips, holding her eyes with his so startling blue. What was he doing? Outside the ice rink he had been driven, hard and urgent. His kisses earlier had been pressing, about physical desire and sex. Now he was making love so tenderly it was drawing her into the emotional abyss she had hoped to avoid.

His hands treasured her, his mouth worshipped her, his eyes adored her. He stroked her skin with caresses so warm and tender, tears threatened. He kissed her chin, her neck, each inch of skin he slowly exposed. This wasn't about just sex, this was about enduring passion, connection...and love. He inched up the tee shirt she wore. She moaned softly,

He stopped and ran his hand over her thigh as if he could hardly stand to interrupt his caresses long enough to undress her. “Brandi, I need you,” he whispered against her neck.

“Okay,” she whispered back.

He pulled her up to strip off her shirt. He whispered words in Russian and broken English as he rained kisses down from her shoulders, across her collarbone, down the slope of her breast as she arched for him. Her body grew heavy with desire, and she reached for him.

His groan was heavy as he shoved his black underwear off and tossed them to the floor. Hers must have landed somewhere beside his, but Brandi didn't bother to watch as she drank in Nikolai with her eyes. He was damn near perfect with his athletic physique. She'd known that, but now she could experience him with her hands, his warm smooth skin, the tensile strength in his muscles. She could finally taste the salty masculine flavor of his shoulder.

His fingers skimmed down from her breast into the dark wet place between her legs. Brandi buried her face against his chest as her hips bucked under his hand. Her fingers closed around him, and his stiff intake of breath pleased her. He was still for a minute before he resumed the lazy swirl of his finger against her.

Brandi grabbed frantically for the package on the nightstand. Nikolai shifted only enough to allow her access as he continued the provoking pattern of his finger. She ripped the box, spilling half the contents on the floor. She tried handing him a packet, but he took the opportunity to kiss her, his tongue mimicking the pattern of his finger.

“You do. I am busy,” he said, softly as he pulled back.

She didn't know if she could. She ripped open the packet with her teeth and reached with both hands to do the task. She made it torture for him, her fingers sliding up and over him, around, and up and down, until he was straining against her. After all, turn about was fair play. She couldn't take much more of his incredibly slow, loving tenderness. Her body was pitched hotter than any inferno. She needed hard, hot, driving passion. If he wouldn't, she would. She pushed him back and straddled him. She pushed her breasts down against him, found his mouth for a deep open kiss.

He answered her needs with a swift upward thrust of his hips, filling her and making her sob with relief. She rocked against him, and his fingers dug into her hips. "*Da*," she whispered in a gasp for breath.

He muttered words in Russian, or maybe they were in English and she was too caught in the spiral of sensation to understand or respond. She moaned as the damn burst within her pulsing with a mad rush that left her melded into him. Nikolai thrust into her, rolling her to her back as she flowed into him. His own cry was music to her as he slumped against her, while the intense throb of his body echoed the absorbing pulse of hers. She couldn't tell which throbbing beat originated in her body and which came first from him. They were as good as one creature. His pleasure was as much hers as her own.

She stroked her hands down his sweat-dampened skin. His lips pressed against her shoulder. His chest heavily rose and fell of against hers. He wrapped his arms around her tighter, embracing her. She felt like she had to tell him something, but the thing she wanted to tell him was the wrong thing. She didn't want him to feel like she was vulnerable. She was too floaty and sated to risk any unpleasantness. She wouldn't burden him with unreasonable expectations.

Her body was like a cooked noodle, limp and boneless. Nikolai backed off of her. She whimpered a protest, but he quickly pulled her against him, resting his head on his elbow right beside her head.

"Are okay, Brandoosha?" asked Nikolai, fixing his intense blue eyes on her face.

"I don't think I've ever felt this good in my life," she said.

He smiled.

"You know, Nikolai. You should smile more often. You are so beautiful when you smile."

He wrinkled his forehead. "Beautiful for women." He stroked his hand over her warm body.

"Men can be beautiful, too," she whispered.

"Beautiful is for you, my wife."

She felt herself flushing. "*Spasibo*."

His eyes glittered as he pulled her into a tight hug and pressed a kiss on her hair. "Thank-you," he repeated back in a rough whisper.

"What is 'you're welcome' in Russian?"

"*Pazhaluista*."

"I thought that was please."

"Is close." His hands continued to stroke over her cooling skin.

She tried to say the word.

He laughed. "Please what?"

"I don't make fun of your English. You shouldn't tease me."

"Make me much happy. I happy laugh," he whispered. He caught her hand and put it over his heart. "No make fun."

"Okay," she answered. Really she was too relaxed to be bothered if he was laughing at her. If she made him laugh by garbling his native language he was probably in for a lot of laughs, and that meant smiles for her. That wasn't such a bad exchange. She shifted against him wanting to smooth out the slight tension she felt in his body. She snuggled her body against his and tilted her head back so she could look up at her husband.

She blinked wondering if his tender indulgent look meant as much as she wanted to believe it did. She touched his cheek softly. He captured her hand and held it against his face. "Are sleepy, little one?"

"*Da*."

He hugged her and reached down to pull the covers over them. There was so much she wanted to tell him, but she drifted to sleep quickly. The mad pace of the week and the total mellow peace of her body was a drugging mix.

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Nikolai woke to find her warm body curled against his. He stroked her soft hair back from her face. She scrunched her nose and shifted away from his hand. He didn't want to wake her. She needed her sleep. He remembered her unexpected capitulation and her eager hunger with a rise of his blood. She was his wife in flesh now. He wanted to hold her to him and never let go.

Her tan skin caught the pale morning light filtering in from the open door to the living room. He longed to stroke it, taste it and slake his thirst for her again. He brushed his lips against her bared shoulder. She shifted in her sleep. Nikolai held perfectly still, angry with himself for not controlling his urge to wake her and make her his again.

He shouldn't wake her. If he meant to take care of her, he couldn't wake her with his mindless need to feel her around him again. He inched away from her as her breathing settled into the slow heavy pattern of deep sleep again. His body was hard with want for her, but he forced himself out from under the covers.

As quietly as could he dressed, then gathered their laundry to take to the laundromat later, and fixed himself breakfast. She slept on.

He stood in the doorway watching her, wanting her and forcing himself to move away when he was millimeters away from rejoining her in their bed. In three years he would have her many times, enough times for her pleasure to grow to love for him, he hoped. But at this fragile stage he would do nothing to risk her withdrawal. He would protect her from his selfish need to make love to her as often as he wished.

And as he waited for her to wake there was nothing he wanted more. Her continued sleep surprised him, and dismayed him when the time before they had to leave grew too short to even consider rejoining her in the bed if she showed the slightest sign of welcome. And he ached.

"Is silly, you only have her few hour ago," he told himself sternly.

His body didn't care.

He paced the living room. Finally, when she needed to be up in order to make it to the interview in time, he woke her.

She stretched and slowly opened her eyes. Her soft womanly smile invited him back to bed, and he was so willing to forget the interview that he nearly threw off his clothes and crawled back in bed with her.

She stretched out her bare arms to him. Under the sheet she wore nothing. One glimpse of her and he wouldn't care about the interview, he wouldn't care about their skating future, he wouldn't care about anything but joining their flesh together.

Nikolai started to sweat. Didn't she realize how thin his control was? "Not have time, much, for interview."

She frowned.

He'd said something backwards, but he couldn't sort it out. He knew somewhere in the back of his mind that getting more sponsors meant she wouldn't have to work and they could spend more time in bed. His mind shouted, Do this interview! Do this! Do this! His body cried out for the denial of her sweetness.

"Must leave soon. Get ready." He pulled the door shut after he backed out of it.

His heart was beating madly. But he had to get her out of the apartment before he touched her, or there was no way they'd ever leave.

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Brandi shifted in her seat, wondering if the interview would ever finish. She pushed another cold French fry into her mouth. She was worried about making it to her job on time, and she was conscious of the pile of laundry and grocery shopping that Nikolai had said he'd do. She felt bad he was taking over so many of the domestic duties. He had to fix dinner most nights because she was at the record store. But meals like this, even if they might drum up future sponsors, had to be paid for.

She had been surprised when he woke her with barely enough time to make it to the interview. She had reached up to kiss him, but he backed away, saying the interview was too important to miss. She hadn't been suggesting that they miss the interview. She just meant to show him how much she... She frowned at her plate. He hadn't spared his kisses in front of the interviewer.

She cast an uneasy glance at him. He squeezed her thigh under the table. She rolled her eyes. She had been gracious and smiled right through him telling the woman from the skating magazine that he fell in love with her almost the first time he saw her.

"Brandi worry to make job on time," he told their interviewer. He signaled their waiter, and settled his arm around her shoulder.

"Oh, where do you work?"

Brandi figured it was a reciprocal arrangement. She didn't really want strangers stopping in to meet her at the party supply store, but at the same time, if the store was sponsoring her with a hundred dollars a month, they deserved the increase in business. She gave the name of the store and plugged it as sincerely as she could manage. "They are even helping to sponsor us in our skating."

At least it was a change in subject. She didn't want to talk about the perceived impression that Nikolai had thrown over a better skater to skate with a woman he loved. Nikolai had apparently been prepared for the question. He calmly and convincingly told the woman he would have skated with Brandi without hope of a personal relationship, purely based on her skating and her ability to deal with pressure. He talked about reviewing videos of her skating and discussing her potential with his coaches. He said he was thrilled to find out Brandi returned his interest.

The interviewer turned to Brandi and asked her how she had decided to skate with Nikolai. "I skated with him at Lake Placid."

"And it went good?"

"It went terrible. We fell, and I rammed my knee into the ice, but I could feel the potential. I knew it would be great. Nikolai is such a great skater and very well trained."

Nikolai squeezed her leg. "Skate was like magic. She skate fast with me, right away."

The interviewer told them she'd take care of the check, and asked if she could take a couple of photographs. Nikolai smiled and said, "Yes. We wait outside."

He led her by the hand outside the restaurant. "Brandi, what wrong?" he asked, turning to her on the sidewalk.

She looked away. "I'm sorry. We just have so much to do, and I shouldn't have slept so late. I was hoping we could get some time on the ice today. Now, I need to work. Maybe, we can do an open session for a couple of hours after that. I just have a hard time sitting for two hours trying to say all these wonderful things about myself without sounding like a conceited, self-absorbed witch."

She stopped, knowing that it exasperated Nikolai when she kept rattling on too much. She knew it was because he had a hard time following the totally random pattern of her thoughts.

"You say I good. I say you good. Not have to say, I good," Nikolai said.

"Fine." It was more than that though.

She didn't want to tell him how hard it was for her to sit and listen to him tell some stranger that he loved her, and that their marriage was more than what it was. She didn't even know what it was. She was shocked when he pulled away from a simple gesture of affection before they left as if the only thing she could want was to make love—have sex—or whatever.

He pulled her to him, and she couldn't help but cling.

"Quit job. We have more sponsors with some interviews."

"I can't quit my job, Nikolai."

"Not work today. We skate...instead." He started to say *after*. After they made love again. This morning as he paced through their little apartment, hungry to wake her and make mad, passionate love to her again, his control had been tenuous at best. Even now as she held him, and he cradled her to him, he wanted her.

He was in over his head.

"I need this job."

No she didn't. They just needed some more sponsors. They needed more training time. He wanted to take dance classes with her. Of course they would need new costumes and money for travel, but he would find a way to get it. The flash of light told him they were no longer alone. He turned and saw their interviewer with her camera. He pulled Brandi in front of him, wrapping his arms around her. "Smile," he said grimly.

She said 'you're welcome' in Russian, which was exactly what he needed. An indulgent grin broke across his own face. He tugged her back against him as the camera snapped. He suspected the pictures would have exactly the kind of playful in-love look he wanted to project. But he wanted it to be more than an act. He wanted it to be real. He wanted her to be his wife in flesh, heart and soul. He had the first part, he hardly dared to hope for the last part.

"Please," he said, after the interviewer thanked them and walked to her own car.

She gave him a bright smile. "Happy?"

"Yes."

"Good, because I'm going to be late."

"Go there. I walk home."

"Oh hell, Nikolai, you can drive, can't you?" she said, moving to the car.

"*Da*. I think English okay to do test. I try license Monday."

"Is that what you were waiting on? Being able to pass the written test?"

"Yes. I have Russian license, but I no get international license."

"You just take the car, okay. I feel bad enough, leaving you with all the shopping and laundry. Just don't speed or anything."

Good, then maybe he would have time to pick up something to show her how he felt about her. Something more than flowers. He just wished he knew what that was.

A pretty good idea hit him when he was stripping the sheets from the bed to take to the laundromat.

He picked up three daisies from the florist on the way to take her dinner. She smiled at him when he came in the store, but she cast a quick anxious glance at her boss. “Thanks, Nikolai,” she said as he handed her the plastic plate.

He handed her the daisies. He could see the softening in her expression. “Shopping done. Laundry done. I clean dishes. Would want skate when done? Open session to midnight?”

“*Da*,” she stepped to the side to ring up a customer, laying the daisies on the counter and snatching them up after she was done.

He was hoping she’d say no. He’d rather take her home and spend the two hours in her arms.

“We need to, don’t we?”

He smiled. “Need ice, *da*. Want us time much.”

“More,” she finished or corrected, her voice breathy and soft reminding him of the night before.

Her boss came up beside her then. She ducked her eyes anxiously. “Nikolai just was leaving. He brought my dinner.” She thrust her flowers back at him. “Would you put these in water for me at home?”

Nikolai glanced at the short round man. Nikolai didn’t care for the man. What difference did it make if he hung around until his wife could eat her dinner with him? But the man had told Brandi, her husband couldn’t sit in the break room, and he didn’t want her eating outside in the parking lot. Nikolai would question her about it later. “*Da*. I bring skates later.”

“Great, thanks, honey,” she smiled.

He turned and left. He couldn’t even feel particularly happy that she had called him honey. He didn’t know if she’d done it to emphasize her marriage to her boss, or to keep up the pretense of a perfect marriage.

She was exhausted when they returned home after skating. He was concerned that she seemed so tired, especially after sleeping so late this morning. The way she dragged up the stairs surprised him a little. She sank down on the couch to remove her tennis shoes.

He took a quick shower, and, when he returned to the living room, she was sound asleep her hand curled under her face against the arm of the couch. She had told him her boss was angry when she was a half-hour late, and he had her moving boxes for several hours. She'd also told him she had to work tomorrow afternoon from two until six, because one of the other store employees was out sick. So they needed to take their own car to the park.

He stood toweling himself off, watching her sleep. He picked her up and carried her to bed. She turned into him sleepily. He laid her down, pulled off her pants. Fortunately, she had worn an ordinary long-sleeved tee shirt and legging type stretch pants to skate in the open session skate. He left her shirt on. Then he left her alone long enough for her to drift back to sleep. He finally crawled in beside her, and cuddled up to her.

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Brandi woke up and stared around her, surprised she was in bed. She remembered taking off her shoes and nothing more. She sat up and rubbed her eyes. Nikolai entered the room, dressed in jeans and a light blue tee shirt.

"What time is it?" she asked. Her voice was rough. She coughed a little to clear it up.

"Eight. Would like breakfast?"

She shook her head. "I don't remember going to bed."

"I carry you. You asleep on couch." He leaned back against the doorjamb.

"I'm sorry."

"Niet." He folded his arms across his chest. He frowned slightly.

Brandi started to push back the covers when she realized something was different. She pulled the sheets back up and smoothed out the bedspread. It had wide teal green stripes with narrow lines of bright yellow and fuchsia. Definitely not putty colored.

"Wow! Where did this come from?" She cleared her throat again, because it still felt scratchy.

"You like?" asked Nikolai.

"Da," she answered. "Very much."

"Are okay?"

"I'm fine," said Brandi, pushing back the covers and swinging her legs down. Maybe her throat wouldn't feel scratchy after she drank something.

She was probably just a little dehydrated. She'd been too tired after skating last night to properly replenish her fluids. "What time are we leaving?" She crossed toward the doorway.

"In hour."

Nikolai reached out for her as she neared him. She went into his arms, with almost relief. She was pretty sure he had slept beside her. She had a vague recollection of snuggling against him.

"I like the bedspread. Does it remind you of Russia?" Was he trying to claim a little of their space before she covered the whole place with bright posters from the party supply store? She had brought home a couple of the promotional posters with interesting and bright pictures on them. They were free and helped add color to the boring brown apartment. She'd tacked them up in the living room.

"No. Buy for make you happy. You no like old bedspread. Want bright, *da?*"

"*Da, spasibo.*"

"You are welcome," he said, kissing her nose. His gaze dropped to her lips, but he pushed her away, patting her rear. "Must get ready, must eat."

"I'm not very hungry. I'll just have some juice."

He watched as she stood at the tiny counter in their kitchen and slowly drank a glass of orange juice.

"What?" she asked.

"Would want stay home?"

"And do what?"

"Go bed."

She flushed. The idea was tempting, but she hadn't expected Nikolai to be so blunt about it. "What would your friends think?" She turned her back to him. "No, we should go. We said we would."

The day promised to be hot. She dressed in jean shorts and a tank top. When she pulled her car into the parking lot in front of the conservatory where the group had agreed to meet, she reached into her purse and brought out the sunscreen.

Nikolai scanned the area. "They are there," he said pointing to a group standing near the entrance. He took a step in that direction.

"Wait, we've got to put this on you."

"*Niet*, I not care."

"Trust me. You'll care if you get a sunburn."

He frowned.

She lowered her sunglasses and looked at him over the top. "Come on, do it for me."

"I do for you, my wife."

He stood impatiently while she put some lotion on her fingertips and smoothed it across his face. She dabbed more in her palms and smoothed it over his arms. His blue eyes took on a different light. His gaze dropped over her shoulders.

"Is for you too? I put on you."

She pulled the bottle away as he reached for it. "No, I don't need it. I already have a tan. I won't burn."

His voice dropped low. "Not burn for me, Brandoosha?"

Now if he'd said those words in that tone before they left, no doubt they would have gone to bed as he so less than charmingly suggested before they left. Perhaps she should have made more allowances for the language barrier.

"We better go join the others," said Brandi. She capped the sunscreen and put it back in her purse.

He caught her arm, before she could move away. "I burn for you."

"But now you don't have to," she said brightly. On one level she was disappointed that he wanted to make his sexual desire for her so clear. On the other she wanted him to fall in love the way she was and maybe sex would help. Since he ended up cooking most of their real meals, she certainly wasn't going to be able to go through his stomach. Besides he made love to her so tenderly, there had to be some emotion there. He had to feel more for her than just animal lust, didn't he?

He smiled, as if that was an answer to her unasked question. Putting his arm around her he walked toward the group. A long, tall, skinny woman broke free and ran towards him.

Tatiana.

"I thought she was in Russia," whispered Brandi.

Tatiana threw her arms around Nikolai's neck. He pulled free from Brandi and gave the woman a brief hug and kissed her cheek. Brandi felt a swirl of jealousy, especially when Tatiana started speaking in Russian and Brandi couldn't catch more than every fourth word, and none of them made sense out of context.

She closed her eyes. Nikolai curled his arm back around her waist and led her forward to the group. Tatiana came with them her arm latched with Nikolai's on the other side.

"Is my wife, zhen, Brandi," he said. He recited names as each of the group stepped forward and shook her outstretched hand. But when each of them moved from her, they all reached out and hugged and kissed Nikolai on the cheek, women and men alike. She wondered if she was being given a less enthusiastic greeting because she was a foreigner to them. Or was it just because she was a stranger?

She noted with dismay that many of them had not achieved even Nikolai's rather limited mastery of English, and of course she had much farther to go in learning Russian. When one of the younger men stumbled over a greeting in English, she responded in Russian.

He spoke back to her in Russian and she had to use the other phrase she'd mastered, "*Ya ne ponimayu.*" I don't understand.

He grinned, and they both shrugged. She turned to ask Nikolai to tell the young man maybe next year they could communicate, and found he had been drawn aside by Tatiana. They stood a little apart, discussing something. She strained to hear the low conversation, but of course the stray words she picked up were in Russian.

Tatiana reached up and wiped her fingers across a tiny white smear of sunscreen near Nikolai's ear. If he hadn't been so impatient, he wouldn't have had any smears. She watched him half smile and focus an indulgent look on his former partner.

Brandi wanted to scream, *No, he's mine now.* Only everyone would think she'd lost her mind. And she had told him that if he wanted to skate with Tatiana she would understand. Her own stupid overreaction to Alexei's revelation of Nikolai's plan to return to Russia after his competition days were done and marry a woman there. Which she had known all along that something like that was the plan. And Alexei couldn't have realized that Nikolai probably hadn't changed his mind.

Was he even now discussing how badly their first run-through of their free dance had gone? Was he making plans to rejoin Tatiana, if not right away, at least next season?

His blue eyes were fixed on Tatiana as if his wife and partner had suddenly become invisible to him. He nodded and reached his arm around Tatiana's shoulders. Brandi's throat caught and she had to clear it.

Alexei steered the group toward the building where they could view the aquariums. Nikolai didn't seem to notice that his wife was alone as they moved into the rooms with tanks. She walked as part of the group although she understood little of the conversation that was going on around her. She stared into a tank of fish all too aware that Nikolai and Tatiana had dropped behind.

Okay, she was not going to succumb to emotion now. She knew she had a lot more emotionally invested in their marriage, but that wasn't his fault. It wasn't anyone's fault. It wasn't anyone's fault that Tatiana was head and shoulders above her in skill. Okay, only a head above in height and skill.

Brandi coughed, the lump in her throat growing larger. Her sunglasses would only hide so much, she thought to herself in dismay. And everyone probably wondered why she was still shading her eyes while they were inside.

Vera moved up beside her and softly said, "Hello."

Although Brandi had seen her several times, she hadn't had much opportunity to talk to her.

"How are you doing?" asked Brandi. She shoved the glasses up. With any luck Vera would interpret any worried look as concern about her. Not that Brandi wasn't concerned, since Vera seemed to be experiencing difficulties with her pregnancy. "Are you going to be okay today?"

Vera shrugged. "My doctor says walking is okay, but he wants me to go easy with strenuous exercise. I'm having a few problems with the pregnancy."

Brandi made herself turn to the other woman. "I don't know whether I should be offering you congratulations on the baby or condolences on the problems."

Vera smiled. "You know, I thought because I was an athlete, having a baby would be a snap. I'm ultra healthy, right? But my blood pressure is too high. My doctor was very worried because it is still early in my pregnancy."

Brandi made a murmur of sympathy.

"But it is okay. My husband waited many years to start a family and now he gets a double dose."

"You're having twins?"

Vera nodded. "Shhh, Alexei doesn't know. My husband doesn't either, but I will tell them soon. They are great friends my husband and Alexei. I'm afraid when he learns he won't let me on the ice at all."

“Wow!”

Vera grabbed her arm. “Do not tell, Nikolai. I’m sorry, I shouldn’t have put you in the position of making you keep secrets from your husband, but I had to tell someone.” As they moved into another room, Vera pulled her off to the side.

Brandi smiled. The other woman’s enthusiasm showed through. Besides if she could keep the secret of her real feelings, how hard would it be to keep quiet about Vera’s twins?

“Twins are good because I have two children with one pregnancy and then I won’t take off more time from skating. That will make Alexei and my husband happy.” Vera rattled around in a purse and pulled out a black and white picture with yesterday’s date printed in white letters across the top, and Vera’s name on the bottom.

Brandi stared at it a minute before realizing it was a sonogram picture with two fetuses showing. “Do you know what they are?”

“I asked them not to tell me the sexes. If you can tell, don’t tell me. Hell, I’m not even sure they’re babies, but there are two blobs there.”

Brandi studied the picture. “Look, you can tell. Here’s the head on this one, and this is the other one’s or a really big foot.” Brandi handed back the photograph.

Vera turned and answered a question in Russian, before looking back to Brandi. She leaned her head close and whispered, “The really bad thing is, since I have a high risk pregnancy I have to stay here in the States. At home the doctors would insist on a C-section. I may still have to have one here.”

“Eew, no fun.”

“Not only not fun, but it would mean there is no chance I could skate at all this coming season.”

Brandi patted her hand in mute sympathy. She opened her mouth to ask if Tatiana had made a commitment to fill-in for the part of the season that Vera would miss.

Vera cut her off, before she could get the question out. “Shhh don’t say anything, Alexei is right behind you. Most of the rest of them don’t speak English very well. Or at least not well enough to understand what I’m saying about you-know-what.”

“You speak English really well,” she said, realizing that Vera hardly had an accent.

Vera smiled. "My mother is half-American. My grandmother is from upstate New York and she moved back there when my grandfather died. We visited every other year when I was a child." She laughed. "You know what's really funny?"

Brandi shook her head.

"When we were kids in Moscow, the coaches talked about making me and Nikolai partners. I'm only two years older than he is, but his mother didn't want him having anything to do with a partner that wasn't Russian, and especially not one that was part American."

"Oh," said Brandi her heart sinking. Was that why he was so reluctant to let her even say hello to his mother?

"Don't worry, she'll get over it when she sees how good a skater you are and that you make her son happy." Vera winked conspiratorially at her.

"I hope so," said Brandi dispiritedly. She wouldn't need to get over it with the divorce already planned.

"I think they've decided we'll see the gardens next and then have a picnic lunch." She cocked her head sideways and listened to the jumble of Russian voices. "Oops, I think your husband is looking for you. Don't tell him, please?" Vera squeezed her arm and let go.

Brandi nodded, faintly bewildered by the confidences of the woman she hardly knew. Vera turned to another woman and started talking just as quickly in Russian.

Nikolai wrapped his arm around her waist.

"What did Tatiana want?"

She could feel his body stiffen, and he gave a tiny shake of his head. "*Niet*, private."

Shock that he would refuse to discuss his conversation with Tatiana deepened her fears. Tears burned at the back of her eyelids. She didn't know if she should demand he tell her or ask if his discussion with Tatiana affected her future and calmly insist if that was true that he should at least explain it to her.

Chapter Thirteen

She was silent as they moved through the rest of the aquatic exhibits. Nikolai hardly seemed to notice that she rarely commented as they viewed the fish. Except when the group was once again outside he turned to her with a concerned look on his face. “Are okay?”

She nodded.

“Is wish talk?” he asked, still looking concerned. “Is something bothers you?”

Didn’t he remember telling her that his conversation with Tatiana was private? Didn’t he think that exclusion would bother her? She didn’t need to know every word they’d exchanged. She just needed to know if their conversation affected her or not. Surely, that wasn’t too much to ask. She waited for him to remember, but he just appeared more puzzled by her silence. She finally shook her head.

“Is sure?”

The only thing she was sure of was that she wouldn’t remain calm through a discussion right now. The rest of the group was headed off toward the long rows of flowers. She pulled out of his loose embrace.

“Brandi, is time go.”

“I’m”—she searched her brain for an excuse to be alone with her misery—“hungry. There’s a hot dog vender over there. I think I’ll get one. Go on, I’ll catch up.”

He frowned at her and folded his arms across his chest. “*Niet*, I wait.”

“Go on, Nikolai. It’ll just take me a minute.”

“Should have eat breakfast.”

“I wasn’t hungry then.” She wasn’t hungry now. If she bought a hot dog, she’d want to rip off half of it and ditch in the nearest trash basket. She just didn’t want to be with him while her emotions were so tangled.

Nikolai reached out for her sunglasses. She backed up another step, turning as if she hadn’t seen what he was about to do.

“Is problem?” asked Alexei, looking back and forth between them.

“*Niet*,” answered Nikolai.

“I’m just going to get something to eat. I skipped breakfast.” Brandi turned and loped off toward the stand and the sickening smell of roasted meat.

~~*

Nikolai watched her walk away from him wondering if he should have insisted they stay home. Her excessive sleep yesterday and her watery eyes—At least he thought her eyes were watering. Inside he thought he saw her wipe them a few times. But now back outside, seeing through the dark lenses of her sunglasses he couldn't be sure—but her symptoms made him think she might be coming down with a cold or flu.

He just wanted to confirm his suspicions by removing her glasses and seeing her eyes in the daylight, but she darted away from his hands.

"Is she pregnant?" asked Alexei. "This how Vera acted at first."

Nikolai considered a moment. Could symptoms of pregnancy start in a day? Probably not. Beside they had used more barricades than the Kremlin used during attack. "*Niet.*"

"So sure?" asked Alexei with a suspicious look.

"She is my wife." He lapsed into Russian. "It is possible, but pregnancy isn't likely." For a brief second he wished she were pregnant. It would make some things simpler, and other things infinitely more complicated, but a baby would need a father and give another longer reason to hold their marriage together.

"Do you have many fights?"

"*Niet.*"

Alexei shook his head as if he didn't believe him. "Fire and ice bad mix?"

Confusing mix, thought Nikolai. He watched his wife hand the vender money and then take the paper wrapped item. Fatal mix if the fire was only built on ice. If the marriage was based only on their skating, it was bound to fail.

Brandi turned toward them. While walking back, she brought her thumb up to her lips. Nikolai lost himself in the idea of her doing what she did to her thumb to him, his fingers, his lips, his—

"I see is still much fire," commented Alexei.

On his side anyway. He hadn't missed her dismayed look this morning when she misinterpreted his suggestion that she go back to bed. He had meant to fight off whatever bug was dragging her down, she should spend the morning resting instead of running around the park with his friends.

Nikolai thought about the blue box in the bathroom. He knew her body rhythms. The count of three meant one per week until she would start on the pill. He frowned wondering if there was a message in her only buying the

one box. Hard to know with Brandi. She didn't always plan things out. On the other hand it could be her way of reminding him that he could expect no more than three years.

"What are you talking about?" asked Brandi as she joined them. She took a bite of her hot dog and looked at it with a sour expression.

"Is bad, no eat."

"No, there's nothing wrong with it."

"We talk about fire and ice," said Alexei.

"I hope everyone isn't waiting on us."

"No they go ahead," answered Alexei.

"What about fire and ice? Like an abstract conversation about which way the world will end?"

"*Niet*," Nikolai said futilely. He wanted the conversation to end not the world.

Apparently some of the others had hung back waiting on either them or Alexei.

"I think Nikolai want to kill something when you insist 'ice dancing only' at restaurant in Lake Placid. I had been teasing him about what he want more with you. Fire or ice. I guess he convince you to want both."

"*Niet*," said Nikolai. He didn't want to talk about what he wanted and how many promises he had broken. He wouldn't make them any more. He wouldn't promise to keep his hands off of her again, not so long as she showed the least willingness to let him have her. He'd meant it every time, but she was too far under his skin to resist. He'd want her and love for the rest of time.

Brandi cast a suspicious glance up at him.

He debated about issuing a warning to Alexei in Russian, but he didn't know how much Brandi understood. He hadn't even known she was learning it.

It was too late anyway as they rejoined their group and Alexei said, "Then I hear that to become citizen much easier when married to an American. Marriage is so fast."

"*Niet*, Alexei," protested Nikolai.

"Yeah, it takes only three years instead of five," supplied Brandi.

"Is how he convince you to mix fire and ice?" asked Alexei. He pushed playfully at Nikolai's shoulder.

“Of course. There’s no other way he’d become a US citizen in time for the next Olympics. And we aren’t going to be able to stay eligible forever. We couldn’t wait seven years for next chance to compete in one.”

Nikolai stopped walking, stunned that she would admit the whole basis for their marriage was getting his citizenship. He didn’t even care that her careless statement might have jeopardized his chances of ever getting his citizenship. He didn’t care that she had just shamed him in front of his friends, who if they didn’t understand the conversation would soon have it translated for them. He cared that she still thought the only reason for their marriage was to get his citizenship.

He could hardly stand to look at his friends whose horrified expressions spoke volumes. Vera moved away from the group. Nikolai knew she’d understood. She spoke English better than he did.

Brandi must have realized she made a major mistake. How could she not realize when all the English-speaking contingent of the group fell silent. And the others were passing speculative whispers between them. “It’s not like it matters why we got married, just so long as we’re still married in three years.”

“And living as husband and wife,” said Vera softly.

“Well we are doing that,” answered Brandi.

Vera pulled on Brandi’s arm and whispered to her.

Nikolai was paralyzed. He didn’t know if he should yell at her or pretend the statement was of no consequence. Underneath it all burned a dread that achieving his citizenship was still the only reason she had for their marriage. He ran his hand up his arm and discovered he had no sleeves to push up.

Brandi sought out his eyes. He could see her mortification at the impact her statement had made. A wash of tenderness swept over him. He didn’t care why she had said it. On one level he was dismayed by the larger repercussions both personally and professionally, but the lying had always bothered her.

He turned to Alexei and spoke in Russian, “Perhaps you were right my friend.”

“About a possible pregnancy or that you had a fight?”

Nikolai shrugged. Let them think what they would. He needed to find out what was going on with his wife and how to stop her from blurting out more details of their marriage plans. “We need a time alone.”

He stretched out his hand and prayed she would take it and not shame him further in front of his friends. “Brandi.”

She did better than that. She hurtled herself against his chest and whispered, “I’m sorry,” against his neck.

Surprised by the full assault on his senses. Her gentle sweet scent, the press of her breast against his chest, her warm breath against his neck, her hair feather soft against his chin all stunned him into inaction. He stood still for a moment, before belatedly wrapping his arms around her and cradling her to him.

“Are they watching us?” whispered Brandi, stretching up on her toes to put her mouth by his ear.

Nikolai couldn’t think of anything but her. He reluctantly forced his attention to his friends. They were moving down the path and he could hear Alexei making a joke about newlyweds and their arguments. Vera teased Alexei that he had no idea how difficult marriage could be, since he’d never done it himself.

“They go ahead.”

She leaned away from him, and he let his hands slide to her sides.

“What did you say to Alexei?”

“You no understand?” She must not comprehend the Russian word for pregnancy yet.

She shook her head, tight-lipped. She tried to back further away.

He refused to let her go so easily. He hoped she understood that he would always try to hold her. No more keeping his hands to himself. No more letting her dictate the physical terms of their marriage. He wouldn’t ever force her, but he would touch her, hold her. He didn’t want her to pull away now. “*Niet.*”

Her lip trembled. “Why won’t you tell me?”

He stared at her, not understanding the emotion in her words, and nearly frantic as a tear dripped down from under her sunglasses and she swiped at it. He needed to fix whatever was wrong. His heart thumped with a feeling of helplessness that angered him and bewildered him.

“Not pull away, Brandoosha. *Niet* cry.”

“I don’t understand.”

She wasn’t the only one.

“If you didn’t understand something that was said, I’d try and explain it to you.”

She was upset because he hadn't told her what he and Alexei had said? That couldn't be all of the problem, she had been upset before that. "He ask what wrong? I do not know. I say need be alone."

They weren't alone now. People were walking past them and giving them odd looks.

"That's all?"

No, not all, but he didn't want to tell her that he had claimed at least the honors of possible parenthood. Although why it should embarrass her since they were married he wasn't sure. He was sure he didn't want to do more damage. "Come, we find private place to sit."

She bent down and scooped up something from the ground. "I need to find a trash can."

He saw it was her half-eaten hot dog. Now that was something he could fix.

"I'm sorry. I'm ruining this whole day. I don't know why I said that in front of your friends. I didn't mean to embarrass you. I just got to thinking that there was no reason that we couldn't say that your citizenship was a reason we got married in the first place. I mean the immigration department will probably ask us why we got married after only knowing each other a month or so.

He steered her in the direction of the street vender. "Know a year. Bucharest."

"We can't really say we *knew* each other there."

"*Da*, talk there. You say, yes, yes, yes, think positive. I have to ask Vera what mean."

She stopped walking. "Nikolai, nobody is going to believe that you wanted to marry me because I told you to think positive."

"Is no only why." It didn't occur to him that she wouldn't understand that he was attracted to her then.

"You were thinking of splitting with Tatiana back then?"

"*Da*." That had been the last chance in his mind.

"And you were thinking about me as a possible partner?"

Nikolai wasn't sure this was the conversation they needed to have, but he could see the hot dog vender now and steered them toward the man and his cart. The idea of her becoming his partner hadn't really formed there, but the seed had been planted. "I see you better skater than Kevin."

She looked around. "Where are we going?"

"I get you new dog."

"What?"

"You drop. I get you new."

She stopped. "No, I don't need one."

Why wouldn't she let him fix this for her? "You hungry?"

"I'm okay now."

He looked at the remains of her meal in her hands. She'd only taken a couple of bites. If there was a slim chance she was pregnant, she needed to eat. "Is bad?"

"No, it was really good. I'm just not hungry any more."

He crossed his arms. "I get you."

"There's a trash can," she said moving toward a barrel near the sidewalk.

Nikolai moved to the vender's cart. He had to wait while a man in front of him ordered.

Brandi tugged on his arm. "I don't need another one."

He stepped up to order. He said to the man in his white apron, "Want dog, and is drinks?"

The vender answered with a list of drinks, but she whispered, "Nikolai," in a protest as the man was reciting the list.

Nikolai only caught the man's final question, "How ya want that hot dog fixed?"

Nikolai turned to her. "How want?"

She rolled her eyes and told the vender, "Mustard and relish."

"Is have purple pop?"

"No, two Cokes," said Brandi.

Nikolai pulled out his wallet to pay, and she inched away from him. Was she that embarrassed about his failure to master the English language? He knew enough to order food. And most people were patient with him if it took more than one try. "Is place sit by tree," he said nodding to a shaded grassy spot near a small body of water.

She took her hot dog and moved off before he had finished paying.

He followed her with the cold cans of pop.

She stood under the tree looking across the water.

"Sit."

"Maybe, I should go home. Alexei or someone could drop you off. I'm just ruining this outing."

He made a concentrated effort to speak entirely in English. “No, please sit down.”

She paced.

“I don’t know why I blurted that out like that. I mean I guess I wanted them to be able to figure it out when we get a divorce.”

She turned to face him. Only her dark lenses greeted his search for her expression. He wanted to remove her sunglasses.

He turned away and moved to sit leaning against the trunk of the tree, facing the water. “Must not tell plan for to divorce,” he said finally.

If she blurted that out to someone than there would be no point in going on. Unless her plan was to make the marriage pointless. “Want Olympics, *d*—yes?”

“Yes,” her voice was barely audible.

He patted the ground beside him. She knelt beside him, her hot dog in her hand untouched. He opened one of the Coke cans and set it between them, opened the other and took a drink.

“Is important show marriage real then. I be with you. You home, stay.”

He heard her sniff and turned to look at her. He reached up to pull off her sunglasses. Her eyes were red-rimmed. She closed them.

“Are we going to skate in the Olympics?” She took a deep breath, opened her eyes and stared at him.

“*Da*, is plan.”

“You wouldn’t lie to me, would you?”

An evasion wasn’t a lie, was it? But he didn’t understand what she was getting at. He had always planned to skate in the Olympics. Most of his life success on the ice had been his only goal. Now he wanted fire, too, but the Olympics and Worlds were still extremely important. “*Niet*. Eat.”

She took a bite and a hasty swallow of her pop. “It’s all so confusing, isn’t it?”

What was she talking about now? He wrapped an arm around her shoulders, pulling her nearer. It confused him that she still wanted it clear that their marriage would end when their goal was achieved. He didn’t want to think about it. “What?”

“Our marriage of convenience.”

When had it ever been anything but inconvenient? “Is not convenience now.”

She put her head on his shoulder. If they could just stay like this forever.

“Alexei told me that you always planned to marry after you were done competing.”

“*Da.*” That had been his plan. “You have plans for future before marry me?”

She shook her head. “I never really thought much about my future beyond skating. I figured it would just take care of itself. You know that sooner or later I’d be living like my parents.”

He smiled. Did she ever think ahead? A thought wiped away his amusement. Yes, she thought ahead to their eventual divorce. And a marriage to him would not be like her parents’ marriage. Not with his home in Russia. Not with his mother living half a world away.

“I guess our marriage doesn’t really change your plans any then, does it?”

“*Niet!*” It changed everything. He clutched her shoulder tighter. *Niet, niet*, he did not want to contemplate another marriage. He wanted her as his wife. Even if they weren’t skating together, he wanted her to stay his wife. All this talk of pregnancy had him wanting to fill her with his child, to make them forever tied by family bonds.

She set her can down on the grass in front of her, and turned slightly toward him. “I don’t want to hurt you, and I didn’t want to get hurt.”

Pain seared through him. If she had no plans for her future, why was she so opposed to having one with him? “Is too late.”

She tilted her head back and blinked. “I know, and I want you to know that I will always hope you are happy.”

He would always be unhappy without her, but at the same time he thought of her impatience with him at the hot dog stand, and all the other times she had been embarrassed by his foreignness, his stumbling with her language, his choice of an apartment. Just living alone seemed luxurious by Moscow standards. But she was not Russian, not even close. “I would you be happy, also. I would wish not talk of end of marriage.”

He didn’t even want to think about it. He would hurt her then he knew, because when it came time, he would let her know that he didn’t want to end the marriage. He still had three years to convince her to change her mind. He took her free hand and placed it on top of his. He twisted the

simple gold band on her ring finger. Maybe if he bought her an engagement ring she would understand.

She might understand if he told her that he loved her, but if she pitied him, instead of returning the emotion, three years could seem an eternity.

“Eat,” he said softly.

She nodded, and slowly worked her way through the hot dog. She seemed dismayed when she tilted her pop can up after the last bite and she quickly lowered it, and shook it as if that would make more magically appear. He handed her his.

“He didn’t have grape,” she said, handing it back to him apologetically.

“I not hear what he say. You talk when he talk. I drink Coke, okay.”

“Well, yeah. I haven’t seen you drool or slobber or anything yet.”

He stared at her wondering what she was talking about now.

She gave him a tenuous smile. “I’m just teasing you. You can drink without spilling, *da?*”

“*Da*, I have many skills, my wife, but must practice.” He leaned her back and followed finding her lips with his. He laced her fingers of her left hand with his right and squeezed. He rained gentle kisses across her lips, over her cheeks, across her brow, and over salty tasting eyelids. He drew back and kissed the end of her cute little nose.

He drew back and waited until she opened her eyes. She looked at him with that soft glow that made him go hard on the outside and melted him on the inside. He touched his lips to her and kissed her more urgently. He shifted wanting to put his entire body over hers, wanting to feel her underneath him. Wanting to be home in bed with her. He moved to whisper in her ear that he wanted to take her home, but the words that came out were different.

She pulled back and looked at him. “What are you saying to me?”

He realized he’d spoken in Russian.

“I wish I understood you better.”

He was glad she didn’t. He’d just told himself there was no point in telling her he loved her if she didn’t understand the words in Russian. He leaned down and kissed the bare skin of her shoulder. “I say, I wish go home.”

He realized he’d just lied to her again.

She put her hands on either side of his face and positioned him where she could see. “Your eyes get so dark, Nikolai.”

Better than his nose growing long. She strained up and kissed that appendage, and then made a face, turned her head and coughed.

"There you guys are," said Vera.

Alexei stood behind her. "We go to Casino to eat. Will you go with us?"

Nikolai pulled his coughing wife to a sitting position.

"Sorry, you tasted like sunscreen. Sure, Alexei, we'll go. Is it really a casino?"

Vera reached down and grabbed Brandi's hand, before Nikolai could protest. "The brochure says it used to be." Vera handed Brandi a slick paper folded in thirds. "Can't let him get off the hook this easy," she said with a conspiratorial wink at his wife.

He wanted to protest. He hadn't done anything wrong, she had. And he was being punished for it. And there was no way he could get up and go anywhere for a while anyway.

Alexei sat down beside where he lay in the grass and sighed. "Women, but I think Vera is having a good time."

Nikolai sure as hell hoped so, because there was no way he would after having declared his love for Brandi and getting no reaction. Of course she didn't know that he had declared his love for her, and he had lied to her rather than risk the word in a language she understood.

"How long you watch?"

"Long enough for the rest to go ahead, but Vera insisted we had to tell you where we are going."

"Why does she think I did something wrong?"

Alexei shrugged. "Who knows how a woman's mind works?"

Well up until now, Nikolai didn't think he had that bad of an understanding. But maybe he didn't understand Brandi because she was an American woman.

"Maybe it's just that Vera's jealous because her husband is so far away," said Alexei leaning back in the grass and putting his hands behind his head.

"Maybe I jealous of Vera."

"Don't even think about it," warned Alexei. "You already let her get confused about why you marry her. Baby would make her wonder why you are with her even more."

If it was so obvious to his friend, why did Brandi miss it? Of course Alexei and Vera had known him since he was a child.

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"I think I ate too many hot dogs," Brandi said, flopping down on the couch. "My boss was ticked off too."

"What this mean?" asked Nikolai, concerned about his wife.

She looked pale with bright spots of color on her cheeks. Maybe she had too much sun earlier. She'd made him slather that sticky goo all over his exposed skin again before they'd gone off to join the others for lunch, but she ducked away from applying it to her own skin or letting him do it.

"He was mad. I was late again. Ticked off means mad. I made a stupid mistake ringing someone up, too." She coughed and rubbed her forehead.

"Brandi, are okay?"

"I feel a little queasy. I think it's just that I shouldn't have had two hot dogs. I was just hungry."

More like one and two bites. But at least she had enjoyed the rest of the outing. She and Vera had sat side-by-side and giggled over something, before they had to leave so she could go to work. "Should have eaten breakfast. Would like a cup of tea?"

She dropped her hand and looked at him with glassy eyes. She was sick. He walked over across the room and put his hand against her forehead.

"I'm not sick," she protested, ducking away from his hand.

"Just hot?" he said, scooping her up in his arms. She wasn't so hot he was worried, but she was hot enough he was sure she was ill.

"I never get sick."

"*Da*, is just much sun," he said, carrying her to the bedroom.

"Why do I get the feeling you are just humoring me?"

"I no tell joke. English too bad."

She looked at him sharply as he pulled back the new bedspread and set her down. "I think you know what I mean."

"I think you look good in bed," he said, pulling off her shoes. He turned around and pulled a tee shirt for her out of their shared dresser. He returned and asked her if she wanted help undressing.

"Of course not. What are you doing? I can't go to bed now. It's only seven o'clock."

"Are sleepy, *da*?"

"A little," she said reluctantly.

"I like undress you."

She looked at him, a hint of heat in her glazed brown eyes.

“Would like?” he asked teasingly.

She stood up. “This is silly. We should find an open session and skate this evening.”

“No. Work English. I read to you from book. Put on sleep clothes. I fix tea, get book.”

He brought back not only two cups of hot tea, but a plate with toast balanced on top of one of the cups. He had a worn paperback book tucked under his arm. He arranged everything on the nightstand, putting the alarm clock on the floor to make room. He kicked off his shoes and climbed onto the bed, sitting and leaning back against the wall beside her. He gave her both the pillows and settled her beside him. He rested his hand on her side, and opened the book.

“You really think I’m sick, don’t you?” she said.

“I wish spend lazy evening in bed with my wife,” he stroked his hand over her hip. “You to be cozy, or I go get cognac.”

“I’m going to take a mega dose of vitamin C,” she said kicking back the covers.

“Lay down. I get.”

She rolled her eyes. “You know, you’re getting awful bossy.”

“*Da*, I must like be slave. I tell you stay, so I take care of you.”

“I’m not sick,” she said.

“Too hard head to be sick,” he muttered.

“I heard that.”

“I not want you hear, I say Russian.”

“Well, that won’t work forever. I’m learning. You might as well get me the zinc too. If I am getting a cold, I’ll just kick it by sucking on one of those.”

She was cranky when she was sick, but Nikolai smiled as he found the stash of vitamins in the kitchen cabinet. Like most athletes she was well stocked. He brought back several of the brown bottles. She had her eyes closed and a hand pressed against her forehead.

“We can’t afford to miss any practices. I can’t believe I could get sick in the middle of summer,” she said.

“Are sick now?” he asked, shaking a vitamin C tablet into his hand.

“Not if I can help it. Give me three of those, please.”

“Would like to be alone?” he asked, stroking her hair as she swallowed a sip of her tea to wash down the tablets.

“No, go ahead and read.”

He settled back beside her, opened the book and began.

“I can’t believe you picked Tolstoy to read in English,” she interrupted.

“He is great writer,” Nikolai shifted uncomfortably.

“*Da*. Haven’t you read the original in Russian?”

“To know story help understand English.”

“Read on. This ought to be interesting. But the next book has to be by an American author.”

“You have plan to be sick much?” he asked lightly. She stilled under his hand.

“I never plan on being sick,” she answered stiffly. “I’m not usually prone to colds and the flu.”

“I not upset you sick, Brandoosha,” he said. Did she think he was blaming her? “I no like work so much we not have time to be together.” He didn’t like the way she ran herself ragged with always being on the go.

“We’re together all the time. We skate. We spent all this morning together.”

“Alone,” he said, before she went much further. He held his breath waiting to see how she would respond. She didn’t. He let out his breath and began the book again.

She was quiet beside him, only reading words he pointed to and asked her how to pronounce. He didn’t know if she was quiet because of her illness, or because she was unsure how to respond to his desire to spend more time alone with her. He had three years to convince her that this marriage could work. He was content to do it in small doses. Until she learned Russian words of love he could move slowly, make her learn to love him. He started wondering if he erred in picking a Russian novel to read. He should have asked the clerk in the dusty used bookstore to point him to an American novel.

He stroked his hand over his sleeping wife’s back. Would he ever be American enough to please his wife? He closed his eyes, knocking his head against the wall.

Chapter Fourteen

Brandi insisted on following her normal routine all week. Nikolai kept frowning at her every time she coughed, and she knew she was sloppy skating, but she wasn't about to let a summer cold get in her way. She sucked on zinc tablets religiously until she felt like she was toting around metal in her mouth. The worst part was she didn't have any time to make love with Nikolai. She was willing to sacrifice sleep at night, but he wouldn't let her.

Her boss wanted her to work closing the next couple of nights. She was damn near working forty hours a week. She hadn't intended to work so much, but one of the other employees quit, and it was just temporary. She needed the money.

She and Nikolai needed to pick out costumes, and they could run close to a thousand dollars for each of them. Nikolai had money from sponsors, but Brandi was worried that because part of that money came in when he was paired with Tatiana, that they wouldn't be able to keep all of it, or the sources would dry up. He kept telling her not to worry.

She finished stocking and clocked out. She stared out the plate glass window at the street, waiting for Nikolai to pick her up. She was looking forward to the late night choreography session. For the first time in days she felt fine.

Her cold must have finally succumbed to the cutting edge of zinc, or her cold had finally been conquered by the soup and sleep Nikolai insisted on this afternoon after practice and before work. He had been incredibly coddling, insisting on reading to her as she rested, lulling her into napping. He made her want to curl up at home in their apartment and stay there forever.

She smiled to herself. He was the kind of man who would make a great father, eventually when the time was right.

She frowned. Where had that thought come from? The time wasn't anywhere close to being right. But for the first time in her life she was thinking about a future that didn't necessarily revolve around ice skating. When had that happened? Of course it would still be there. Both she and Nikolai loved skating. It would be a part of their life no matter what, but when had she stopped thinking it would be the only thing she had to look forward to?

What difference did it make? She and Nikolai only had ice dancing. The rest was a sham, a false hope and dream. Every time she mentioned the marriage ending he clammed up. Obviously, he didn't want to change the terms of their agreement. Just because they had made love once didn't change anything. He hadn't claimed to love her. She hadn't told him that she loved him, and she couldn't. She didn't want him to feel trapped into a bargain he'd made with no intention of making it a permanent arrangement.

She especially was afraid, since she didn't know what he and Tatiana had discussed that day at Belle Isle. She was afraid to ask again. Afraid the answer would cut short the dream. She wanted every moment she could get with Nikolai. She wondered if he delayed telling because he was comfortable with their arrangement for now.

She believed Nikolai when he said nothing had changed, but then she wondered if there was a certain level they had to attain this season for him to continue with her. It wasn't so much that he made her suspect this, but that Tatiana had rejoined the training sessions with Alexei, and just seemed utterly too nice to both of them. As if she knew that all would be well next year, and she would have Nikolai back as a partner.

If there was some secret agenda she was determined to meet it. She refused to lose Nikolai because her skating level wasn't as high as Tatiana's. She skated her heart out every time they hit the ice. She skated for him, to stay with him, to keep him, and most of all to give him his dreams.

Her boss walked in from the back office where he had been going over the books. "Do you want to come back and help me?"

"I already clocked out. I'm just waiting for Nikolai."

"Why are you skating with a Russian?" asked her boss Roger as if the question had been bothering him for some time, and he hadn't felt comfortable asking.

"Because he's good." Because she couldn't imagine skating with anyone else now, not even Kevin.

"You're done early. He probably won't be here for another half an hour."

Brandi frowned as she looked at the clock. It was early, but Nikolai often waited for her outside after closing. "Maybe, I should call him."

"No don't. I want to make a suggestion. I've been thinking about giving you more money for your skating."

“You have?” Brandi spun around her toes coming off the ground. “That would be great. We could really use all the help we can get.” Maybe it would get Nikolai off her back, about working.

“Come back to the office, and we’ll discuss it.”

Brandi crossed the darkened store. She didn’t even anticipate a problem when she entered the cramped office lit only by a small green banker’s lamp. She sank down in one of the two folding chairs in front of the desk. Her boss, instead of crossing to sit behind his metal desk, came up behind her and put his hands on her shoulders. His stomach brushed against her back as the whole scene suddenly seemed sordid.

“I think I’ve misunderstood your offer,” she said, leaning forward away from his touch. “I’m going to go see if my husband is here.”

“Don’t get excited. No harm done,” said her boss in a voice that was probably meant to be placating.

“No, of course not.” She darted out of the chair.

“We won’t discuss this any more,” said her boss.

Brandi tugged the strap of her purse across her breasts. She just wanted to get out of there. “No harm done.” She sidled toward the door.

“My offer is open if you change your mind,” he said, his eyes boring into hers, but he had stepped back away from her.

She didn’t bother to answer as she fled out of the office and out of the building. She paced in the dark parking lot, wondering if she should knock and ask to be let back inside so she could call Nikolai.

He drove up then, and she wished she’d had more time to get her composure back. He was halfway out of the car before she reached for the door handle on the passenger side.

“What wrong?” he asked.

“Nothing. Let’s just go.”

He turned off the car.

“Nikolai, I don’t want to stay here. We need to get to the rink.”

“Have much time. What happen?” He reached out and stroked her arm.

“Nothing. Can we go?”

He cast her a skeptical look, and started the car again. He drove, not to the rink, but to their apartment.

“What are we doing?”

“Playing hooky.”

“We need to skate.”

“Need talk worse. You tell me what happened make you upset, Brandi.”

“It was nothing,” she said.

He climbed out of the car and walked up to their apartment. She followed him, not knowing what else to do.

“I call Yuri and cancel practice,” he said once they were inside. He pulled his phone from his back pocket.

What was it with all the domineering roles the men in her life seemed inclined to take lately? She stalked into the bedroom after him. “Don’t you dare. My boss made an offer to give us more sponsorship money.”

Nikolai paused and turned around. He lowered the phone. “Why upset?”

“There were strings attached. So I said no. You happy? Let’s go.” She folded her arms across her chest.

“Brandi, must quit job,” he said, scowling at her.

She hadn’t made that decision yet. Certainly it was a possible solution, but she didn’t want to forgo the money. And other than tonight she had grown comfortable. There were still advantages to working there, it was close to home, her boss said he’d have no problem letting her off when she had a competition. And, damn it, quitting was *her* decision, not his.

“You not go back.” He stepped closer to her.

“It’s not your decision.”

“Brandi, boss want you to...” he let the sentence dangle, his blue eyes radiating concern.

“Yes, but he took no for an answer. It’s no big deal. He said he wouldn’t mention it again.”

Nikolai crossed the room and took her shoulders in his hands. His brow lowered and his jaw ticked. “You are my wife. You never go back.”

She broke away. “I need the money.”

“*Niet, niet!*”

“Oh boy, here we go,” she said, rolling her eyes. “I told you what happened. Now let’s go.” She turned to leave their bedroom.

“We go, when you say you stop work.” He stepped in front of her, blocking the bedroom door.

“I shouldn’t have told you. I should have refused like you refuse to tell me things.”

He put his hands up in the air. “What things? I not refuse to tell you things.”

“Yes you do. You refused to tell me what you and Tatiana talked about at the aquarium.”

“Not refuse!”

“You did too. I asked you what you talked about, and you said no you wouldn’t tell me it was private.”

“*Niet.*”

“Yeah, that’s what you said.”

He looked puzzled. Then he shook his head and marched toward her. “*Niet*, have nothing to do with this. You quit job.”

He was still refusing to tell her. Her heart sunk to her toes. What if he really had made plans to return to a partnership with Tatiana? “No. It’s my decision.”

“Is too much for you. Work too much. Not sleep enough. We find other money.” He reached out for her again, but she leaned away. He crossed his arms across his chest.

“You find money your way. I’ll get money my way,” she said angrily.

“You quit that job. I not have my wife work with man who upset you.”

“You don’t have the right to tell me what to do. You don’t have the right to control my life. You aren’t a real husband.”

How had that slipped out? She’d meant to say that her boss couldn’t continue making these kind of offers or it would become sexual harassment, and she could file a lawsuit. She wasn’t really frightened of him. Maybe she would just refuse to work after the store closed.

“Am skate partner. Must make good decisions for to skate. I look out for you best interest even if you no wish me to stay husband after become citizen,” he said quietly. His blue eyes glittered with an intensity she was having a hard time understanding.

“I think you are a little confused about who wants what,” she said, suddenly feeling defeated. She dropped her eyes down. Didn’t he realize she wanted him to stay her husband? Didn’t he realize that she loved him? “Can we go to the rink now?”

“*Niet*,” He touched her temple, gently pushing her hair back. “I want you, Brandi.”

It seemed like an eternity since the first and only time they made love. His touch made her quiver. She put her hand against his chest, feeling his broad strength, the warmth of his skin seeping through his shirt.

“Okay,” she whispered, tilting her head up to look at him. She hoped he understood the flash of heat, burning through her resistance.

He raised his other hand to the other side of her face. He leaned toward her, and she met him halfway there. His kiss swirled under and around her disappointment and her fears. She moaned softly as she opened for him. He drew her against him.

She threaded her fingers through his dark hair.

“I want you, Brandoosha,” he whispered.

“I’ve missed you,” she answered brokenly. It was a silly thing to say, since they were together every day. But she knew his smile against her lips meant he understood. His kisses and caresses continued as she leaned into him. His hands swept down, pulling her against him.

“*Da*, I miss us time, Brandoosha.”

Heat swirled under her skin in a torrid rush. She stretched up on her tiptoes, trying to equalize the difference in their heights. She wanted against him. His hands swept over her breasts, his thumbs skimming across the crests. Fiery sparks shot out from his touch. She moaned, pushing into him.

He lifted her up, and she wrapped her legs around his narrow hips. She dropped her hands down his back, feeling his smooth body. She tugged his shirt free from his waistband reaching underneath. His mouth broke from hers only long enough to let her remove his long-sleeved tee shirt. He carried her through the door. She wanted to protest he was carrying her the wrong way, but when he lowered her to the floor in front of the bathroom door, she understood.

“Hurry,” he whispered, pushing her into the little room.

He was in bed when she returned. His clothes littered the floor. He held out his arms, and she flew into them. She traced her fingers down his naked length, and felt his shudder. He pulled her down on top of him, his mouth seeking hers. His hands worked their magic over her skin as he gently removed her clothes. Desire washed away the remnants of anger.

She rubbed against him relishing the double friction of his hot skin against her flushed skin. His palm slid down her back, his fingers curling in as he encountered curves. He pulled her over him, so he could tease her taunt nipples with his tongue. Brandi grew impatient. She wanted him with a need that raged inside her. She slid down to drop kisses on his chest, running her tongue over his flat male nipples. She reached down to find his hardness. His groan answered the coiling emptiness of her body. She held

him against her warm wet center and sank down on him, relishing the slow joining of their flesh.

He jerked upward, his mouth finding hers. His arms banded around her, holding her still, as she felt the throbbing fullness and stretching, the relief of being filled with him. But the need fisted in her, she sobbed against his mouth. She rocked against him, catching his stiff intake of breath.

Nikolai fought back the sensations that threatened to overwhelm him. He skimmed his hands down his wife's hips, encouraging her as she rocked against him. He was so hungry for her, he fought to keep his touch gentle. Her petite body was so urgent, so hot and tight on his. The tension building inside her dragged him along no matter how he fought to go slow. He ran his hands over her flushed skin. It had been an eternity since he was inside her like this. His breathing was ragged. He broke his mouth away from hers. He had to tell her. There was no avoiding the words.

"Brandi, my *zhena*, I love you."

Her hand clenched in his hair. "Oh God, Nikolai." She pulled her head back from his.

He wanted to hide his face in her neck. Her nose wrinkled and her eyes closed and then popped open to gaze deep in his. Her brown eyes shined with a soft wonder. "I love you, too," she said, touching his cheek tenderly.

She brushed her lips across his, and he felt the flood of heat that broke through her body and released the tide in his own body. His love for her kept him from drowning in the powerful rip tide of emotion.

~~*

As he drifted in the hazy aftermath he stroked her damp body. He dropped spent kisses on her neck and shoulders, wherever he could reach. He loved the way her body laid across his, limp as a rag doll.

He whispered in Russian.

"Teach me how to say 'I love you' in Russian," she said, popping her head up.

"I just say, Brandoosha. You no listen."

"I listened," she said quietly. Her brown eyes sought his. "Tell me again, so I can say it."

"We say in English."

"Don't be silly. We'll say it in both. One language isn't enough."

"I wish become American," said Nikolai stubbornly. If he were more optimistic like an American, he would believe that her love meant she

wanted to continue as his wife forever.

“But, sweetheart, that’s the wonderful thing about being an American. You’re free to be who you are. We respect and encourage differences. You can be as Russian as you want and still be an American.”

“You no like Russia.”

“I’d like to see for myself. Besides, I can learn to appreciate anything. I’ve learned to like our apartment. Of course, that may be just because you’re here. It’s not so bad with some color thrown in, but one of these days we’re going to have to paint. Maybe some new furniture. Course we’ll need a bigger place when we decide to have a baby.” She bit her lip and winced. She closed her eyes as if she’d said something she shouldn’t have. She dropped her head down to his shoulder.

Nikolai, was thrilled with what her rattling told him. He ran his hand over her feather-soft hair. He tilted her chin back so he could see her face as he spoke. “I love you. I want you stay wife always. I want marriage for to be real.”

“Okay,” she whispered. “I want that too.” Her voice shook a little, and he wondered if she ducked her head away because of the sheen of moisture in her eyes.

He frowned wondering why his wife seemed fearful, well beyond it was scary to admit to the depth of emotion, but he had gone first. He remembered her accusation of keeping secrets from her. “Brandi, I forget tell you what Tatiana say. I not mean not tell you. I mean private, I tell *you* in private.”

He could feel the tightness in the muscles of her shoulders as he rubbed his hands across her warm skin. She gave no other sign that she wanted to know.

“Tatiana not go home to Russia when gone. She go to hospital.”

Brandi popped up and looked at him. “Was she sick?”

“Is sick for long time. She go for...” He tapped the side of his head. “She have what call nerves breakdown.”

“Nervous breakdown. Because you wouldn’t go back to skating with her?”

“Is not my fault. She have...” He squeezed his eyes shut trying to come up with the right words, “chem...chem...” He gave up and waved his hand in the air. “Imbalance.”

“Chemical imbalance?”

“*Da*. Is need medicine to make normal. Doctor say to her I keep her function long time, but much better with medicine.”

“But can she take the medicine and be okay with the drug screens?”

“*Niet*, but no matter for professional. Is make her decision to skate with Alexei easy. She say she like new person. She thank me for be strong, but wish she could learn problem sooner.”

“Oh, Nikolai, I thought you were planning to go back to skating with her.”

“*Niet*, why? You are better skater. Tatiana say so. She just good for tricks. Judges mark higher for good skate.”

“That’s not true. Tatiana is one of the best skaters I’ve ever seen.”

“Brandi, you are better fit for me. Is feel right. We will have gold. I feel it.”

“And I thought you weren’t an optimist.”

“Now would quit job?” he asked, his voice lightly teasing. “If not, I become annoying customer. Never leave.”

She popped up. “Oh no. We’re supposed to be skating.”

“*Da*. This much better,” he said, tugging her back against him.

His phone rang.

“You didn’t call Yuri.” She pushed up onto her arms.

He settled for looking up at the view, since she wouldn’t stay down. “I forget. I forget much today. I forget skate bags before come to get you.”

The phone rang again, and Nikolai ignored it. He should have remembered to call Yuri, but once he started thinking about Brandi, everything else went away.

“You mean you didn’t bring me here to browbeat me into quitting?” she asked.

“*Niet*. You not sick any more,” he said, stroking a finger down the curve of her breast.

Brandi grabbed the phone as it rang again. She shoved his hand away, giving him a dirty look. “Sorry, we overslept. We’ll be there in half an hour.”

“*Niet*,” he said, rolling her to her back. “We stay here, and I torture you until quit job.”

She dropped the phone onto the bed when she grabbed his shoulders as he put her on the bottom. “If this is torture. I am never quitting,” she said, her brown eyes deep with love.

“We be there in fifteen minutes,” said Nikolai, into the phone. Then he turned it off.

“What’s he going to think when we don’t show up?”

“That I am very happy husband,” answered Nikolai, and he was. “He probably think you as my wife damn inconvenient.”

“Why inconvenient?”

“If we just lovers, we make much effort to hide us time. I give up ice time for us time. Maybe get bronze, no gold”

“Oh great, now you’re making me choose between working and skating.”

“Is you choice. I never go without us time again. Alexei warn fire might melt ice.” He stroked his hand over her satiny skin. “I want you most.”

Her eyes were bright, as if she realized that he was willing to risk their Olympic dream with less practice time just to be with her. He would choose fire over ice.

“Fine, you win, I’ll quit,” her voice wavered, while she laid a palm against his cheek.

“We win.”

Her phone rang.

Nikolai picked it up. “What?”

He smiled, and answered in Russian. He watched his beautiful wife as he replaced the phone.

“What did you say?” asked Brandi.

“Yuri say save some passion for ice.”

“You told him not to worry, right? Plenty more where this came from.”

“*Da.*”

“We really should go skate. I want both you and gold.”

“*Niet.*”

“Oh, here we go again. And here I thought I detected a little bit of optimism in you.”

“*Niet*, is too long apart. Stay in my arms tonight.”

“It wasn’t me that was afraid of getting sick,” she protested.

“*Niet*, not afraid of getting sick. Afraid of steal my wife’s sleep.”

She pushed at him. “You know that I would be in your arms skating.”

He was afraid he wasn’t going to win this argument. He groaned. “Why I have wife like ice more than fire?”

“You don’t, but we’re still going skating,” she said. She scrambled out of the bed. She pulled open her drawer and drew out a skating outfit.

He leaned up on an elbow to watch.

“You know that ice is awful cold if you’re naked when you hit it.”

“I not go.”

“If you get out of that bed, I promise we’ll build a fire when we get back.”

Okay that was enough incentive for him.

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